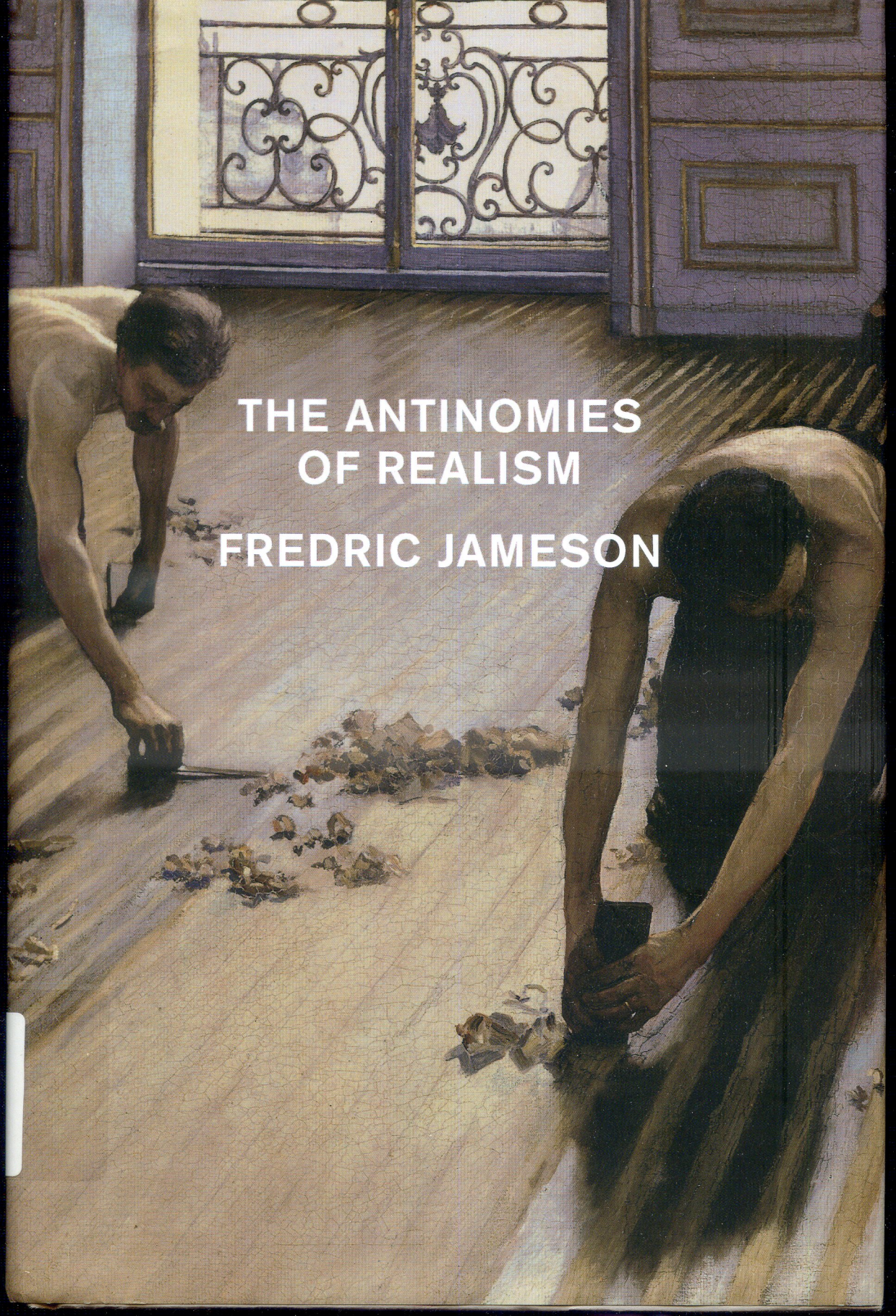


THE ANTINOMIES OF REALISM

FREDRIC JAMESON

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The Antinomies of Realism is a history of the nineteenth-century realist novel and its legacy told without a glimmer of nostalgia for artistic achievements that the movement of history makes it impossible to recreate. The works of Zola, Tolstoy, Pérez Galdós, and George Eliot are in the most profound sense inimitable, yet continue to dominate the novel form to this day. Novels to emerge since struggle to reconcile the social conditions of their own creation with the history of this mode of writing: the so-called modernist novel is one attempted solution to this conflict, as is the ever-more impoverished variety of commercial narratives—what today's book reviewers dub "serious novels," which are an attempt at the impossible endeavor to roll back the past.

Fredric Jameson examines the most influential theories of artistic and literary realism, approaching the subject himself in terms of the social and historical preconditions for realism's emergence. The realist novel combined an attention to the body and its states of feeling with a focus on the quest for individual realization within the confines of history.

In contemporary writing, other forms of representation—for which the term "postmodern" is too glib—have become visible: for example, in the historical fiction of Hilary Mantel or the stylistic plurality of David Mitchell's novels. Contemporary fiction is shown to be conducting startling experiments in the representation of new realities of a global social totality, modern technological warfare, and historical developments that, although they saturate every corner of our lives, only become apparent on rare occasions and by way of the strangest formal and artistic devices.

In a coda, Jameson explains how "realistic" narratives survived the end of classical realism. In effect, he provides an argument for the serious study of popular fiction and mass culture that transcends lazy journalism and the easy platitudes of recent cultural studies.

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For Kim Stanley Robinson

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Introduction: Realism and its Antinomies

I have observed a curious development which always seems to set in when we attempt to hold the phenomenon of realism firmly in our mind's eye. It is as though the object of our meditation began to wobble, and the attention to it to slip insensibly away from it in two opposite directions, so that at length we find we are thinking, not about realism, but about its emergence; not about the thing itself, but about its dissolution. Much great work, indeed, has been done on these lateral topics: on the former, for example, Ian Watt's canonical *Rise of the Novel* and Michael McKeon's monumental *Origins of the Novel*; and on the latter, any number of those collections entitled "problems of realism" (in which Lukács deplored the degeneration of realistic practice into naturalism, symbolism and modernism), or "towards a new novel" (in which Robbe-Grillet argued the unsuitability of Balzacian techniques for capturing our current realities). I will later explain how these slippages determined the form of the theory about to be presented.

First, however, we must enumerate a number of other possibilities which are not explored here (but which this particular theoretical exercise is by no means intended to exclude). Thus, the most ancient literary category of all—mimesis—still inspires work and thought, enshrined as anthropology and psychology in the Frankfurt School's idiosyncratic notion of the mimetic impulse; and provocatively worked out, following Lenin's reflection theory (*Widerspiegelung*), by scholars like Robert Weimann.[1] (Auerbach's use of the term, not exactly classical, will be mentioned below). Aristotle did not, of course, know that form we call the novel, a product of Hegel's "world

[1] Robert Weimann, "Mimesis in Hamlet," in Geoffrey Hartman and Patricia Parker, eds., *Shakespeare and the Question of Theory*, New York: Routledge, 1985; and see also Dieter Schlenstedt, ed., *Literarische Widerspiegelung*, Berlin: Aufbau, 1981.

of prose"; nor are we taking theatrical practice into account in the present book (so much the worse for it!); and indeed, my suspicion is that later discussions of this term tend to be contaminated by those of the visual arts, and to be influenced either in the direction of representationality or abstraction (in painting) or that of Hollywood or the experimental in film.

This is the moment at which to assert the inevitability, in the realism debate, of what has just been illustrated by the turn to visuality, namely the inescapable operative value, in any discussion of realism, of this or that binary opposition in terms of which it has been defined. It is this, above all, which makes any definitive resolution of the matter impossible: for one thing, binary opposites make unavoidable the taking of sides (unless, as with Arnold Hauser, or in a different way, Worringer, one sees it as some eternal cyclical alternation[2]). Realism, for or against: but as opposed to what? At this point the list becomes at least relatively interminable: realism vs. romance, realism vs. epic, realism vs. melodrama, realism vs. idealism,[3] realism vs. naturalism, (bourgeois or critical) realism vs. socialist realism, realism vs. the oriental tale,[4] and of course, most frequently rehearsed of all, realism vs. modernism. As is inevitably the case with such a play of opposites, each of them becomes inevitably invested with political and even metaphysical significance, as, with film criticism, in the now somewhat antiquated opposition between Hollywood "realism" and formal subversions such as those associated with the *nouvelle vague* and Godard.[5] Most of these binary pairs will therefore arouse a passionate taking of sides, in which realism is either denounced or elevated to the status of an ideal (aesthetic or otherwise).

The definition of realism by way of such oppositions can also take on a historical, or periodizing, character. Indeed, the opposition between realism and modernism already implies a historical narrative which it is fairly difficult to reduce to a structural or stylistic one; but

[2] I refer to Arnold Hauser's *Social History of Art* (1954) as well as Wilhelm Worringer's influential and rather cosmological oppositions in *Abstraction and Empathy* (1907).

[3] The provocative concept of an idealist novel was developed by Naomi Schor in her study of George Sand and elaborated by Jane Tomkins in her work on the American western, where it also involved Christian religious and familial traditions (which the traditional western functioned to undermine).

[4] See Srinivas Aravamudan, *Enlightenment Orientalism*, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2012.

[5] And with *Screen* magazine in its heyday in the 1960s and '70s.

which it is also difficult to control, since it tends to generate other periods beyond its limits, one of postmodernity, for example, if some putative end of the modern is itself posited; or of some preliminary stage of Enlightenment and secularization invoked to precede the period of realism as such, in a logic of periodization bound to lead on into the positioning of a classical system or a pre-capitalist system of fixed modes and genres, and so forth. Whether such a focus on periodization necessarily leads out of literary history into cultural history in general (and beyond that to the history of modes of production) probably depends on how one situates capitalism itself and its specific cultural system in the sequence in question. The focus, in other words, tends to relativize realism as one mode among many others, unless, by the use of mediatory concepts such as that of modernity, one places capitalism uniquely at the center of human history.

For at this point another combination comes into play, and that is the tendency to identify realism with the novel itself as a uniquely modern form (but not necessarily a "modernist" one). Discussions of either concept tend to become indistinguishable from the other, at least when the history of either is invoked: the history of the novel is inevitably the history of the realist novel, against which or underneath which all the aberrant modes, such as the fantastic novel or the episodic novel, are subsumed without much protest. But by the same token, chronology is itself equally subsumed, and a Bakhtin can argue that "novel-ness" is itself a sign, perhaps the fundamental sign and symptom, of a "modernity" that can be found in the Alexandrian world fully as much as in the Ming dynasty.[6]

Indeed, Bakhtin is himself among the major figures for whom the novel, or realism as such, is both a literary phenomenon and a symptom of the quality of social life. For Bakhtin, the novel is the vehicle of polyphony or the recognition and expression of a multiplicity of social voices: it is therefore modern in its democratic opening onto an ideologically multiple population. Auerbach also invokes democracy in an analogous sense, even though for him the opening is global and consists in the conquest and achievement of a "realist" social life or modernity around the world.[7] But for Auerbach "realism," or mimesis in his sense, is a syntactic conquest, the slow

[6] See, for example, his essay, "Epic and Novel," in Michael Holquist, ed., *The Dialogical Imagination*, Austin: University of Texas Press, 1994.

[7] Erich Auerbach, *Mimesis: The Representation of Reality in Western Literature*, Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1953, 552, "a common life of mankind on earth."

appropriation of syntactic forms capable of holding together multiple levels of a complex reality and a secular daily life, whose twin climaxes in the West he celebrates in Dante and in Zola.

Lukács is more ambivalent in his reading of the novel's formal and historical record: in the *Theory of the Novel*, the form is essentially distinguished by its capacity of registering problematization and the irreconcilable contradictions of a purely secular modernity. The latter becomes reidentified as capitalism, in the later Lukács, and the novel with realism, whose task is now the reawakening of the dynamics of history.[8]

But in all three apologists for the realist novel as a form (so to speak), it is never very clear whether that form simply registers the advanced state of a given society or plays a part in society's awareness of that advanced state and its potentialities (political and otherwise). This ambiguity (or hesitation) will characterize the evaluative approaches to realism I want to outline in this initial survey, and which grasp the problem in terms of form and content respectively.

Realism as a form (or mode) is historically associated, particularly if you position the *Quijote* as the first (modern, or realist) novel, with the function of demystification. It is a function which can take many forms, in this foundational instance the undermining of romance as a genre, along with the use of its idealizing values to foreground features of the social reality they cannot accommodate. I have mentioned a first period of modernity in which the tasks of enlightenment and in particular secularization were fundamental (in a kind of bourgeois cultural revolution): these are for realism essentially negative, critical or destructive tasks which will later on give way to the construction of bourgeois subjectivity: but as the construction of the subject is always an intervention supported by taboos and inner restrictions of all kinds (one model of which is Weber's "protestant ethic"), the eradication of inherited psychic structures and values will remain a function of realist narrative, whose force always comes from this painful cancellation of tenaciously held illusions. But later on, when the realistic novel begins to discover (or if you prefer, to construct) altogether new kinds of subjective experiences (from Dostoyevsky to Henry James), the negative social function begins to weaken, and demystification finds itself transformed into defamiliarization and the renewal of perception, a more modernist impulse, while the emotional tone of such texts tends towards resignation, renunciation or compromise, as both Lukács and Moretti have noted.

But the very ideology of realism also tends to stage it in terms of content, and here clearly the realist mode is closely associated with the bourgeoisie and the coming into being of bourgeois daily life: this, I would like to insist, is also very much a construction, and it is a construction in which realism and narrative participate. Sartre argued that mimesis is always at least tendentially critical: holding up a mirror to nature, in this case bourgeois society, never really shows people what they want to see, and is always to that degree demystifying.[9] Certainly the attacks on realism which have already been mentioned are based on the idea that the literature of realism has the ideological function of adapting its readers to bourgeois society as it currently exists, with its premium on comfort and inwardness, on individualism, on the acceptance of money as an ultimate reality (we might today speak of the acceptance of the market, of competition, of a certain image of human nature, and so forth). I myself argue elsewhere in this collection that the realistic novelist has a vested interest, an ontological stake, in the solidity of social reality, on the resistance of bourgeois society to history and to change.[10] Meanwhile, it could also be argued that in a stylistic and ideological sense, the consumerism of late capitalism is no longer a bourgeois society in that sense, and no longer knows the forms of daily life that emerged in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries: so that realism inevitably gives way to modernism insofar as its privileged content has become extinct. This argument thus makes a fundamental distinction between a bourgeois class culture and the economic dynamics of late capitalism.

I have outlined these multiple approaches to realism not only to make the point about its contextual variability as an object, but also to admit, finally, that I plan to do none of these things here. Realism, as I argued elsewhere, is a hybrid concept, in which an epistemological claim (for knowledge or truth) masquerades as an aesthetic ideal,

[8] The most succinct summary of Lukács' formal views is to be found in "Narrate or Describe?" in George Lukács, *Writer and Critic*, London: Merlin, 1970. We will see that this opposition is fundamental in explaining his (equally political) rejection of Zola's naturalism.

[9] Jean-Paul Sartre, "*What is Literature?" and Other Essays*, Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1988, 91: "The mirror which he modestly offers to his readers is magical: it enthralls and compromises."

[10] See "The Experiments of Time: Providence and Realism," in Part Two of this volume.

with fatal consequences for both of these incommensurable dimensions.[11] If it is social truth or knowledge we want from realism, we will soon find that what we get is ideology; if it is beauty or aesthetic satisfaction we are looking for, we will quickly find that we have to do with outdated styles or mere decoration (if not distraction). And if it is history we are looking for—either social history or the history of literary forms—then we are at once confronted with questions about the uses of the past and even the access to it which, as unanswerable as they may be, take us well beyond literature and theory and seem to demand an engagement with our own present.[12]

From a dialectical standpoint it is not hard to see why this is so. Both sociology and aesthetics are superannuated forms of thinking and inquiry, inasmuch as neither society nor what is called cultural or aesthetic experience are in this present of time stable substances that can be studied empirically and analyzed philosophically. History, meanwhile, if it is anything at all, is at one with the dialectic, and can only be the problem of which it claims to be the solution.

My experiment here claims to come at realism dialectically, not only by taking as its object of study the very antinomies themselves into which every constitution of this or that realism seems to resolve: but above all by grasping realism as a historical and even evolutionary process in which the negative and the positive are inextricably combined, and whose emergence and development at one and the same time constitute its own inevitable undoing, its own decay and dissolution. The stronger it gets, the weaker it gets; winner loses; its success is its failure. And this is meant, not in the spirit of the life cycle ("ripeness is all"), or of evolution or of entropy or historical rises and falls: it is to be grasped as a paradox and an anomaly, and the thinking of it as a contradiction or an aporia. Yet as Derrida observed, the aporia is not so much "an absence of path, a paralysis before roadblocks" so much as the promise of "the thinking of the path."[13] For me, however, aporetic thinking is precisely the dialectic itself; and the following exercise will therefore be for better or for worse a dialectical experiment.

But we need to have a better idea of what Deleuze might have called the image of the concept, the shape of some new dialectical solution, before continuing. Hegel's thoughts certainly had some distinctive shapes, but it is not a question of adopting any of those forms here and today; nor does the word "dialectical" give us much help except to revive antiquated formulas, many of which are not even historically accurate.

The unity of opposites, for example, will certainly characterize a situation in which what brings a phenomenon into being also gradually undermines and destroys it. But the content of these fundamental categories is not identifiable: what is negative and what is positive in the trajectory of realism (it being understood that the struggles over its ideological value are not yet even in play here)? Indeed, on any responsible reading of Hegel it will have been clear that what is positive in its own eyes is negative from the standpoint of its opposite number, and vice versa: so nothing much is gained here except the notion of unity—unity not as synthesis but rather as antagonism, the unity of attraction and repulsion, the unity of struggle.

What is also gained—but it may well simply have been some unconscious structuralist premise, smuggled in avant la lettre—is the sense that we still have to do here with a binary opposition. I have argued elsewhere that the play of oppositions we have grown accustomed to since structuralism is not some newfangled linguistic supplement, but already exists fully developed in Hegel's own time and work, who derives them from ancient philosophy.[14] But now what we need to do is not only to give some literary content to this abstract form, but also to demonstrate such an opposition at work within realism itself (and not externally, between realism and some other kind of discourse). Meanwhile, the superficial traits that come at first to mind—the new plain-language écriture versus the language of dialogue, for example—must not only be specific to realism itself but must also entertain some relationship to the seemingly more external question of realism's coming into being and going hence.

Taken all together in bulk, the heterogeneous materials that somehow end up coalescing into what we call the novel—or realism!—include

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[11] See Jameson, "The Existence of Italy," in *Signatures of the Visible*, New York: Routledge, 1992.

[12] It is not only the content of literature which is itself profoundly historical (and necessarily has its own shaping influence on the form), it is also the sensory medium itself; it is always instructive to recall Marx on the history of the senses (*Early Writings*, London: Penguin, 1975, 351–55).

[13] Jacques Derrida, *Memoires for Paul de Man*, New York: Columbia University Press, 1989, 132.

[14] See Michael N. Forster, *Hegel and Skepticism*, Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1989, 10–13, on "equipollence."

the following: ballads and broadsheets, newspaper sketches, memoirs, diaries and letters, the Renaissance tale, and even popular forms like the play or the folk- or fairy-tale. What is selected from such a mass of different types of writing is its narrative component (even when, as for Balzac or Dickens, that component is first offered as a seemingly static description of characteristic types or activities, of picturesque or costumbrista evocations). To put it this way is to isolate something like a narrative impulse which is also realized in the novel as a form, but perhaps does not exhaust the novel's energy sources.

What could then constitute the opposite of the narrative impulse as such? Taken thus abstractly and speculatively we could surely think of any number of non-narrative sentence types: judgements, for example, such as the moral a storyteller might want to add on at the end, or a bit of the folk wisdom with which George Eliot liked to regale her readers. But the most inveterate alternative to narrative as such reminds us that storytelling is a temporal art, and always seems to single out a painterly moment in which the onward drive of narrative is checked if not suspended altogether. The shield of Achilles!: this is the most famous instance of that suspension of narrative which still remained to be theorized as late as Lessing's *Laocoon* in the late eighteenth century. Will the ancient rhetorical trope of ekphrasis be sufficient to fold this descriptive impulse back into narrative homogeneity?

Everyone knows the patience one must bring to his novels as Balzac slowly sets in place his various components—description of the town, history of the profession, the loving enumeration of the parts of the house, inside and out, the family itself, the physiognomy of the protagonist and his or her favorite clothes, his or her favorite *emploi du temps*—in short, all those different types of discourse which as raw material were to have been fused back together in this new form, but which Balzac unapologetically requires us to plow through on our way to the story itself (which will eventually satisfy any taste for reckless momentum, suspense and action we may have had to hold in check during those opening pages).

But if all it accomplished was to lead us back to Lessing and the status of ekphrasis today, this search for the opposite of the narrative impulse will not have been very productive. Perhaps, indeed, the more satisfactory identification of narrative's opposite number is better sought at the other end of the history of the genre, namely at the moment of realism's dissolution, which we always seem to

call modernism, without feeling the need to rummage among the innumerable modernisms, not all of them reducible to a single denominator in the first place.

But this procedure, which assumes that by subtracting the modern from narrative we will be left with the essence of realism, assumes that some general definition of what modernism is (or was) is available, an optimistic assumption which generally results in a few stereotypical formulae (it is subjectivist—the inward turn; reflexive or conscious of its own procedures; formalistic in the sense of a heightened attention to its own raw materials; anti-narrative; and deeply imbued with a mystique of art itself). Roland Barthes took a wiser and more prudent position on the matter: "When it comes to the 'modern,' you can only carry out tactical-style operations: at certain times you feel it's necessary to intervene to signal some shift in the landscape or some new inflection in modernity."[15] But his own experience, to be sure, expressed the preoccupations of the post-war period, in which, in what I have called the "late modern," the effort to theorize and to name what had happened in the first half of the twentieth century became a dominant theoretical ambition.

There are also more paradoxical trajectories to be followed: as for example in film, where Tom Gunning has identified what in our present context might be described as a movement from modernism to realism. D. W. Griffith, who rightly or wrongly is traditionally credited with having invented the modern (fiction) film as we know it (relying indeed very heavily on literature and in particular on Dickens), began with atmospheric sketches (of a photographic nature) which it was his mission to develop into plots and narrativity as such.[16]

The example suggests that, whatever thematic clue we choose to follow in our identification of the opposite number to the narrative impulse, its theorization will ultimately involve that most paradoxical of philosophical problems, namely the conceptualization of time and temporality. In the world of art, it is a dilemma compounded by our limited vocabulary: for even the *récit* or tale, whose events are already over and done with before the telling of it can begin, is experienced by

[15] Quoted in Alain Robbe-Grillet, *Why I Love Barthes*, trans. Andrew Brown, London: Polity, 2011, 39. My own proposals on modernism can be found in *A Singular Modernity*, London: Verso, 2002.

[16] See Tom Gunning, *D.W. Griffith and the Origins of American Narrative Film*, Chicago: University of Illinois Press, 1991.

listener or reader (and above all, of course, by the viewer) as a present of time, but it is of course our present, the present of reading time, and not that of the events themselves.

So in what follows I will approach the question of realism from the angle of temporality; and I will suggest that the opposite number of that chronological temporality of the récit has somehow to do with a present; but with a different kind of presence than the one marked out by the tripartite temporal system of past-present-future, or even by that of the before and after. For all kinds of reasons, to be developed in the following pages, I will identify this present—or what Alexander Kluge calls the "insurrection of the present against the other temporalities"[17]—as the realm of affect.

As the rather crude misuse of this term will be explained later on, I might as well generalize our other impulse with equally decisive approximation and replace the very general word "narrative" with a far sharper and more limited *Fremdwort*, which is the French "récit," and which transforms narrative into the narrative situation itself and the telling of a tale as such.

This means that we now have in our grasp the two chronological end points of realism: its genealogy in storytelling and the tale, its future dissolution in the literary representation of affect. A new concept of realism is then made available when we grasp both these terminal points firmly at one and the same time.

A number of images come to mind for the shape of this thought: the electrical one of negative and positive currents is perhaps not the most reassuring one. But one can also imagine the strands of DNA winding tightly about each other, or a chemical process in which the introduction of a fresh reagent precipitates a combination which then slowly dissolves again as too much of the element in question is added. But it is the dialectical formulation which, taken as an image of thought rather than a philosophical proposition in its own right, still strikes me as the most suggestive: for in it positive force becomes negative (quantity changing into quality) without the determination of a threshold being required, and emergence and dissolution are thought together in the unity of a single thought, beyond all-too-human judgements that claim to separate the positive from the negative, the good from the bad. Still, what I will want to insist on

[17] The title of one of his books: *Der Angriff der Gegenwart gegen die übrige Zeit*, Frankfurt: Europaeische Verlagsanstalt, 1985.

in such images is the irrevocable antagonism between the twin (and entwined) forces in question: they are never reconciled, never fold back into one another in some ultimate reconciliation and identity; and the very force and pungency of the realist writing I here examine is predicated on that tension, which must remain an impossible one, under pain of losing itself altogether and dissipating if it is ever resolved in favor of one of the parties to the struggle.

What we call realism will thus come into being in the symbiosis of this pure form of storytelling with impulses of scenic elaboration, description and above all affective investment, which allow it to develop towards a scenic present which in reality, but secretly, abhors the other temporalities which constitute the force of the tale or récit in the first place.

The new scenic impulse will also detect its enemies in the hierarchy of characters who people the tale, which can scarcely be conceived without a protagonist. In particular, it will wage a ceaseless muffled battle against the structures of melodrama by which it is ceaselessly menaced; in the process also throwing off other genres such as the *Bildungsroman*, which for a while seemed so central to it as to define it. Its final battle will be raged in the microstructures of language and in particular against the dominance of point of view which seems to hold the affective impulses in check and lend them the organizing attribution of a central consciousness. Engaging this final battle will however exhaust and destroy it, and realism thereby leaves an odd assortment of random tools and techniques to its shrivelled posterity, who still carry its name on into an era of mass culture and rival media.

So Part One of the present text is by way of offering a phenomenological and structural model, an experiment which posits a unique historical situation without exploring the content of that situation, as so many indispensable studies of the various realisms have already done. Of the two chronological sequels to the moment of realism—modernism and postmodernism—only the latter outcome will be briefly sketched in conclusion. The essay that comprises Part One is followed by three monographs on the relationships of narrative possibility to its specific raw material. *The Antinomies of Realism* constitutes the third volume of the sequence called *The Poetics of Social Forms*.

April 2013

PART I

THE ANTINOMIES OF REALISM

Chapter 1

The Twin Sources of Realism: The Narrative Impulse

If there is anything distinctive to be discovered about realism, then, we will not find it without somehow distinguishing between realism and narrative in general, or without, at least, mapping some vague general zone of narrative which lies outside it (at the same time including it as well, since the realisms are presumably narratives themselves). Single-shot answers always seem possible: the fantastic, for example, or so-called primitive myth (the very word *mythos* means narrative); or in some narrower and more literary sense, the epic (insofar as we distinguish it from the novel), or the oral tale, insofar as we distinguish it from the written one.

This is not the solution I want to begin with here, for I am looking for a storytelling impulse that precedes the formation of the realist novel and yet persists within it, albeit transformed by a host of new connections and relationships. I will call the products of this impulse simply the tale, with the intent of emphasizing its structural versatility, its aptness for transformation and exploitation by the other forms just enumerated. The tale can thereby be pressed into service by epic performance fully as much as by tribal and mythic storytelling, by the Renaissance art-novella and its equivalents in the Romantic period, by the ballad, by sub-forms and subgenres like the ghost story or SF, indeed by the very forms and strictures of the short story itself, as a specific strict formal practice in its own right with its own history.

At the level of abstraction at which we are working, then, the tale becomes the generalized object of which narration is the generalized production process or activity, but this generic specification also becomes a convenient way of evading psychological or anthropological analysis of that activity, which would be a distraction in our present context.

Yet we may retain one feature from traditional or modern

psychological theories of the faculties and/or functions, in which narrativity might be opposed to cognition for example, or emotion to reason; and that is the requirement that the storytelling function, if we want to call it that, must form part of an opposition, must be defined against something else: otherwise the potentiality we are trying to circumscribe risks extending over the entire field of mental activity, everything becoming narrative, everything becoming a kind of story.[1]

So it is that in an influential pronouncement of the 1920s, Ramon Fernandez developed an opposition between the tale and the novel—or rather, to use the more precise and only imperfectly translatable French terms, between the récit and the *roman*.[2] It was a distinction that proved useful for several generations of French writers from Gide to Sartre; and that will remain helpful for us here, particularly since the same general opposition has taken somewhat different forms in other national traditions.

In effect, Fernandez organized his distinction around two distinct genres, which may be taken as markers for either historical developments or structural variations. Translators have tried to render "récit" in English with its cognate, the recital, which is suggestive only to the degree to which someone might recite an account or even a chronicle of events. But even the word "tale," which I prefer here, bears a weight of generic connotation, and can easily crystallize back into historical forms such as the Renaissance novella or the Romantic art-story.

This is the sense in which the active content of Fernandez' theory lies in the opposition itself and the differentiation it generates. For in itself, the term "novel" is even less structurally operative here than that of the récit: the latter can be more rigorously specified, particularly with the use of those national variants I mentioned. As for the

[1] Jack Goody's stern rebuke to pan-narrativists (such as myself) overlooks the distinction between a restricted use of the term for a generic type of discourse (songs, divinations, orations and the like) and a more general, dare I say hermeneutic use of the term in which the object of analysis is temporal movement of a more musical kind (in which, for example, mathematical problems are solved or one follows the adventures of a named concept through a technical philosophical argument): Jack Goody, "From Oral to Written," in Franco Moretti, ed., *The Novel, Volume 1: History, Geography, and Culture*, Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2006.

[2] My impression is, however, that the fortunes of this opposition were in fact based on a misunderstanding: Fernandez, in his essay on Balzac (in *Messages*, 1943) seems to have meant "récit" to mean the background and "backstory" passages which accompanied the various characters, and not a distinct form of discourse in its own right.

novel itself, however (not to speak of the realist novel which interests us here), very little is to be deduced from Fernandez' opposition, and writers have tended to fill in their own blank check according to their aesthetic and their ideology.

So it is that Gide, conceiving of the récit as the tale of a unique personal existence or destiny (mostly, for him, a tale told in the first person), is able to draw the conclusion that the novel ought then to be a "*carrefour*," a crossroads or meeting place of multiple destinies, multiple récits. The only book of his own that he was willing to call a novel, then, *Les faux-monnayeurs* (*The Counterfeiters*), offers just such a convergence of a number of different life stories; and it may be agreed that many writers, particularly those specializing in the short story, have thought of the novel in this general way, as a sort of formal Everest to be confronted.

Sartre, on the other hand, has a much more philosophical and ideological conception of this opposition, which he grasps in temporal terms and wields with no little critical and polemic power. Here is his evocation of the Maupassant short story, which he grasps as a kind of bourgeois social institution and translates into a concrete after-dinner situation set in the den of cigar-smoking affluent men:

> The procedure is nowhere more manifest than in Maupassant. The structure of his short stories is almost invariable; we are first presented with the audience, a brilliant and worldly society which has assembled in a drawing-room after dinner. It is night-time, which dispels fatigue and passion. The oppressed are asleep, as are the rebellious; the world is enshrouded; the story unfolds. In a bubble of light surrounded by nothing there remains this élite which stays awake, completely occupied with its ceremonies. If there are intrigues or love or hate among its members, we are not told of them, and desire and anger are likewise stilled; these men and women are occupied in *preserving* their culture and manners and in *recognizing* each other by the rites of politeness. They represent order in its most exquisite form; the calm of night, the silence of the passions, everything concurs in symbolizing the stable bourgeoisie of the end of the century which thinks that nothing more will happen and which believes in the eternity of capitalist organization. Thereupon, the narrator is introduced. He is a middle-aged man who has "seen much, read much, and retained much," a professional man of experience, a doctor, a military man, an artist, or a Don Juan. He has reached the time of life when, according to a respectful and comfortable myth, man is freed from the passions and considers with an indulgent clear-sightedness those he has experienced. His heart is calm, like the night. He tells his story with detachment. If it has caused him suffering, he has made honey from this suffering. He looks back upon it and considers it as it really was, that is, *sub specie aeternitatis*. There

> was difficulty to be sure, but this difficulty ended long ago; the actors are dead or married or comforted. Thus, the adventure was a brief disturbance which is over with. It is told from the viewpoint of experience and wisdom; it is listened to from the viewpoint of order. Order triumphs; order is everywhere; it contemplates an old disorder as if the still waters of a summer day have preserved the memory of the ripples which have run through it.[3]

Gide practiced both "genres"; Sartre has nothing but contempt for the kind of anecdote which forms the structural core of the récit and which he associates with the oppressive cult of "experience" wielded by the older generation over the younger (see *La nausée*). But it is precisely that judgement that allows him to formulate what the novel ought to be—the authentic, existential novel—in temporal terms.

The time of the récit is then a time of the preterite, of events completed, over and done with, events that have entered history once and for all. It will be clear enough what a philosophy of freedom must object to in such an inauthentic and reified temporality: it necessarily blocks out the freshness of the event happening, along with the agony of decision of its protagonists. It omits, in other words, the present of time and turns the future into a "dead future" (what this or that character anticipated in 1651 or in 1943). Clearly enough, then, what Sartre calls upon the novel to reestablish is the open present of freedom, the present of an open, undecided future, where the die has not yet been cast, to use one of his favorite expressions. The aesthetic of the existential novel will then bend its narrative instruments to the recreation of this open present, in which not even the past is set in stone, insofar as our acts in the present rewrite and modify it.

We will not fully appreciate the force of this conception of the novel until we recall the devastating critique of François Mauriac's novels, with their sense of impending doom, their melodramatic rhetorical gestures ("this fatal gesture," "she was not then to know," "this encounter, in retrospect so full of consequences," etc.), their built-in predictable mechanisms of sin and judgement. All this, Sartre tells us, is narrated from above, with a God-like omniscience of past and future alike. "Dieu n'est pas bon romancier," he concludes, "M. Mauriac non plus."[4]

But just as surely, even though more subtly, the Sartrean recipe for

[3] Jean-Paul Sartre, *"What is Literature?" and Other Essays*, Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1988, 125–126.

[4] Sartre, *Situations I*, Paris: Gallimard, 1947, 67.

the novel is shaped and determined, preselected, by its own historical content: the time of the momentous decision and the impending Event, the effacement of everyday life and the iteratives of peacetime, the pressure of what he called extreme situations. The Sartrean taboo on foreknowledge will be replicated in a somewhat different way by the Jamesian ideology of point of view, and both will be appropriated, as we shall see, for far more inauthentic purposes after the end of realism as such, in what I will call a more commercial realism after realism.

What we can retain of the Sartrean perspective on the récit, however, is its insistence on irrevocability, on which a somewhat different light is shed by the German tradition, relatively poor in novels as it may be, but extraordinarily rich in storytelling of all kinds, particularly in the Romantic era. We have, for example, Goethe's memorable encapsulation of the content of storytelling as an "*unerhörte Begebenheit*"[5]—an unheard-of event or conjuncture, one thereby itself memorable and worthy of retelling over and over again, and of being passed down in the family and even the community: the time of the single lightning bolt that killed three people at once, the time of the great flood, of the invasion of the barbarians, the time Lizzie Borden took an axe, and so forth. It is then this time of the memorable event, of the traditional tale or story, that Walter Benjamin memorialized in his great essay "The Storyteller" (on Leskov).

Indeed, Benjamin makes it clear what so many examples of the "*unerhörte Begebenheit*" have in common: namely death. "Warming your hands on a death that is told" is the way he characterizes the récit[6]; and if we feel that this is too bleak, we may substitute for death simply the mark of the irrevocable. This irrevocability adds a new dimension to Sartre's critique of the inauthenticity of the récit: the temporal past is now redefined in terms of what cannot be changed, what lies beyond the reach of repetition or rectification, which now comes to be seen as the time of everyday life or of routine. The

[5] Johann Peter Eckermann, *Gespräche mit Goethe*, Vol. I, Basel: Birkhäuser, 1945, 210 (January 25, 1827): "denn was ist eine Novelle anders als eine sich ereignete unerhörte Begebenheit."

[6] Walter Benjamin, "Der Erzähler," *Gesammelte Schriften*, Vol. 2, Frankfurt: Suhrkamp, 1989, 457. "Das was den Leser zum Roman zieht, ist die Hoffnung, sein fröstelndes Leben an einem Tod, von dem er liest, zu wärmen." It will be remembered that earlier in the same section he compared the construction of a novel to the building of a fire.

irrevocable then comes to stand as a mark of one specific temporality which is separated off from another kind; and Goethe's definition may then be reread to designate, not strangeness or uniqueness, but precisely this shock of a marked time brutally differentiating itself from ordinary existence.

It should be added that for Benjamin, this ordinary existence is itself grasped as collective and historical, as the time of peasants or of the village, in which, as opposed to the great industrial metropolis of a later date, the tale as such flourishes.[7] Indeed, we may further point out that for Benjamin, the opposite number of the tale or récit is not the realistic novel at all: it is the dissolution of the memorable and the narratable in Baudelaire's modernism, or the technological and political recuperation of Baudelaire's fragments in Eisensteinian montage, in the so-called reproducible work of art.[8]

Meanwhile, in a paradoxical turn-about, this new notion of the irrevocable mark as the very basis of the récit is also susceptible of a Sartrean authenticity very different from the bourgeois inauthenticity of the Maupassant smoking den. Indeed, the irrevocable also comes in Sartre to define the heroic, the freely chosen act, one that marks you forever and from which there is no turning back: the act one drags about with one like a ball and chain (again a Sartrean figure). It is then the recoiling in horror before such a choice that is inauthentic; and we may draw on *Peer Gynt* for a comic example. For when Peer is welcomed into the kingdom of the trolls, he is promised everything: the troll king's daughter, riches beyond price, a life of leisure and pleasure, the succession to the throne—and all this, the king assures him, on the most minimal condition, namely, that you let yourself—painlessly, to be sure—undergo hideous defacement as a pledge of solidarity with us and a guarantee that you will never seek to return to the world of ordinary humans. Peer draws the line at that kind of guarantee, that mark of irrevocability, preferring to keep his options open and his "Sartrean freedom" untouched by any such binding commitments.[9]

We may thus grasp the lightning bolt of the récit as the marking

[7] The "origin" of storytelling, according to him, lay in the intersection of travelling seamen and merchants with the sedentary life of the villagers.

[8] I believe that Benjamin's three essays, on Leskov, on Baudelaire, and finally on Eisenstein and film, make up a trilogy that stages history as the rise and fall of narrative as it symptomatizes experience itself.

[9] Henrik Ibsen, *Peer Gynt*, Act II.

of a body and the transformation of an individual into a character with a unique destiny, a "life sore," as one American novelist puts it, something given to you uniquely to bear and to suffer[10]: something "*je mein eigenes*," as Heidegger described individual death. This brings our account of the récit or the tale a little closer to the destinies once offered in spectacle by tragedy as a form. In modern times, however, such destinies at best mark a character as one of Todorov's "*hommes-récits*," the Thousand-and-One-Nights characters who *are* their own stories,[11] at the high tide of the récit as a form; while at worst, in yet more modern times, they are taken to be little more than bad luck. Still, I will retain the category of "destiny" or "fate" as the deeper philosophical content of this narrative form, which might also be evoked as the narrative preterite, the mark of irrevocable time, of the event that has happened once and for all. What has happened in the course of our discussion—it will be important later on—is that this mark has slowly been turned or rotated in the direction of other people: it is not only my act, for myself, which defines my destiny: the latter also becomes my scar, my sore or limp, my being-for-other-people, which is also to say my existence as a character in a story.

It will not have escaped notice that in this lengthy discussion of the récit, we have completely lost sight of its opposite number, namely the *roman*. Sartre seemed to have made a place for it in that existential present in which the choice was in the process of being made or being refused: a time before destiny, in other words, and perhaps before the récit itself. We need to retain this notion of an existential present as it is opposed to the irrevocable past tense of the récit; but we now need to approach it in a different way, and for this I will turn to yet a third tradition, that of English-language narratology or rather, to be more precise about it, the American tradition.

Here, of course, the fundamental theoretician is Henry James in his *Prefaces*, its ideas codified and popularized in Percy Lubbock's *Craft of Fiction*. And here the distinction between récit and *roman* takes on a much more familiar appearance: it is simply that between "telling" and "showing." You tell, you *recite*, the events; you show them happening in the present of the novelistic scene. To be sure, the novel includes both types of discourse; indeed, the very passage from one

[10] See Susan Willis, *Specifying: Black Women Writing the American Experience*, Madison, WI: University of Wisconsin Press, 1987, 70. (The writer referred to is Paule Marshall).

[11] Tzvetan Todorov, *Poetics of Prose*, Ithaca: Cornell, 1977, chapter 5, "Narrative Men."

to the other is itself stylistically and even metaphysically significant—that "choice," as André Malraux put it, "of what is to become scene or to remain récit, the emplacement of those porches where a Balzac or a Dostoyevsky lie in wait for their characters as destiny itself waits on man."[12]

Yet Malraux, along with James himself, is biased in favor of showing rather than telling; and we must factor this prejudice in favor of scene, this commitment to Jamesian "point of view," into their theorization of the opposition.

For James himself, it would seem that mere telling—the récit part of what he describes as a "double pressure" on the novel—means shirking his job.[13] The narrative summaries and foreshortenings are in effect sheer laziness, they are the sign he has not lived up to his calling, the august vocation he invented for himself (and for others). "One's poor word of honor has *had* to pass muster for the show."[14] "The poor author's comparatively cold affirmation or thin guarantee"[15] he calls such passages, on the point of drawing the whole process into an economic transaction (as he does so often), while calling on the literary critics to live up to their vocation and denounce all the "dodges" (his word) the novelist has thereby had recourse to. The more modern language of discourse versus story does not really modify this bias, which I hope my own dual model will redress, giving some of the honor back to the great storytellers and the framers of the great art-novellas.

But James is very clear about the antagonism between the two modes of récit and presence. He characterizes it as

> the odd inveteracy with which picture, at almost any turn, is jealous of drama, and drama (though on the whole with a greater patience, I think) suspicious of picture. Between them, no doubt, they do much for the theme; yet each baffles insidiously the other's ideal and eats round the edges of its position; each is too ready to say, "I can take the thing for 'done' only when done in *my* way."[16]

[12] André Malraux, *Les voix du silence*, Paris: Gallimard, 1951, 353.

[13] Henry James, *The Art of the Novel*, New York: Scribners, 1934, 300. James's foundational distinction between telling and showing now finds confirmation in the light of David Kurnick's remarkable *Empty Houses*, Princeton UP, 2012, which, documenting the theatrical failures at the heart of much of the modernist canon now grasps modernist showing as a formal and structural nostalgia for theatricality.

[14] Ibid., 298.

[15] Ibid., 301.

[16] Ibid., 298. (The quotes are all part of the Preface to *The Wings of the Dove*.)

In defense of telling, however, and by way of redressing the scales so heavily weighted by Sartre against the extraordinary storytelling art of Maupassant, it may be well to insist on the relative insignificance of "showing" in the narratives, not only of the great oral practitioners, but even in that of more sophisticated practitioners such as Boccaccio. Many are no doubt the candidates for the most beautiful story in the world, but I am not far myself from endorsing the view of the distinguished German writer Paul Heyse,[17] who based his so-called *Falkentheorie* on the ninth tale of the fifth day of the *Decameron*, whose "moral" or summary I herewith append:

> 9. In courting a lady who does not return his love, Federigo degli Alberighi spends the whole of his substance, being left with nothing but a falcon, which, since his larder is bare, he offers to his lady to eat when she calls to see him at his house. On discovering the truth of the matter, she has a change of heart, accepts him as her husband, and makes a rich man of him.[18]

Heyse thought that the perfection of this little tale lay in the way in which its convergences were crystallized in a single object, namely the hawk of the title, in such a way as to concentrate the temporality of narrative into something the mind could uniquely appropriate and hold to itself, time made space, in other words, the event materialized, in a fashion perhaps not so distant after all from Benjamin's conception of a moment which becomes "memorable."[19] This object is not a symbol; it is not its meaningfulness which is essential but rather its unity and density.

Heyse is here clearly enough specifying the properties of the most usable anecdotal starting point (or "subject" as Henry James liked to call it), rather than a structural law of some kind: in contemporary stories objects tend to be far more contingent, resembling Barthes' *punctum*[20] more than they do his *studium*. What gives his theory its plausibility is, however, the part of the story Boccaccio has dropped, either by negligence or by design, from his little summary. For the hawk—in this, paradigmatic of most twist or trick endings, even those which do not turn on a single object—is double-valenced, which is

[17] Paul Heyse, "Einleitung," *Deutscher Novellenschatz*, Munich: Oldenbourg, 1971.

[18] Boccaccio, *The Decameron*, London: Penguin, 1995, xiv.

[19] Benjamin, "Der Erzähler," 453–54, section xiii on *Erinnerung*.

[20] Roland Barthes, *La Chambre Claire*, *Œuvres completes, tome III*, Paris: Seuil, 1995, 1126.

to say that it can serve a different function in each of the contexts in which it appears, switching back and forth in a kind of Gestalt effect.

What is curious here is that Boccaccio has omitted both contexts, both storylines which converge here, from his brief outline. For the hawk is not only his master's prize possession (and not merely his only one, as the summary suggests), it is something of a substitute for the desperate and forlorn passion he nourishes for the pointedly indifferent and uninterested Monna Giovanna, so that he will have sacrificed with it everything that still gives any meaning to his sad existence.

But the hawk also stands at the center of the other storyline, the reason for Monna Giovanna's unusual visit to a man she has every reason to avoid, inasmuch as its possession also constitutes the passionate desire of her beloved son, deathly ill and unlikely to recover even if he is able to have this last wish satisfied.

The story shows us that Federigo is willing to do anything she wants, and the banquet with which he regales her is intended to dramatize that willingness. The hawk thereby unites the tragic failure of three passions, and its story thereby triumphantly wins its nomination, not only for the saddest story ever told but also for the most perfect.

But it is a tale that needs no "showing," no scene, no present of narrative at all; and this is the point of its introduction here, as the purest form of the récit. The anecdote not only needs no dialogue and no point of view (it has all these in Boccaccio's brief "telling"), but the whole art of storytelling lies in this possibility of the anecdote, the *fait divers*, to be expanded and contracted at will, and according to the practical necessities of the situation. Even more important from our perspective is the palpable fact that the tale cannot exist in the present, its events must already have happened: this is the "moment of truth" of Sartre's analysis, for whom in this sense the absolute past, what has already happened, the irrevocable, cannot exist, for it can always be rewritten, reevaluated, revised by the power of a new act in the present or the future. The mode of the récit now seals this event off and makes such revision impossible (and the death of the hawk is the figure for this irrevocability of death in general). What confuses the issue is of course the eternal present of the reader, who brings a different temporality to the process.

This is then the moment to distinguish two kinds of time, two systems of temporality, which will be the basis for the argument that follows. The distinction is one between a present of consciousness and a time, if not of succession or of chronology, then at least of

the more familiar tripartite system of past-present-future. I want to assert that the present of consciousness is somehow impersonal, that consciousness is itself impersonal; while it is the subject of consciousness or the self that is the locus of personal identity in the ordinary sense. That self, however, is itself only an object for the impersonal consciousness of the present; and in a way all the personal identifications of past-present-future in the other sense are distinct from the impersonal present, mere objects in it, no matter how inseparable they are from it. You can say that theories of this kind reflect the famous "death of the subject" or that they articulate the split subject of poststructuralism or Lacanianism: we won't follow those debates any further here, but will only draw some interesting consequences for the narrative theories in the process of elaboration. In particular, it becomes clear that the regime of the past-present-future and of personal identities and destinies is at its outer limit the realm of the récit; while the impersonal consciousness of an eternal or existential present would at its outer limit govern pure scene, a showing that was altogether divorced and separated from telling and purified of it. Let's see what an event might look like from this second temporal perspective:

> Lunch went on methodically, until each of the seven courses was left in fragments and the fruit was merely a toy, to be peeled and sliced as a child destroys a daisy, petal by petal.

This is a rather different lunch from many we can remember reading about: the one which makes Mr. Bloom belch with satisfaction in *Ulysses*; the immense two-hundred-page lunches in Proust, from which all the gossip and anecdotes fan out like a rhizome; the truly abominable lunch break that sets everything in motion at the beginning of *La bête humaine*; some elegant English luncheon in which, according to the newspapers, someone ingests a virulent particle of radiation; or that infinitely sad lunch to which Boccaccio's impoverished hero invited his beloved. All of those—and I will treat you to yet another lunch later on, a truly wondrous well-nigh salvational one—all of those are inserted into one or another kind of narrative time; the anonymous lunch in which one course is peeled off after another is not.

Many are to be sure the theories of metaphor from time immemorial, from Ricoeur's identification (based on Aristotle) of metaphor

as the very source of Being itself[21] to any number of tropological systems, let alone systems of resemblance and recognition. In our context, however, what is inescapable is the function of metaphor to detemporalize existence, to dechronologize and denarrativize the present, indeed, to construct or reconstruct a new temporal present which we are so oddly tempted to call eternal. The word is evidently an attempt to escape the temporal overtones of the normal vocabulary for experiences of time, and is consistent with the "eternity" of individual consciousness itself as long as it lasts (inasmuch as in that sense, consciousness has no opposite and we are in it, even in sleep, in some absolute and inescapable fashion).

What we can at least conclude from this discussion is that we have here finally located the definitive formulation for the discursive opposition we have been trying to name. Now it can be articulated not as récit versus *roman*, nor even telling versus showing; but rather destiny versus the eternal present. And what is crucial is not to load one of these dies and take sides for the one or the other as all our theorists seemed to do, but rather to grasp the proposition that realism lies at their intersection. Realism is a consequence of the tension between these two terms; to resolve the opposition either way would destroy it; James's guilt feelings are not only justified, they are necessary. And this is also why it is justified to find oneself always talking about the emergence or the breakdown of realism and never about the thing itself, since we will always find ourselves describing a potential emergence or a potential breakdown.

[21] Paul Ricoeur, *The Rule of Metaphor*, Toronto: University Press, 1977, 307.

Chapter II

The Twin Sources of Realism: Affect, or, the Body's Present

We have, to be sure, ourselves omitted something significant from our account of "The Hawk," and it is the happy ending: the boy recovers from his illness (despite the absence of his beloved falcon), Monna Giovanna relents, and, although she fails to develop any genuine passion for Federigo, consents to the marriage, in which "they all live happily ever after" and so forth. But this involves a lowering of tone, and as it were a decompression, a return to the flatlands of everyday life, a slow disengagement from the intensities of the Event (the narrative or récit itself) and a consent to the less exhilarating yet ultimately more humanly bearable comfort of the everyday (using this last word in Auerbach's heightened sense, with its connotation of a realism to come).

The shift, then, from tale to daily life simply confirms the point being made about the two temporalities at stake here. Yet also to be noted, if not unduly stressed, is the mild desolation that accompanies this narrative, whether in its major mode as a récit or in the coda. I have used the word "sad" (to which we will return in a more official context): is this feeling only to be attributed to the reader or is it possible that it suggests a dimension of narrative we have not yet taken into consideration?

This observation will then serve to introduce the second agency in my story, and the other impulse—affect—I want to associate with the emergence of realism as such. I will first stage this second impulse as the opposite of the narrative one: that is to say, I will approach it from the standpoint of temporality, for which the récit has seemed to embody a temporality of the past and of the preterite, a temporality of the chronological, in which, everything having happened already, events succeed each other in what is today loosely called "linear time" (a rather faddish expression I believe we owe to Marshall McLuhan).

Is it possible to imagine a temporality so different from this conventional one that the word "time" ceases to seem altogether appropriate for it (something we already mused about in connection with the term "eternal")?

In the hindsight of the theory (and historical experience) of the postmodern, and of what I have called "the end of temporality," perhaps we can add greater specificity to the kind of temporality (or lack of it) at stake here. "The End of Temporality" theorized a shrinking of contemporary (bourgeois) experience such that we begin to live a perpetual present with a diminishing sense of temporal or indeed phenomenological continuities[1]: this perpetual present was, I believe, what Deleuze and Guattari described as a schizophrenic present (in the *Anti-Oedipus*)[2], but theirs was an altogether Utopian account which takes its place in a tradition of literary celebrations of temporal immediacy from Wordsworth's imbeciles and Flaubert's "simple heart"[3] on down to modern times. I believe that the contemporary or postmodern "perpetual present" is better characterized as a "reduction to the body," inasmuch as the body is all that remains in any tendential reduction of experience to the present as such. But I would not necessarily want to argue that in such temporal isolation the body's senses gain a heightened existence, something that is more likely to happen when, for whatever reason, one sense is given priority over the others (as in the evolving specializations of nineteenth-century painting and music). Rather, the isolated body begins to know more global waves of generalized sensations, and it is these which, for want of a better word, I will here call affect.

It is a technical term which has been strongly associated with a number of recent theories which alternately appeal to Freud or to Deleuze and which, like the theory of postmodernity, also take this phenomenon as evidence for a new turn in human relations and forms of subjectivity (including politics).[4] I do not here mean to

[1] See Jameson, "The End of Temporality," in *Ideologies of Theory*, London: Verso, 2009.

[2] See the first chapter of Deleuze and Guattari's *L'Anti-Œdipe* (Paris: Minuit, 1972), as celebrated, for example, in the following account: "Il y a une expérience schizophrénique des quantités intensives à l'état pur, à un point presque insupportable—une misère et une gloire célibataires éprouvées au plus haut point, comme une clameur suspendue entre la vie et la mort, un sentiment de passage intense, états d'intensité pure et crue dépouillés de leur figure et de leur forme" (25).

[3] To Felicité's blessed simplicity should be added the very different longing expressed in Saint Antoine's final cry: "Être la matière!"

[4] Various conceptual streams meet in this concept: Deleuze's commentaries on Spinoza, Eve Sedgwick's meditations on Sylvan Tompkins, trauma theory, queer theory and a whole new generation of work, which is scarcely summarized by references to Jonathan Flatley, *Affective Mapping*, Cambridge, MA: Harvard, 2008—but see his bibliographic note on 198–99—or to Sianne Ngai, *Ugly Feelings*, Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2005.

appropriate it for a different theory of all these things, nor do I mean to endorse or to correct the philosophies of which it currently constitutes a kind of signal or badge of group identity. Indeed, I want to specify a very local and restricted, practical use of the term "affect" here by incorporating it into a binary opposition which historicizes it and limits its import to questions of representation and indeed of literary history.

I will therefore begin by distinguishing affect (in my sense of the word) from emotions as such. The opposition between feelings and emotions is a long-standing one, based mostly on tradition rather than any successfully articulated structural difference. The replacement of the vague word "feeling" by the more technical if not clinical term "affect" does seem to promise a little more rigor in the debate, if not indeed to promise some renewal of it in the reconsideration of an old problem, which has become the unexamined sedimentation of common sense thought.

I will clarify it by modifying the terminology of the opposite number as well: for I wish to redefine emotion as "named emotion," and thereby not only to mark a structural difference between emotion and affect but also to underscore yet a further dimension of this problem, which involves the intervention of language as such. The new implication is that affect (or its plural) somehow eludes language and its naming of things (and feelings), whereas emotion is preeminently a phenomenon sorted out into an array of names. Traditionally those names—love, hatred, anger, fear, disgust, pleasure, and so forth—have been grasped as a system of phenomena (like the system of the colors, for example); and like colors, the system is a historical one which varies from culture to culture and from period to period. Many are the handbooks which seek to map out the then current systems of emotions, from Aristotle's *Nichomachean Ethics* to Descartes' *Treatise on the Passions*.[5] But what needs further clarification in our context—

[5] I have not found a suitable structural history; but see Amélie O. Rorty, ed., *Exploring Emotions*, Berkeley: University of California Press, 1980; Daniel M. Gross, *The Secret History of Emotion*, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2006; and, in order not to omit the humors from this picture, Noga Arikha, *Passions and the Tempers*, New York: Harper Collins, 2007.

for such systems eventually seem to dissolve in the era of affect, and yet to survive residually like so many traditions—is not so much the system as such as rather the reifying effects of the name itself.

It is indeed a delicate philosophical problem, if not a false one altogether, to distinguish between a phenomenological state of being—say, the experience of anger—and the word by which it is named: "Sing, Muse, the wrath of Achilles"—*thumos*. The philological dialectic deflects our interest in the thing itself—how the ancients felt anger—to the history of the word: but is the existence of the word altogether foreign to the experience of the emotion? If it does not bring it into being in the first place, as some absolute constructivism might claim, then at least the articulation language brings to the as yet unexpressed feeling will surely open all kinds of new channels into which it can spread and thrive.

By habit and tradition, the notion of reification now strikes us as a negative or critical one; and the implication that the name necessarily reifies the emotion at once suggests the possibility of some more authentic experience that preceded the baleful spell of nomination (and that could in a pinch perhaps be recovered). But this is to forget Hegel's judiciously ambivalent deployment of the original concept: humans objectify their projects and their desires, thereby enriching them: life is itself then a series of reifications which are themselves reabsorbed and enlarged by way of the new project. Naming is a fundamental component of such objectification, and alienation is only one possible fate for what is a universal process.

"If the word love comes up between them I am lost!" Count Mosca's famous apprehension (on seeing Gina and Fabrice together) is perhaps only the most dramatic expression of the way in which the name can suddenly bring a whole new world into being (for good or ill!).[6] Meanwhile, many are the examples of words which have historically articulated undiscovered states of being which, while perhaps not newly emergent, were at least dormant if not unconscious in everyday human existence, and which then begin to play their own role as agents in a reorganization of life. Such was, for example, the appropriation of the old word "*ennui*" for the new state of nineteenth-century boredom, which brought all kinds of new questions about activity and even existence into being around it. Such was also, in my opinion, the word "anxiety," which rescued a daily and unnerving experience

[6] Stendhal, *La Chartreuse de Parme*, Paris: Cluny, 1948, 165 (chapter 8).

from the melodramatic and quasi-religious grandeur of words like "anguish." Such finally is also the designation of an ancient scholastic term for that register of feeling we now call "affect" itself, not to speak of medicalization.[7] Yet the onto-philological dilemma remains (or is it the Sapir-Whorff hypothesis?): were there affects before this name raised them into the light of consciousness, or did the word somehow slowly begin to modify the field of existential reality itself in such a way as to endow us with a bodily dimension absent from the bodily experience of, say, the ancient Greeks?

As I suggested, I believe that the problem is unsolvable in that form, but also that, if we specify a restriction on what the historical language can and cannot express at any given point, the ontological question will not disrupt the historical one. (Meanwhile, the question of whether affects cannot themselves be reified in the naming process must also remain open: Did the medieval term "acedia" not modify the experience of medieval clerks? Does the word "melancholia," itself long present in Western discourse, not do something significant to our own internal subjectivities? And does not the very word "affect," itself henceforth powerfully reorganize the latter's force field?)[8]

At any rate, it will have become clear that by positing the named emotion (rather than emotion tout court) as the binary opposite of affect per se (or at least as the term whose difference allows us best to articulate the latter's identity), I am also insisting on the resistance of affect to language, and thereby on the new representational tasks it poses poets and novelists in the effort somehow to seize its fleeting essence and to force its recognition. For in its insatiable colonization of the as yet unexplored and inexpressed (it is an impulse in which realism can be said to share the telos that modernism only more stridently affirms and sloganizes), the system of the old named emotions becomes not only too general but also too familiar: to approach the emotions more closely is microscopically to see within them a Brownian movement which, although properly unnamable in its own right, calls out imperiously for all the stimulation of linguistic innovation. It is towards mid-century, let us say in the 1840s of the bourgeois era, that such linguistic demands begin to become audible and inescapable, at least for the most alert arts that scan the era for the new.

[7] See Ivan Illich, *Limits to Medicine*, London: Marion Boyers, 1995.

[8] We will see that the very word "body," unifying and totalizing as it is, can itself scarcely escape the reproach of reification either.

But now we must introduce another feature of affect: I provisionally follow Rei Terada's idea (derived ultimately from Kant) that affects are bodily feelings, whereas emotions (or passions, to use their other name) are conscious states.[9] The latter have objects, the former are bodily sensations: it is the difference between the *coup de foudre* and a state of generalized depression. But this is then to endow the concept of affect with a positive content: if the positive characteristic of the emotion is to be named, the positive content of an affect is to activate the body. Language is here opposed to the body, or at least the lived body (which may itself be a "modern" phenomenon). And therefore, alongside a crisis of language, in which the old systems of emotions come to be felt as a traditional rhetoric, and an outmoded one at that, there is also a new history of the body to be written, the "bourgeois body" as we may now call it, as it emerges from the outmoded classifications of the feudal era. (Foucault's historical periodization of the emergence of "life" or of the new biosciences offers one possible context for what I here mean to be an existential and class-social phenomenon, related to the emergence of new forms of daily life.[10])

One has only to compare the descriptions in Balzac's novels, concocted by someone who came of age in the Restoration, to the organization of narrative discourse in Flaubert only a generation later, to grasp the truly historical changes in what is asked of language by each novelist, and what is represented in the way of the representation of subjectivity, and of its perceptions.

In that case, it will be appropriate to associate rise of affect with the emergence of the phenomenological body in language and representation; and to historicize a competition between the system of named emotions and the emergence of nameless bodily states which can be documented in literature around the middle of the nineteenth century (literary representation furnishing the most comprehensive evidence as to a momentous yet impossibly hypothetical historical transformation of this kind). Flaubert and Baudelaire can stand as the markers for such a transformation of the sensorium, which can perhaps best be demonstrated by way of Balzac's dealings with the senses in the previous generation. Balzacian descriptions are well-known: here is the most famous, of the salon of the Maison Vauquer:

[9] Rei Terada, *Feeling in Theory: Emotion After the "Death of the Subject,"* Cambridge, MA: Harvard, 2001, 82.

[10] See also Donald Lowe's pathbreaking *History of Bourgeois Perception*, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1983.

> Cette première pièce exhale une odeur sans nom dans la langue, et qu'il faudrait appeler *l'odeur de pension*. Elle sent le renfermé, le moisi, le rancé; elle donne froid, elle est humide au nez, elle pénètre les vêtements; elle a le goût d'une salle où l'on dine; elle pue le service, l'office, l'hospice. Peut-être pourrait-elle se décrire si l'on inventait un procédé pour évaluer les quantités élémentaires et nauséabondes qu'y jettent les atmosphères catarrhales et *sui generis* de chaque pensionnaire, jeune ou vieux.
>
> This room gives off a smell for which our language has no special word; it can only be described as a *boarding house smell*. It smells stuffy, mouldy, rancid; it is chilly, clammy to breathe, permeates one's clothing; it leaves the stale taste of a room where people have been eating; it stinks of backstairs, scullery, workhouse. It could only be described if some process were invented for measuring the quantity of disgusting elementary particles contributed by each resident, young or old, from his own catarrhal and *sui generis* exhalations.[11]

Everything would seem to confirm the first impression, that it is an affect that is at question here: it is nameless and unclassifiable, the senses are mobilized, Balzac is keenly aware of his linguistic and representational problem and fusses with his recording apparatus. But this description is not the evocation of an affect, for one good reason: namely that it *means* something.

The passage makes clear why the elaborate descriptions in Balzec do not invalidate the historical proposition I want to advance about the body in literature. For in Balzac everything that looks like a physical sensation—a musty smell, a rancid taste, a greasy fabric—always means something, it is a sign or allegory of the moral or social status of a given character: decent poverty, squalor, the pretensions of the parvenu, the true nobility of the old aristocracy, and so on. In short, it is not really a sensation, it is already a meaning, an allegory. By the time of Flaubert, these signs remain, but they have become stereotypical; and the new descriptions register a density beyond such stereotypical meanings.

Roland Barthes, a keen amateur of the new vibrations modernity brought with it, has spoken authoritatively of the irreconcilable divorce between lived experience and the intelligible which characterizes modernity, between the existential and the meaningful.[12]

[11] Honoré de Balzac, *Le père Goriot*, in *Oeuvres III*, Paris: La Pléiade, 1976, 53. Note the wistful longing for a quantitative turn in this description. English translation by A. J. Krailsheimer, Oxford, 1991, 4–6.

[12] Roland Barthes, "L'Effet de réel," in *Oeuvres*, Vol. II, Paris: Seuil, 1994, 483. And see my own commentary in "The Realist Floor Plan," in *Ideologies of Theory*, London: Verso, 2009.

Experience—and sensory experience in particular—is in modern times contingent: if such experience seems to have a meaning, we are at once suspicious of its authenticity. Balzac, however, will not give up on meaning: he continues energetically to deploy the twin weapons of metaphor ("Old Goriot was a lion!") and of metonymy, as in this passage and indeed everywhere in his work, where the nameless smell is composed of the decent or desperate miseries of pensioners who have deposited their traces in this haven.

To this we might well oppose the contingencies enumerated by Flaubert in his descriptions (Barthes terms them "l'effet de réel" or the "reality-effect"). Baudelaire is just as useful:

> dans une maison déserte quelque armoire
> Pleine de l'âcre odeur des temps, poudreuse et noire.
>
> "Le flacon"

where the musty smell of time drifts in indeterminable synesthesia across the grimy tactility of the armoire. These unnamable sensations have become autonomous, as Balzac's odor might have been had it been converted into some distasteful melancholia. At any rate they no longer mean anything: states of the world, they simply exist.

Yet this is a historical proposition which raises serious philosophical problems. Are we to suppose that before the construction of the secular or bourgeois body in the course of the nineteenth century, affects simply did not exist, and an older pre-modern humanity had to make do with the various systems of emotions referenced above? But it is not exactly this kind of sweeping and peremptory affirmation which I am advancing here, but rather a hypothesis that, with the change in nuance, differentiates it absolutely from this or that statement about human nature. For what I suggest is that before this mid-century, such affects had not been named, had not found their way into language, let alone become the object of this or that linguistic codification. To be sure, this is also a historical proposition, but one about language itself and the way in which the nomination of an experience makes it visible at the very moment that it transforms and reifies it. And what is presupposed is that affects or feelings which have not thus been named are not available to consciousness, or are absorbed into subjectivity in different ways that render them inconspicuous and indistinguishable from the named emotions they may serve to fill out and to which they lend body and substance. This is to say that any proposition about affect is also a proposition about the body; and a historical one at that.

We have so far (in our examples) characterized affect in terms of physical sensation or sensory perception. Odor, the most repressed and stigmatized of the senses as Adorno pointed out,[13] seems everywhere, from Baudelaire to Proust, to be a privileged vehicle for isolating affect and identifying it for a variety of dynamics (we should not forget Teresa Brennan's startling proposal that the contagion of affect—its interpersonal transmission—is historically the result of smell, of which sexual pheromones are only a particularly dramatic example[14]). But these sensory vehicles of affect present a representational problem inasmuch they are easily confused and identified with the bodily senses as such, and thereby reduced to merely physical perceptions or sensations. It is clear, for example, that the usefulness of smell as a vehicle for different types of affect derives at least in part from its marginalized status, its underdevelopment, so to speak, as a symbolic element.

We need then, before continuing, to enumerate some of the features affect seems to present (or to require): the variety of such features then begins to suggest the multiplicity of ways this new element can pervade nineteenth-century realism and open up its narratives, not only to scene and consciousness as such, but above all to some new realism of affect, some heightened representational presence.

We have already insisted on the namelessness of this new reality. It can certainly be constructed, and not only in literature but also in the other arts; but that very operation is dialectical and expresses both faces of a tenacious representational nominalism, for the name, whatever its vocabulary field—the celebration of the *body* or the positing of something like *melancholy* as the fundamental ground-tone of human existence—necessarily turns the affect into a new thing in its own right. The *symboliste* doctrine of suggestion here betrays a deeper truth, that of a radical distinction between naming and representational construction, which, distantly evoking our more fundamental distinction between telling and showing, explains why affect cannot be present in the regime of the récit.

Yet the temptation to name is encouraged by another feature of affect, namely its autonomization. It seems to have no context, but to float above experience without causes and without the structural relationship to its cognate entities which the named emotions have with

[13] T. W. Adorno and Max Horkheimer, *Dialectic of Enlightenment*, Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2007. See the chapter "Elements of Anti-Semitism."

[14] Teresa Brennan, *The Transmission of Affect*, Ithaca: Cornell, 2004.

one another.[15] This is not to say that in reality affect has no causes whatsoever, no relationship to its situation of emergence: for any number of chemical, psychoanalytic, or interpersonal factors may well plausibly be proposed or experimentally tested. But its essence is to remain free-floating and independent of these factors (which only exist for other people), and this is obviously a function of its temporality as an eternal present, as an element which is somehow self-sufficient, feeding on itself, and perpetuating its own existence ("all joy wants eternity!"). This is then the point at which we must evoke another feature (explored in recent times by Deleuze and Lyotard)[16], namely intensity: that is, the capacity of affect to be registered according to a range of volume, from minute to deafening, without losing its quality and its determination. Indeed, Lyotard's usage makes it clear that we could just as well substitute the term "intensity" for that of "affect" itself, provided we use it in the plural—yet here too it is no longer a matter of form and content, but rather of that other contemporary verbal-fetish, which is singularity. Affects are singularities and intensities, existences rather than essences, which usefully unsettle the more established psychological and physiological categories.

This was indeed what Roland Barthes meant by his notion of the "reality effect," a formulation designed to replace any substantive idea of realism (and in particular those based on its content) by a semiotic one, in which "realism" is only one of the possible signs and signals given off by the text in question. That texts designed to be called "realism" and recognized as such give off signals or connotations of the type Barthes described in *Writing Degree Zero* (and which he called "*écriture*" as such) is unquestionable, even though the type of realism they may have wanted to convey necessarily had a historical and ideological status. Yet I believe there is a more satisfactory way of dealing with realism than its reduction to signs alone (this book attempts to justify that belief).

For with his uncanny sense of intellectual consequences, Barthes then at once historicizes his position: "In the ideology of our time, the obsessive reference to the 'concrete'... is always trained like a

[15] But who says autonomization also necessarily implies differentiation and institutionalization: just as music became an autonomous art with it own rules and properties, so also the musical institutions and material instruments developed around it, from music schools to orchestras, from new instruments to new kinds of municipal funding, etc.

[16] See, for example, Jean-François Lyotard, *Economie libidinale*, Paris: Minuit, 1974.

weapon against meaning as such, as though, de jure, what lives could not signify—and vice versa."[17] This irreconcilable divorce between intelligibility and experience, between meaning and existence, then can be grasped as a fundamental feature of modernity, particularly in literature, whose verbal existence necessarily inclines it to idealism. If it means something, it can't be real; if it is real, it can't be absorbed by purely mental or conceptual categories (the ideal of the "concrete" then attempting an impossible synthesis of these two dimensions: clearly enough phenomenology conceived the most strenuous modern vocation to achieve it.) Yet what Barthes in fact describes here already has another name, it is "contingency"; for the intellectuals of his generation, the novel that gave its discovery the most indelible expression was Sartre's *Nausea*, a unique and unrepeatable solution to an endemic form-problem. Barthes has himself here reincorporated it by transforming Flaubert's non-meaningful non-symbolic objects into so many rhetorical signs (signs of realism). But we can also keep faith with the aims of phenomenology by suggesting that the affect released in Flaubert by the disappearance of Balzac's symbolic and allegorical possibilities shares with Barthes' contingency the "property" of being unassimilable to meaning, to verbal and intellectual abstract (names) and to rational conceptualization as such. So in reality, it is not existence and meaning which are incompatible here (although they may well be in the context of some other philosophical inquiry), it is allegory and the body which repel one another and fail to mix.

And as we shall show elsewhere,[18] allegory in this traditional sense means personification, it means naming and nomination; and it is therefore words themselves (the medieval universals) which are incompatible with the body and its affects. Such is then the first lesson we will want to draw from this foray into the affective realm, namely, that we need a different kind of language to identify affect without, by naming it, presuming to define its content. Metaphor and the metaphorical are not themselves a reliable guide; that the lunch-flower of Virginia Woolf[19] that has been quoted above has an affective dimension is little more than a presumption, the reader must somehow introduce it from the outside; yet we can nonetheless retain at least one feature from its temporality, in which, with each petal

[17] Barthes, "L'Effet de réel," 483.

[18] The second volume of the *Poetics of Social Forms* will be devoted to allegory.

[19] Virginia Woolf, *The Long Voyage Out*, New York: Random House, 2000, 143.

plucked the lunch disintegrates into a pitiable collection of ruined and inedible objects.

For affect to achieve a genuine autonomization, either in its experience or in its representation, however, it must somehow achieve independence from the conventional body itself (which as Sartre taught us is the body of other people). This is why I have for some time found suggestive Heidegger's inaugural invocation of affect—the starting point, not only of Sartrean phenomenology but also of Merleau-Ponty's attempts to formulate embodiment—and that turns on the German word "*Stimmung,*"[20] of which the English "mood" is but a pale and one-dimensional equivalent. Heidegger wanted to show that *Stimmung* was neither subjective nor objective, neither irrational nor cognitive, but rather a constitutive dimension of our being-in-the-world; and his term goes well beyond the characterization of a cloudy sky as "ominous" or a particular kind of lighting as "sinister," as in Gaston Bachelard's psychoanalysis of the elements (joyously rippling streams, stagnant pools)[21]—although the primacy of light is significant here, as we shall see later on.

In fact, Heideggerian or Sartrean *Stimmung* adds something like an object-pole to the subject-pole suggested by the word "affect" (thus demonstrating in the process how difficult it is for us to escape this fatal prejudice by which we are obliged to decide whether something is subjective or objective from the outset). For us, in the present context, however, the alternative opens up a welcome enlargement of the field, in which it is either the world or the individual subject who is thereby the source of what we have until now simply called affect.

The German term has the additional advantage of introducing an auditory dimension, not so much in its relationship to *Stimme* or voice, as rather to what the term suggests of musical tuning, of the according of a musical instrument (as well as the jangling of the unharmonized)—not for nothing does German use the expression "*das stimmt!*" for "it's true!" or "it's correct!" (and their opposites).

More extensive musical reference suggests not only the moods of major and minor (and of the variety of the old Greek modes as well[22]), it also moves us on to the matter of affect's chromaticism, its

[20] Martin Heidegger, *Sein und Zeit*, Tübingen: Niemeyer, 1967, 134, Par. 29.

[21] The first in his series of explorations was *La psychanalyse du feu* (1938).

[22] On the other hand, the Greek system of the seven modes (which are even referenced in Plato and Aristotle's political theories) might well be considered an equivalent of the traditional systems of named emotions to which we have alluded (and also to have their analogues in other cultures as with the Indian ragas). Yet the reappearance of unfamiliar modes in a modern music from which all traces of that systematicity have long since disappeared might well offer suitable occasions for the registration of uncodified affect.

waxing and waning not only in intensity but across the very scale and gamut of such nuances. Not for nothing is Wagner's *Tristan* (1865) counted (along with Flaubert and Baudelaire, and with Manet) as a fundamental date in modernism's liberation from tradition and convention, in this case, I am tempted to say, from the musical récit and that completion into which Beethoven led sonata form and instrumental music. Chromaticism here means a waxing and waning of the scale, a slippage up and down the tones which dismisses all respect for their individual implications (their inner logic of tonic and subdominant), and which also develops each tone into its own specific coloration (articulated by the material development of the instruments themselves).

The evolution of music is thus a vivid way to describe the logic of affect, and indeed the very notion of a sliding scale seems already to suggest quarter-tones and their eventual disaggregation of the Western tonal system (at one, according to Max Weber, with the emergence of Western modernity and "rationality").[23]

But in this mid-century period, it is best to limit ourselves to the disaggregation of the "rationality" of the sonata form (or its completion and exhaustion by Beethoven), in order to appreciate the Wagnerian innovations—the reorganization of sonata-form temporality into the repetitions of the *Leitmotiven*, the transformation of heightened dissonance (the diminished seventh and ninth) into vehicles for affect rather than simple preparations for resolution; chromaticism itself and the very conversion of the key system into precisely that sliding scale of which I have spoken. In all this, there is perhaps a strange regression into the modal systems of pre-Western music; while the Wagnerian "endless melody" itself projects a temporality notably distinct from the past-present-future of the sonata, indeed it brings into being very precisely that "eternal present" we have already evoked in another context. Wagner's own remark about "an art of transitions"[24]

[23] Max Weber, *The Rational and Social Foundations of Music*, trans. Don Martindale, Johannes Riedel and Gertrude Neuwirth, Carbondale: Southern Illinois University Press, 1958.

[24] Richard Wagner, *Selected Letters*, trans. S. Spencer and B. Millington, New York: Norton, 1988, 475: "The characteristic fabric of music ... owes its construction to

not only uncannily anticipates what modern critics have had to say about Flaubert's style, but itself constructs a pure present in which little by little transition itself replaces the more substantive states (or musical "named emotions") that precede and follow it.

None of this, to be sure, takes into account that immense material development and expansion of musical coloration (and material instruments) which Wagner pioneered along with Berlioz and which would seem the most essential, but also the most obvious, way of characterizing everything that is proteiform, metamorphic, shimmering and changeable-ephemeral about affect itself, not excluding its immense (but unmotivated) crescendoes and diminuendi. Meanwhile, Wagnerian affect determines a crisis and a revolution in external form (and the very conception of the music drama) which, although without any immediate analogy with the realistic novel, nonetheless portends significant formal changes to come.

But Wagnerian chromaticism offers a useful staging of the concept (and the new bodily reality?) of affect in yet another way than in its tension with sonata form, for its continuities (the so-called "endless melody") can also be seen as the systematic exclusion of closed entities and episodes essential to the more traditional Italian opera Wagner wished to displace: namely, the aria. It is enough to recall the occasional "songs" that punctuate Wagner's musical continuities—either the official songs of *Meistersinger* or *Tannhäuser*, or the "Du bist der Lenz" of *Walküre*—indeed, it might also be argued that Wagner's long retrospective storytelling passages are something of a replacement for the old aria as such—to understand that the aria was designed to express what we have called the named emotion as such (love! vengeance! grief!); and indeed, to express that expression: ideologically to stage the existence of the emotion and to draw attention to itself as that emotion's embodiment. Whence the flourishes that offer the voice its properly rhetorical vehicle, combining material sound with emotional content. Wagner's repudiation of the aria is thus a profound critique and repudiation of the "named emotion" as such,

the extreme sensitivity which gudes me in the direction of mediating and providing an intimate bond between all the different moments of transition that separate the extremes of mood. I should now like to call my most delicate and profound art the art of transition." (October 29, 1859, to Mathilde Wesendonk). One might well juxtapose this remark with Jean Rousset's study of "l'art des modulations" of Flaubert, in *Forme et signification*, Paris: Corti, 1963; and, on the strength of Charles Rosen's *Romantic Generation*, Cambridge: Harvard, 1998, add Chopin into the picture.

both in reality and in its concept; and what he replaces it with is very precisely affect as such.

The very notion of orchestral coloration, to be sure, reminds us of the tendency of such accounts of one art to borrow the terminology and logic of another, and return us to the parallel developments in painting, where Manet's attention to material color (Gertrude Stein would say, material oil paint) surreptitiously drains his storytelling content of its primacy. Indeed, the word "chromaticism" itself is derived from the Greek *chroma*, which first means "skin" or "skin color," thereby reaffirming the constitutive relationship with the body itself, and not merely one of its reified senses.

Time is thus famously eternalized by Monet's impressionism, as the latter painted his haystacks or cathedrals at every moment of the day from dawn to dusk, seizing each shade of light as a distinct event which the surfaces in question are but a pretext for capturing. It is the intimate relationship between this new conjuncture of light and temporality with Wagner's chromaticism that we now need to grasp, as it constructs a virtually imperceptible passage of perception from one level to the next. Here then, in impressionism as well, an absolute heterogeneity of the elements is translated into some new kind of homogeneity in which a new kind of phenomenological continuum is asserted.

The vogue of the pseudo-scientific experiments with perception (and of such mythical concepts as the meaningless "sense-data" from whose combinations our sense-perceptions are allegedly derived) also suggests this double movement whereby the body is analytically broken down into its smallest components and then scientifically reconstructed as an abstraction, all the while releasing a flow of affect hitherto stored and bound by its traditional unities and their named feelings. Yet it would be wrong to see this development as the exclusion of narrative, as does the conventional account, grasping narrative only in the representational or storytelling content of the painting. This new "pure present" of the visual data of paint and painting in reality harbors new kinds of narrative movement and awakens new trajectories in the movement of the eye and new conceptions of the visual event and its new temporalities.

At any rate, in all these contemporary symptoms, a certain sensory heterogeneity is disguised as that absolute homogeneity we call style, and a new phenomenological continuum begins to emerge, which is that of the play and variations, the expansion and contraction,

the intensification and diminution, of that nameless new life of the body which is affect. Affect becomes the very chromaticism of the body itself.

Such changeability endows the dimension of affect with a capacity for transformation and metamorphosis which can register the nuances of mood fully as much as it can mutate into its opposite, from the depressive to the manic, from gloominess to ecstasy. And the Greek derivation then ultimately returns us to the body itself, along with its temperatures, from the feverish to the deathly chill, from blushing to the pallor of fear or shock.

Affect thus ranges chromatically up and down the bodily scale from melancholy to euphoria, from the bad trip to the high—from Nietzsche's most manic outbursts to the unquenchable depression and guilt of a Strindberg. And this is, as I have stressed, to be radically distinguished from the play of the named emotions as such, even though as modernism develops, their representations will not fail to be tinged and colored, as it were tuned and orchestrated, by the new affective phenomena and the new registering apparatuses designed to capture them.

This puts us on the track of a temporality specific to affect, which I will call the sliding scale of the incremental, in which each infinitesimal moment differentiates itself from the last by a modification of tone and an increase or diminution of intensity. The reference to the other, more material arts is unescapable in this context, not only because it is here a question of the body and its sensations, far more tangibly deployed in music and the visual arts; but also because such an account must necessarily remain external to the thing itself, a language from the outside, which must necessarily be called upon to characterize the structure of language effects, let alone the lived experiences of the body as such.

Impressionism and post-impressionism in painting, the Wagnerian revolution in music—these are only the most obvious analogies to the new affective styles invented by Flaubert and Baudelaire: all are indeed contemporaneous with that historic emergence of the bourgeois body which I want outrageously to affirm here as a historical fact and date. (And if we follow the now conventional story of the emergence of existentialism as a revolt against Hegelianism, then both Kierkegaard's discovery of anxiety and Marx's dramatization, by way of his theory of alienation, of "naked life" can also be summoned to document this radical transformation of the experience of the body

in the European 1840s.) At its outer limit, then, affect becomes the organ of perception of the world itself, the vehicle of my being-in-the-world that Nietzche and after him phenomenological philosophy begin to discover at much the same time.

I now want to explore some of the forms such affect can take, it being understood that our primary interest here lies in what this affective dimension of the new existential present does to the novelistic and in particular the scenic possibilities it opens up and begins to undermine at one and the same time.

But the content of affect is of course itself variable, and even if melancholia remains a kind of constant, in Flaubert, in *Tristan*, in Munch, in Gogol, its opposite is very different in all these cases, as also in Zola, where an expected excess of orgiastic excitement is far less authentic than the domestic shelter and metaphysical comfort of what the French call "*bonheur*," something again quite different from the trivial and truly petty-bourgeois state which English names "happiness." Here, for example, is the truly wondrous moment, in all the heat and dust of the campaign, the fatigue of endless forced marches and the confusion of rumor and fear, in which the protagonist of Zola's *Debacle* is able to know "*un dejeuner rêvé*" in a little garden as yet spared from the sound of artillery and the whistling of flying bullets:

> Dans la joie de la nappe très blanche, ravi du vin blanc qui étincelait dans son verre, Maurice mangea deux oeufs à la coque, avec une gourmandise qu'il ne se connaissait pas.
>
> In his delight at the snowy tablecloth and the white wine sparkling in his glass, Maurice ate two soft-boiled eggs with such an appetite that he surprised himself.[25]

It is an interlude in white utterly distinct in tone from the sad debris of Virginia Woolf's luncheon, and confirmed later on by the luxuriation of his fellow soldier, Jean, when, for one single solitary night of rest and quiet, he is able to sleep in a real bed:

> Ah! ces draps blancs, ces draps si ardemment convoites, Jean ne voyait plus qu'eux … C'était une gourmandise, une impatience d'enfant, une irrésistible passion, à se glisser dans cette blancheur, dans cette fraicheur, et à s'y perdre.

[25] Émile Zola, *Les Rougon-Macquart*, Volume V, *La Débacle*, Paris: Pleiade, 1967, 446. English translation by Elinor Dordray, Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000, 54.

> Oh! All Jean could see were those white sheets, the sheets he'd longed for so fervently! … He was greedy and impatient as a child, feeling an irresistible passion urging him to slip into the whiteness, the freshness, and lose himself inside it.[26]

Many more will however be the metamorphoses of white in this work before we have done with it. Indeed, it is with the development of Zola's extraordinary bodily and linguistic sensibility that the realistic novel is able to deploy the possibilities of what James was to call "the scene as such."

We may conclude this introductory discussion of affect with a table in which the variety of its forms is systematically contrasted with those of the older named emotions:

EMOTION	AFFECT
system	chromaticism
nomenclature	bodily sensation
marks of destiny	perpetual present/eternity
generalized objects	intensities
traditional temporality	singularities
human nature	diagnosis, medicalization
motives	experiences, existentialisms
arias	endless melody
representation	sense-data
closed sonata form	the problem of endings
narration	description

[26] Ibid., 555; Dordray, 161–2.

Chapter III

Zola, or, the Codification of Affect

The novelist who offers some of the richest and most tangible deployments of affect in nineteenth-century realism is Émile Zola, inheritor of the Flaubertian narrative apparatus, contemporary of Wagner, an art critic who was one of the most fervent and perceptive defenders of Manet, and a profound political and social observer, whose own codification of the naturalist novel as a form then serves as a standard for the practice of mass culture and the bestseller up to our own time and all over the world. His unrequited claim to stand among Lukács' "great realists" should not be shaken by his political opinions nor by his enthusiastic practice of melodrama and a dramatic rhetoric often bordering on vulgarity; nor is the naturalism debate—as it is perpetuated by generations of critics intent on somehow separating Zola from the mainstream of nineteenth-century realism—relevant for our own purposes here, except insofar as it plays its part in a contemporary literary tug-of-war. As Susan Harrow has astutely observed, this categorical, conservative view situates Zola as a confirmed Realist-Naturalist whilst Flaubert's modernity allows the author of *Madame Bovary* and *Bouvard et Pécuchet* to be read forwards (by Sarraute or Robbe-Grillet).[1] We may prefer to follow Deleuze's extraordinary analysis (he is speaking of film and of the relationship of Stroheim, whose *Greed* is an adaptation of one of the greatest of American naturalist novels, to Buñuel)[2]: where the opening of the social and the uncharted exploration of its "lower depths" ("*flectere si nequeo superos*") leaves the psyche exposed to seismic tremors and eruptions from the unconscious. It is precisely of such openings and possibilities that we have to speak here.

[1] Susan Harrow, *Zola: The Body Modern: Pressures and Prospects of Representation*, London: Legenda, 2012, 3.

[2] Gilles Deleuze, *Cinéma I*, Paris: Minuit, 1983. See chapter 8, "De l'affet à l'action."

Famously, and one may even say notoriously, Zola organized his multivolume project around the pseudo-scientific notion of "tainted heredity," going so far as to establish elaborate genealogical charts of his characters and their relationships from book to book. Here we find most tangibly the survival of that "mark of destiny" which defined the récit, a biographical framework (shared by the other novelists of the period) which has however here been melodramatically intensified into an extravagant sense of impending doom (doing double-duty for the usual naturalist pessimism). We will here, however, see this less as a regression into some older Hugolian if not Gothic excess, than a unique form taken by the temporality of destiny when it is drawn into the force field of affect and distorted out of recognition by the latter. It will indeed even be possible to show that the pseudo-scientific doctrine of heredity Zola articulates in his final volume (the discovery of Dr. Pascal) is itself an affective schema. Meanwhile, the melodramatic endings and climaxes that regularly terminate these novels foretell, *a contrario* and as a kind of anticipatory compensation, the dissolution of the compact between chronology and the present that makes realism possible in the first place, and thereby signals the crisis of plot which has regularly been taken to spell the end of realism as such: in that, Zola's endings play out what will later become the dialectic of mass culture, as in contemporary action film and its specific "end of temporality."

Yet it is important to remember that our interest in affect lies primarily in the combinations it forms with the longer-range temporalities of storytelling, of récit and of destiny. Indeed, everything that is admirable and productive in Zola to this effect can also be judged as a shameless exploitation and manipulation of poetic perception that has been harnessed to a commercial project and that scarcely merits the "distinction" of the literary in the first place (whence Zola's endemic exclusion from the canon).

It is precisely this skill in the utilization of his raw materials that the word "codification" is meant more neutrally to designate. Still, even that exploitation, and the very properties of his remarkable new raw material, has had to be learned; and the earlier novels of the Rougon-Macquart series testify to the stages of this process.

It is perhaps in the second and third novels in the series, *La Curée* (1871) and *Le ventre de Paris* (1873), that the registration of affect as such begins its work. The first novel of the series (1840), which sets the political stage as such with Louis Napoleon's coup d'état and

its provincial equivalents, was still written under the Empire and thus still bears the traces of a satiric exposé and denunciation. *La Curée* itself is begun in the same spirit; but with the Franco-Prussian war and the abrupt collapse of the Empire as such, Zola is able to change his focus: few writers, indeed, have had this kind of luck, where History obligingly redistributes your material for you in a more workable form.

Zola's investigation now has closure, and a different kind of experimental spirit takes the place of the older, politically committed one. Now the viruses of the Empire may be allowed to develop autonomously, in their own local petri dishes and according to their own specificities; the laboratory itself is now sealed, we have to do with a historical settlement and not a partisan struggle. It is in this new space of "observation" (to speak for a moment the language of Zola's scientistic rhetoric) that the resonances of affect will be registered.

Yet this registration begins modestly enough with simpler exercises in perception, about which this is the moment to observe that it is itself no more affect than named emotion was. Perception is still a concept located within the subject/object split, it is a rationalization of the sensory and its expression a codified form of rhetoric under the rubric of description.

Affect is perhaps here present as a kind of invisible figuration, which doubles the literal invisibly; a convex that shows through, as though reality itself blushed imperceptibly, and some strange new optical illusion separated the trees from one another stereoscopically, allowing their three dimensions to be visible three-dimensionally. Such are, for example, the great opening lines of *La Terre* (1887), in which Jean plows the field, seeing his village ahead of him in one direction, and then, turning on the next furrow, the whole vast plain of the Beauce spread out before him in the other:

> Jean, qui remontait la pièce du midi au nord, avait justement devant lui, à deux kilomètres, les bâtiments de la ferme. Arrivé au bout du sillon, il leva les yeux, regarda sans voir, en soufflant une minute … Mais Jean se retourna, et il repartit, du nord au midi, avec son balancement, la main gauche tenant le semoir, la droite fouettant l'air d'un vol continu de semence. Maintenant, il avait devant lui, tout proche, coupant la plaine ainsi qu'un fossé, l'étroit vallon de l'Aigre, après lequel recommençait la Beauce, immense, jusqu'à Orléans.
>
> The farm buildings themselves lay only about a mile and a half in front of Jean as he moved up the field from the south to the north. Pausing at the end of the

furrow, he lifted his head and stared blankly as he took a breather … Jean now turned back and set off once again, this time from north to south, his left hand still holding open the bag while his right swept through the air and dispersed its cloud of seed. Directly ahead of him now lay the narrow little valley of the Aigre, cutting through the plain, while beyond it the flat lands of the Beauce began once again, their vast expanses stretching as far as Orleans.[3]

The furrows coming and going, the boustrophedon of the camera eye, giving us now the landscape, now the town, Jean as a mere servant of the apparatus. This movement has become itself so productive and creative that old-fashioned description can itself be diminished and streamlined: to describe this as cinematographic (as well as opportunistic, in the way in which it allows Zola to lay his double background in place) is already to refocus the visual in the form of the camera's figuration.

In much the same way, these early descriptions, like Gestalt images, can be taken either as rhetorical flourishes that still function allegorically as in Balzac: thus the vegetation of *La Curée*—

Pour gazon, une large bande de Sélaginelle entourait le bassin. Cette fougère naine formait un épais tapis de mousse, d'un vert tendre. Et, au-delà de la grande allée circulaire, quatre énormes massifs allaient d'un élan vigoureux jusqu'au cintre: les Palmiers, légèrement penchés dans leur grâce, épanouissaient leurs éventails, étalaient leurs têtes arrondies, laissaient pendre leurs palmes, comme des avirons lassés par leur éternel voyage dans le bleu de l'air; les grands Bambous de l'Inde montaient droits, frêles et durs, faisant tomber de haut leur pluie légère de feuilles; un Ravenala, l'arbre du voyageur, dressait son bouquet d'immenses écrans chinois; et, dans un coin, un Bananier, chargé de ses fruits, allongeait de toutes parts ses longues feuilles horizontales, où deux amants pourraient se coucher à l'aise en se serrant l'un contre l'autre. Aux angles, il y avait des Euphorbes d'Abyssinie, ces cierges épineux, contrefaits, pleins de bosses honteuses, suant le poison. Et, sous les arbres, pour couvrir le sol, des fougères basses, les Adiantums, les Ptérides, mettaient leurs dentelles délicates, leurs fines découpures. Les Alsophilas, d'espèce plus haute, étageaient leurs rangs de rameaux symétriques, sexangulaires, si réguliers, qu'on aurait dit de grandes pièces de faïence destinées à contenir les fruits de quelque dessert gigantesque. Puis, une bordure de Bégonias et de Caladiums entourait les massifs; les Bégonias, à feuilles torses, tachées superbement de vert et de rouge; les Caladiums, dont les feuilles en fer de lance, blanches et à nervures vertes, ressemblent à de larges ailes de papillon; plantes bizarres dont le feuillage vit étrangement, avec un éclat sombre ou pâlissant de fleurs malsaines. (II, 354–5)

[3] French notes are referenced in the text to the five volume Gallimard/La Pléiade edition of Zola (1960–1967), as here: IV, 367–8. English translation mine.

By way of turf, a broad edging of selaginella encircled the tank. This dwarf fern formed a thick mossy carpet of light green. Beyond the great circular path, four enormous clusters of plants shot up to the roof: palms, drooping gently in their elegance, spreading their fans, displayed their rounded crowns, hung down their leaves like oars wearied by their perpetual voyage through the blue; tall Indian bamboos rose upwards, hard, slender, dropping from on high their light shower of leaves; a ravenala, the traveller's tree, erected its foliage like enormous Chinese screens; and in a corner a banana tree, loaded with fruit, stretched out on all sides its long horizontal leaves, on which two lovers might easily recline in each other's arms. In the corners were Abyssinian euphorbias, deformed prickly cactuses covered with hideous excrescences, oozing with poison. Beneath the trees the ground was carpeted with creeping ferns, adianta and pterides, their fronds outlined daintily like fine lace. Alsophilas of a taller species tapered upwards with their rows of symmetrical branches, hexagonal, so regular that they looked like large pieces of porcelain made specially for the fruit of some gigantic dessert. The shrubs were surrounded by a border of begonias and caladiums: begonias with twisted leaves, gorgeously streaked with red and green; caladiums whose spear-headed leaves, white with green veins, looked like large butterfly wings; bizarre plants whose foliage lives strangely, with the somber or wan splendor of poisonous flowers. [4]

—flora and fauna which can be taken as signs of the sickness of the Second Empire, the morbidity or indeed decadence of its social relations, whose properly abnormal growths (happily paralleling the efflorescence of the tainted heredity of Zola's two conjoined families) stand as a culture critique of this political and economic system; or else it begins to foreground new kinds of perceptions, whose microscopic convexities now serve as vehicles for affect itself.

This is perhaps then the place to say a word about the famous "pathetic fallacy" denounced by New Criticism, which rightly deplored the facile use of an external nature—even though the key text is the storm on the heath in *King Lear*—to express the emotions raging within the protagonist.[5] But they were talking about the expression of named emotions, that is to say, the aesthetic of expression as such;

[4] *The Kill*, trans. Brian Nelson, Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004, 37.

[5] Ruskin's original concept (*Modern Painters*, Volume III, chapter 12) seems to have had more to do with the mendacity of artificial tropes, more spontaneous outbursts being tolerated. He deplores the subject-object split, but on the other hand wishes to preserve objectivity and accurate observation. Perhaps it would be better in this context to suggest that the manifestations of affect, whatever they are, are not tropological. (*Lear* is a New Critical importation, but see W. K. Wimsatt and Monroe Beardsley, "The Affective Fallacy," in *The Norton Anthology of Theory and Criticism*, Vincent Leitsch, ed., New York: Norton, 2001, 1246–61.)

and in our context here we might reverse their judgement and suggest that what is poetically inauthentic in traditional "pathetic fallacy" is not so much its illicit use of nature as its presupposition of named emotions as such, which reacts back on the former to endow it with those "meanings" we found in Balzacian description, that is to say, a signifying system and no longer really a physical perception at all.

But Zola discovers his own narrative space with the third novel of the Rougon-Macquart, *Le ventre de Paris*. The opening novel laid the political situation in place with Louis Bonaparte's coup d'etat; the second, *La Curée*, was a relatively didactic exposé of the corruption of the Second Empire—corruption in sexuality (incest), corruption in money (gentrification), even corruption in botany (exotic, dangerous tropical plants) and corruption in architecture (Saccard's "palace"), etc. The problem is that all of these richly explored dimensions, when juxtaposed, simply give off the univocal meaning of the hieroglyph (or ideogram) for "corruption." In other words, as in Balzac, they still mean something, no matter how rich their sensory overload.

With *Le ventre de Paris*, that excess of the sensory becomes autonomous, that is to say, it begins to have enough weight of its own to counterbalance the plot, it begins to fill its function as affect calculated to stand in a successful tension with the belief in "destiny" to which Zola is also committed. (Yet we will see later on how the theory of heredity itself subtly and not so subtly inflects the pole of destiny and makes of it a sensory and bodily form as well, susceptible to all kinds of affective investment, as though it were precisely affect that had a destiny of its own...).

Obviously, the very project of a novel on Les Halles (begun in 1854) originated spatially (*La Curée* centered on a villa, with the new Haussman quarter not yet fully built; while *La Fortune de Rougon* turned on a whole national region), and thus of itself proposed description, landscape painting, and with the multiplicity of vegetables and edible objects, a variety of strokes, colors, textures and smells. To these meanwhile Zola has added time itself, the time of day, the nighttime in which its produce is brought to Les Halles, slowly lightening into the dawn when the market opens. He has in other words had to "set it in motion" à la Monet, thereby also adding the jolts of the cart through the darkness as the farmers laboriously bring their produce to market. All of this would make for a transformation of description into action—indeed, it may be said that if it is a question of technique, in the reified cut-and-dried meaning of that term,

then it is precisely this transformation which is Zola's method and his discovery.[6] Balzac made everything stop until he was finished, first his laborious descriptions, and second, his account of the past history of his characters. Zola has not developed a means for innovating with the latter—he will still interpolate lengthy flashbacks or récits—but the former he has completely revolutionized, bringing all his narrative intelligence to bear on the problem of "exposition," as the great dramatists from Molière to Ibsen faced that technical difficulty.[7] Still, there the second problem remained, that of the past of the characters and their situations. Now it is ekphrasis, which demands planning something like a camera movement through the object world, so that *attention to each item* is motivated, as in early film.

Yet with *Le ventre de Paris*, we are not quite at that point, and Zola still seems to need a point of view; indeed, it is, at least in part, of the very notion of point of view that we will be speaking here and throughout this theory of realism, speaking of it not only as a technique but also as a concept, indeed as something like a technique-concept (the film-theory version of camera agency will have autonomized and reified some of this ambiguity), and finally as an ideology; but in any case not as some empirical common-sense datum on the order of the eyes of bodily daily life. That obvious phenomenological reality will have first had to be made strange, to be differentiated (autonomization means that as well), somehow separated out from the existence we take for granted, only in order then to be added back in as a specific and ideologized technique.

What Zola does here, however, is something a little more complex and extraordinary than simple Jamesian point of view. James might have argued that Zola was still insufficiently aware of point of view as a technical problem and necessity, and allowed himself the slovenliness of all the other omniscient narrators, without realizing that Zola's shrewdness with respect to point of view had just taken on another, more psychoanalytic form.

Thus, to the degree to which description sheds its allegorical

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[6] This might be the argument to make in the face of Lukács' opposition of the active and temporal, profoundly historical virtue of narration as opposed to what is static and contemplative in description (an argument by virtue of which the great Hungarian philosopher is able to condemn naturalism and symbolism alike, and to devalue Zola in the face of Balzac). See note 8, "Introduction."

[7] Goethe thought the opening of Molière's *Tartuffe* was the most dramatic and successful exposition in the history of dramatic literature.

meanings and approaches the state of a more purely physical and bodily registering of external contingency, to that extent it lies open to affective investment. Such is now the case with the opening chapters of *Le ventre de Paris*, a novel set in the old Les Halles now newly constructed, and into which the protagonist arrives by night, as if parachuted ex nihilo by the great carts which provision the enormous market before the dawn.

Here Florent will confront a chaotic multiplicity of goods organized according to their species with much the same engineering sensibility Zola himself brought to his subjects (to each novel, a specialty or a specialization—the railroad, disease, painting, the stock market, etc.). Immense quantities of objects are collected and enumerated for us (under the pretext of Florent's new position as inspector):

> Quand il déboucha dans la grande rue du milieu, il songea à quelque ville étrange, avec ses quartiers distincts, ses faubourgs, ses villages, ses promenades et ses routes, ses places et ses carrefours, mise tout entière sous un hangar, un jour de pluie, par quelque caprice gigantesque. (I, 621)
>
> As he turned into the broad central avenue, he imagined himself in some foreign town, with its various districts, suburbs, villages, walks and streets, squares and intersections, all suddenly placed under a huge roof one rainy day by the whim of some gigantic power.[8]

As with animation or miniaturization, this unification redeems the bewildering and contingent chaos of the immense commercial center by suggesting that it has been constructed by a single intelligence (like a miniature train set).

And it is always worth emphasizing the degree to which such apparently static catalogues and enumerations are symbolic forms of praxis and of construction, invisibly harboring the work of the hand itself in some more fundamentally physical sense than the autoreferential imagination of its writer.

Yet a bewildering multiplicity returns within this rational organization: masses of vegetables first (627), then the heaps of edible flesh and blood, Quenu's storehouse of dairy products, sausages and sausage-making, and finally, in a kind of delirious climax, the world of seafood (697) in which the category of fish differentiates into pages of monsters and weird otherworldly beings:

[8] *The Belly of Paris*, trans. Brian Nelson, Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2007, 20.

> Pêle-mêle, au hasard du coup de filet, les algues profondes, où dort la vie mystérieuse des grandes eaux, avaient tout livré: les cabillauds, les aigrefins, les carrelets, les plies, les limandes, bêtes communes, d'un gris sale, aux taches blanchâtres; les congres, ces grosses couleuvres d'un bleu de vase, aux minces yeux noirs, si gluantes qu'elles semblent ramper, vivantes encore; les raies élargies, à ventre pâle bordé de rouge tendre, dont les dos superbes, allongeant les noeuds saillants de l'échine, se marbrent, jusqu'aux baleines tendues des nageoires, de plaques de cinabre coupées par des zébrures de bronze florentin, d'une bigarrure assombrie de crapaud et de fleur malsaine; les chiens de mer, horribles, avec leurs têtes rondes, leurs bouches largement fendues d'idoles chinoises, leurs courtes ailes de chauves-souris charnues, monstres qui doivent garder de leurs abois les trésors des grottes marines. Puis, venaient les beaux poissons, isolés, un sur chaque plateau d'osier: les saumons, d'argent guilloché, dont chaque écaille semble un coup de burin dans le poli du métal; les mulets, d'écailles plus fortes, de ciselures plus grossières; les grands turbots, les grandes barbues, d'un grain serré et blanc comme du lait caillé; les thons, lisses et vernis, pareils à des sacs de cuir noirâtre; les bars arrondis, ouvrant une bouche énorme, faisant songer à quelque âme trop grosse, rendue à pleine gorge, dans la stupéfaction de l'agonie. Et, de toutes parts, les soles, par paires, grises ou blondes, pullulaient; les équilles minces, raidies, ressemblaient à des rognures d'étain; les harengs, légèrement tordus, montraient tous, sur leurs robes lamées, la meurtrissure de leurs ouïes saignantes; les dorades grasses se teintaient d'une pointe de carmin, tandis que les maquereaux, dorés, le dos strié de brunissures verdâtres, faisaient luire la nacre changeante de leurs flancs, et que les grondins roses, à ventres blancs, les têtes rangées au centre des mannes, les queues rayonnantes, épanouissaient d'étranges floraisons, panachées de blanc de perle et de vermillon vif. Il y avait encore des rougets de roche, à la chair exquise, du rouge enluminé des cyprins, des caisses de merlans aux reflets d'opale, des paniers d'éperlans, de petits paniers propres, jolis comme des paniers de fraises, qui laissaient échapper une odeur puissante de violette. Cependant, les crevettes roses, les crevettes grises, dans des bourriches, mettaient, au milieu de la douceur effacée de leurs tas, les imperceptibles boutons de jais de leurs milliers d'yeux; les langoustes épineuses, les homards tigrés de noir, vivants encore, se traînant sur leurs pattes cassées, craquaient. (I, 697–8).

> The seaweed that lies on the ocean bed where the mysteries of the deep lie sleeping had jumbled everything into the sweep of the net: cod, haddock, flounder, plaice, dabs, and other sorts of common fish in dirty grey spotted with white; conger eels, huge snake-like creatures, with small, black eyes and muddy, bluish skins, so slimy that they seemed to be still alive and gliding along; broad flat skate, their pale underbellies edged with a soft red, their superb backs, bumpy with vertebrae, marbled to the very tips of the bones in their fins, in sulphur-red patches cut across by stripes of Florentine bronze, a sombre assortment of colours from filthy toad to poisonous flower; dogfish, with hideous round heads, gaping mouths like Chinese idols, and short fins like bats' wings, monsters who doubtless kept guard over the treasures of the ocean grottoes. Then there were the finer fish,

> displayed individually on wicker trays: salmon, gleaming like chased silver, whose every scale seemed to have been exquisitely chiselled on highly polished metal; mullet, with larger scales and coarser markings; huge turbot and brill, their scales pure white and closely knit like curdled milk; tuna fish, smooth and glossy, like bags of black leather; and rounded bass, with gaping mouths, as if some outsize spirit, at the moment of death, had forced its way out of the surprised creatures' bodies. Everywhere there were soles, grey or pale yellow, heaped in pairs; sand eels, thin and stiff, like shavings of pewter; herrings, slightly twisted, with bleeding gills showing on their silver-worked skins; fat bream, tinged with crimson; golden mackerel, their backs stained with greenish brown markings, their sides shimmering like mother-of-pearl; and pink gurnet with white bellies, placed with their heads together in the middle of the baskets and their tails fanned out, so that they seemed like strange flowers in a bloom of pearly white and brilliant scarlet. There were red rock mullet, too, with their exquisite flesh; boxes of whiting, like opal reflections in a mirror; and baskets of smelt—neat little baskets as pretty as punnets of strawberries and giving off a strong smell of violets. The tiny jet-black eyes of the prawns, in covered baskets, were like thousands of beads scattered across the piles of soft-toned pink and grey; the spiky lobsters and crayfish, striped with black and still alive, were dragging themselves about on their broken legs.[9]

What seems crucial here is the relationship between the perceptual and language or naming. It would appear at first glance, and in the light of Zola's remarkable organizational procedures, that what is at stake here is a resolution of multiplicity back into unity, of difference back into identity. The enormous lists and catalogues would seem to be subsumed under generic categories and everyday commonsense universals: from life to the edible, from the edible to plants and animals, from the latter to meats and fish, and so on. In fact, I believe that this impression is at the least ambiguous; and that simultaneously with this first centrifugal movement of mastery and subsumption, of the ordering of raw nameless things into their proper genetic classifications, there exists a second movement which undermines this one and secretly discredits it—a tremendous fermenting and bubbling pullulation in which the simplicity of words and names is unsettled to the point of an ecstatic dizziness by the visual multiplicity of the things themselves and the sensations that they press on the unforewarned observer. The unexpected result is that far from enriching representational language with all kinds of new meanings, the gap between words and things is heightened; perceptions turn into sensations; words no longer take on a body at prey to its nameless

[9] Ibid., 91.

experience. Finally the realm of the visual begins to separate from that of the verbal and conceptual and to float away in a new kind of autonomy. Precisely this autonomy will create the space for affect: just as the gradual enfeeblement of named emotions and the words for them opened up a new space in which the unrepresentable and unnameable affects can colonize and make their own.

But this autonomy is itself subject to imminent dissolution from both sides at once. For language (and conceptualization) rises to the challenge, and matches this new proliferation of beings by a differentiation that generates ever newer generic categories, themselves quickly filled and subsequently overwhelmed by the sensory. Thus the world of marine life is multiplied (not to speak of the opposition between fresh water and salt water fish as such), and expands through the crustaceans to the eels and so on and so forth. At the same time, as though by the very force of its intensifying multiplicities, it generates a new and autonomous realm of the sensory alongside itself, namely that of Odor, so that Florent begins to have in his very body the lived experience of Baudelairean synesthesia, whose specificity lies in the ambiguity of separation and identification. Does it combine the senses or rather affirm the coming into being of a new and heightened sense in which they are combined? And even this new experience of the nausea of a dizzying continuity of smells whose apprenticeship he makes in his new domain as the inspector of the fish market will reach a rather different climax in the subterranean world of the cheeses.

But in order to appreciation the new autonomization of the sensory as it here first emerges in Zola, we must first note a significant displacement in what will later on be called point of view (as well as in the protagonicity it marks and certifies). Florent is of course the nominal hero of the novel: a demonstrator against the regime of Louis Philippe, he has been arrested and shipped off to the penal colony in Cayenne (Devil's Island)—a *séjour* whose memories mark the intrusion of a flora and fauna even more exotic than Renée's plants, but less amenable to Utopian reorganization than the levant of Saccard's daydreams in *L'Argent*. He escapes, after eight years, and returning to Paris, offers a double defamiliarization for reader and writer alike: first, because he recognizes nothing any more, and second, because there is nothing he can recognize owing to the prodigious transformation of Paris begun by Haussman (and memorialized by Baudelaire), in which the construction of Les Halles is a functional centerpiece.

So far so good, and this is a trope readily available even to the most inexperienced would-be novelist (the Persian visit, as it were).

But to this mediatory outsider's point of view, Zola adds a Virgil: it is the painter Claude Lantier, himself an authentic member of the eponymous Macquart clan (he is the son of the ill-fated Gervaise of *L'Assommoir* [1878], the later novel whose success will precipitate Zola into the front ranks of the literary world, and later on the protagonist of a novel of his own [*L'Oeuvre* (1886)] based on Zola's childhood friendship with Cézanne.)

To be sure, Zola did not have the benefit of later Jamesian statutes on the proper use of point of view, and there is a deplorable, or opportunistic, and at least wholly unregulated displacement of the narrative center from one participant to another in all of Zola's novels. But this particular doubling of perception, in which the aesthetic perspective of the painter does not replace that of the explorer-protagonist, but rather imperceptibly slips in beside it, in a kind of stereoscopic view which is no doubt initially multi-dimensional, but which, we will argue, ultimately tends to release its sensory material from any specific viewer or individual human subject, from any specific character to whom the function of observation has been assigned.

Florent is the ideal of the Russian Formalist reader: for him everything is estranged, partly because he has never seen this unique quartier of Paris before (for the obvious reason that it did not then exist, something which would seem to render the evocation of the *ostranenie*, or making strange of habitual objects, less relevant); but also partly because he has not been among people for a long time, and particularly not in cities, nor, above all, in the kind of milling, asphyxiating crowd he here encounters, with its welter of noises and smells (of which more later). His is thus the privileged point of perception for the onslaught of raw sensation, for sheer intensity.

Claude meanwhile brings the painterly eye to this confusion; it is the era of Zola's defense of Manet and of nascent impressionism, and we may assume that Claude's eye tends to master its material in analogous fashion. It would then be tempting to assume that Florent brings the raw material which Claude then organizes in ways propitious for Zola's descriptive practice (which is prodigious and voracious).

And this seems to me a significant, experimental moment in Zola's approach to affect, and a preparation for the later and more programmatic exercises in the sensory sublime, as when that blissful white

of the tableclothes and sheets which we have evoked in the previous chapter is in *Au Bonheur des Dames* (1883) whipped into a frenzy by the inventor of the new department store (himself obviously a surrogate for the novelist and inventor of the new literary series) into masses of white intensities which stagger the patrons and rivalize with one another like repeated orchestral tutti, each one distinct, each one the same:

> Ce qui arrêtait ces dames, c'était le spectacle prodigieux de la grande exposition de blanc. Autour d'elles, d'abord, il y avait le vestibule, un hall aux glaces claires, pavé de mosaïques, où les étalages à bas prix retenaient la foule vorace. Ensuite, les galeries s'enfonçaient, dans une blancheur éclatante, une échappée boréale, toute une contrée de neige, déroulant l'infini des steppes tendues d'hermine, l'entassement des glaciers allumés sous le soleil. On retrouvait le blanc des vitrines du dehors, mais avivé, colossal, brûlant d'un bout à l'autre de l'énorme vaisseau, avec la flambée blanche d'un incendie en plein feu. Rien que du blanc, tous les articles blancs de chaque rayon, une débauche de blanc, un astre blanc dont le rayonnement fixe aveuglait d'abord, sans qu'on pût distinguer les détails, au milieu de cette blancheur unique. Bientôt les yeux s'accoutumaient: à gauche, la galerie Monsigny allongeait les promontoires blancs des toiles et des calicots, les roches blanches des draps de lit, des serviettes, des mouchoirs; tandis que la galerie Michodière, à droite, occupée par la mercerie, la bonneterie et les lainages, exposait des constructions blanches en boutons de nacre, un grand décor bâti avec des chaussettes blanches, toute une salle recouverte de molleton blanc, éclairée au loin d'un coup de lumière. Mais le foyer de clarté rayonnait surtout de la galerie centrale, aux rubans et aux fichus, à la ganterie et à la soie. Les comptoirs disparaissaient sous le blanc des soies et des rubans, des gants et des fichus. Autour des colonnettes de fer, s'élevaient des bouillonnés de mousseline blanche, noués de place en place par des foulards blancs. Les escaliers étaient garnis de draperies blanches, des draperies de piqué et de basin alternées, qui filaient le long des rampes, entouraient les halls, jusqu'au second étage; et cette montée du blanc prenait des ailes, se pressait et se perdait, comme une envolée de cygnes. Puis, le blanc retombait des voûtes, une tombée de duvet, une nappe neigeuse en larges flocons: des couvertures blanches, des couvre-pieds blancs, battaient l'air, accrochés, pareils à des bannières d'église; de longs jets de guipure traversaient, semblaient suspendre des essaims de papillons blancs, au bourdonnement immobile; des dentelles frissonnaient de toutes parts, flottaient comme des fils de la Vierge par un ciel d'été, emplissaient l'air de leur haleine blanche. Et la merveille, l'autel de cette religion du blanc, était, au-dessus du comptoir des soieries, dans le grand hall, une tente faite de rideaux blancs, qui descendaient du vitrage. Les mousselines, les gazes, les guipures d'art, coulaient à flots légers, pendant que des tulles brodés, très riches, et des pièces de soie orientale, lamées d'argent, servaient de fond à cette décoration géante, qui tenait du tabernacle et de l'alcôve. On aurait dit un grand lit blanc, dont l'énormité virginale attendait, comme dans les

légendes, la princesse blanche, celle qui devait venir un jour, toute-puissante, avec le voile blanc des épousées. (I, 768–9)

It was the stupendous sight of the great exhibition of household linen which had caused the ladies to stop. First of all, surrounding them, there was the entrance hall, with bright mirrors, and paved with mosaics, in which displays of inexpensive goods were drawing the voracious crowd. Then there were the galleries, dazzling in their whiteness like a polar vista, a snowy expanse unfolding with the endlessness of steppes draped with ermine, a mass of glaciers lit up beneath the sun. It was the same whiteness as that displayed in the outside windows, but heightened and on a colossal scale, burning from one end of the enormous nave to the other with the white blaze of a conflagration at its height. There was nothing but white, all the white goods from every department, an orgy of white, a white star whose radiance was blinding at first, and made it impossible to distinguish any details in the midst of this total whiteness. Soon the eye grew accustomed to it: to the left in the Monsigny Gallery there stretched out white promontories of linens and calicoes, white rocks of sheets, table-napkins, and handkerchiefs; while in the Michodière Gallery on the right, occupied by the haberdashery, hosiery, and woollens, white edifices were displayed made of pearl buttons, together with a huge construction of white socks, and a whole hall covered with white swansdown and illuminated by a distant shaft of light. But the light was especially bright in the central gallery, where the ribbons and fichus, gloves and silks were situated. The counters disappeared beneath the white of silks and ribbons, of gloves and fichus. Around the iron pillars were twined flounces of white muslin, knotted here and there with white scarves. The staircases were decked with white draperies, draperies of piqué alternating with dimity, running the whole length of the banisters and encircling the halls right up to the second floor; and the ascending whiteness appeared to take wing, merging together and disappearing like a flight of swans. The whiteness then fell back again from the domes in a rain of eiderdown, a sheet of huge snowflakes: white blankets and white coverlets were waving in the air, hung up like banners in a church; long streams of pillow-lace seemed suspended like swarms of white butterflies, humming there motionless; other types of lace were fluttering everywhere, floating like a gossamer against a summer sky, filling the air with their white breath. And over the silk counter in the main hall there was the miracle, the altar of this cult of white—a tent made of white curtains hanging down from the glass roof. Muslin, gauzes, and guipures flowed in light ripples, while richly embroidered tulles and lengths of oriental silk and silver lamé served as a background to this gigantic decoration, which was evocative both of the tabernacle and of the bedroom. It looked like a great white bed, its virginal whiteness waiting, as in legends, for the white princess, for she who would one day come, all powerful, in her white bridal veil.[10]

[10] *The Ladies' Paradise*, trans. Brian Nelson, Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1995, 397–8.

But here, for the moment, in *Le ventre de Paris*, we are merely being trained in this new sensorium, forming new habits of perception in accordance with the new realms and dimensions of bodily reality thereby opened up to us.

We now need no intermediaries in this novel ontological exploration, and characters become the most perfunctory pretexts for what is virtually an autonomous unfolding of sense data, as in the virtuoso chapter on the cheeses, in which the two hostile observers, Mme. Lecoeur and the conniving Mlle. Saget exchange their gossip about Florent and his criminal past in the underground storeroom of the former's dairy shop:

– Vous savez, ce Florent ?... Eh bien, je peux vous dire d'où il vient, maintenant.
Et elle les laissa un instant encore suspendues à ses lèvres.
– Il vient du bagne, dit-elle enfin, en assourdissant terriblement sa voix.
Autour d'elles, les fromages puaient. Sur les deux étagères de la boutique, au fond, s'alignaient des mottes de beurre énormes; les beurres de Bretagne, dans des paniers, débordaient; les beurres de Normandie, enveloppés de toile, ressemblaient à des ébauches de ventres, sur lesquelles un sculpteur aurait jeté des linges mouillés; d'autres mottes, entamées, taillées par les larges couteaux en rochers à pic, pleines de vallons et de cassures, étaient comme des cimes éboulées, dorées par la pâleur d'un soir d'automne. Sous la table d'étalage, de marbre rouge veiné de gris, des paniers d'oeufs mettaient une blancheur de craie; et, dans des caisses, sur des clayons de paille, des bondons posés bout à bout, des gournays rangés à plat comme des médailles, faisaient des nappes plus sombres, tachées de tons verdâtres. Mais c'était surtout sur la table que les fromages s'empilaient. Là, à côté des pains de beurre à la livre, dans des feuilles de poirée, s'élargissait un cantal géant, comme fendu à coups de hache; puis venaient un chester, couleur d'or, un gruyère, pareil à une roue tombée de quelque char barbare, des hollandes, ronds comme des têtes coupées, barbouillées de sang séché, avec cette dureté de crâne vide qui les fait nommer têtes-de-mort. Un parmesan, au milieu de cette lourdeur de pâte cuite, ajoutait sa pointe d'odeur aromatique. Trois bries, sur des planches rondes, avaient des mélancolies de lunes éteintes; deux, très secs, étaient dans leur plein; le troisième, dans son deuxième quartier, coulait, se vidait d'une crème blanche, étalée en lac, ravageant les minces planchettes, à l'aide desquelles on avait vainement essayé de le contenir. Des port-salut, semblables à des disques antiques, montraient en exergue le nom imprimé des fabricants. Un romantour, vêtu de son papier d'argent, donnait le rêve d'une barre de nougat, d'un fromage sucré, égaré parmi ces fermentations âcres. Les roqueforts, eux aussi, sous des cloches de cristal, prenaient des mines princières, des faces marbrées et grasses, veinées de bleu et de jaune, comme attaqués d'une maladie honteuse de gens riches qui ont trop mangé de truffes; tandis que, dans un plat, à côté, des fromages de chèvre, gros comme un poing d'enfant, durs et grisâtres, rappelaient

les cailloux que les boucs, menant leur troupeau, font rouler aux coudes des sentiers pierreux. Alors, commençaient les puanteurs: les mont-d'or, jaune clair, puant une odeur douceâtre; les troyes, très épais, meurtris sur les bords, d'âpreté déjà plus forte, ajoutant une fétidité de cave humide; les camemberts, d'un fumet de gibier trop faisandé; les neufchâtels, les limbourgs, les marolles, les pont-l'évêque, carrés, mettant chacun leur note aiguë et particulière dans cette phrase rude jusqu'à la nausée; les livarots, teintés de rouge, terribles à la gorge comme une vapeur de soufre; puis enfin, par-dessus tous les autres, les olivets, enveloppés de feuilles de noyer, ainsi que ces charognes que les paysans couvrent de branches, au bord d'un champ, fumantes au soleil. La chaude après-midi avait amolli les fromages; les moisissures des croûtes fondaient, se vernissaient avec des tons riches de cuivre rouge et de vert-de-gris, semblables à des blessures mal fermées; sous les feuilles de chêne, un souffle soulevait la peau des olivets, qui battait comme une poitrine, d'une haleine lente et grosse d'homme endormi; un flot de vie avait troué un livarot, accouchant par cette entaille d'un peuple de vers. Et, derrière les balances, dans sa boîte mince, un géromé anisé répandait une infection telle que des mouches étaient tombées autour de la boîte, sur le marbre rouge veiné de gris. (I, 826–8)

All around them the cheeses were stinking. On the two shelves at the back of the stall were huge blocks of butter: Brittany butter overflowing its baskets; Normandy butter wrapped in cloth, looking like models of bellies on to which a sculptor had thrown some wet rags; other blocks, already cut into and looking like high rocks full of valleys and crevices. Under the display counter of red marble veined with grey, baskets of eggs shone like white chalk; while on layers of straw in boxes were *bondons* placed end to end, and *gournays* arranged like medals, forming darker patches tinted with green. But for the most part the cheeses stood in piles on the table. There, next to the one-pound packs of butter, a gigantic *cantal* was spread on leaves of white beet, as though split by blows from an axe; then came a golden Cheshire cheese, a *gruyère* like a wheel fallen from some barbarian chariot, some Dutch cheeses suggesting decapitated heads smeared in dried blood and as hard as skulls—which has earned them the name of "death's heads." A *parmesan* added its aromatic tang to the thick, dull smell of the others. Three *bries*, on round boards, looked like melancholy moons. Two of them, very dry, were at the full; the third, in its second quarter, was melting away in a white cream, which had spread into a pool and flowed over the thin boards that had been put there in an attempt to hold it in check. Some *port-salut*, shaped like ancient discuses, bore the printed names of their makers. A *romantour* in silver paper suggested a bar of nougat or some sweet cheese which had strayed into this realm of bitter fermentations. The *roqueforts*, too, under their glass covers, had a princely air, their fat faces veined in blue and yellow, like the victims of some shameful disease common to rich people who have eaten too many truffles; while on a dish next to them stood the *fromages de chèvre*, about the size of a child's fist, hard and grey like the pebbles which the rams send rolling down stony paths as they lead their flock. Then came the strong-smelling cheeses: the *mont-d'ors*, pale yellow, with a mild sugary smell; the

troyes, very thick and bruised at the edges, much stronger, smelling like a damp cellar; the *camemberts*, suggesting high game; the *neufchâtels*, the *limbourgs*, the *marolles*, the *pont-l'évèques*, each adding its own shrill note in a phrase that was harsh to the point of nausea; the *livarots*, tinted red, as irritating to the throat as sulphur fumes; and finally, stronger than all the others, the *olivets*, wrapped in walnut leaves, like the carcasses of animals which peasants cover with branches as they lie rotting in the hedgerow under the blazing sun. The warm afternoon had softened the cheeses; the mould on the rinds was melting and glazing over with the rich colours of red copper verdigris, like wounds that have badly healed; under the oak leaves, a breeze lifted the skin of the *olivets*, which seemed to move up and down with the slow deep breathing of a man asleep. A *livarot* was swarming with life; and behind the scales a *géromé* flavoured with aniseed gave off such a pestilential smell that all around it flies had dropped dead on the marble slab.[11]

The multiplicity comes before us not as things or visible objects but rather as names, it is the alien guts and insides of the words themselves that are overwhelmingly juxtaposed and arrayed against us in such catalogues, which are very far from expressing their original Whitmanian gusto. Here perhaps the Sartrean opposition between centrifugal and centripetal poetics has its relevance, the Whitman lists and catalogues being at one and the same time the explosion of the self, inhaling its impossibly large breath and appropriating the outside world itself, and yet at one and the same time making that world object by object a little like Fichte's big bang of the first Subject producing a universe of objectivity outside of itself. Here, however, the world multiplies and pullulates over against the observing subject, delirious from the cascading names as they begin to translate themselves into infinite space itself. Certainly the Flaubertian delectation with the weirdest stones and ritual jewelry from antiquity—leaving its traces in Huysmans and Wilde and a truly decadent fin de siècle—has somehow released this orgiastic compilation, but without any of Flaubert's morbidity or the antiquarian and perverse spirit in which he revels in the past and its grotesque documents. That peculiar taste has suddenly left Zola free in the present to collect the names of our own richly commercial and exploratory world in a present open to the senses.

Yet names are not enough, and now the piles and well-nigh infinite variety of commodities find their way into the other senses at the same time that they borrow their distinct temporalities, and along with smell, a sonorous dimension appears which reorganizes

[11] *The Belly of Paris*, 210–11.

the trajectory of the eye into the temporality of something which is neither noise nor music, neither the deafening sound-pollution of the crowd all around us, nor the fragile path of an instrument pursuing its unfamiliar course towards an unknown note which can never be the last word.

We must then here distinguish two distinct allegorical levels: the sensory one, in reality itself multiple, which is necessary in order to endow the inert multiplicity of these material things—fish or cheeses—with their appropriate intensities; and then the parallel with the gossiping women, for whom the multiplicity all around them is in fact the multiplicity of Rumor itself, as it sends its horde of messages and distortions into an outside world as vast as outer space. The object world cannot immediately parallel the drama of human exchange, in which Florent's past and state crimes, his politics and his unavowable exile, will come to light, like a bad smell whose origins become apparent. Rather, as the theorists of film theory have suggested, from Eisler to Marie-Claire Ropars, there must be an essential disjunction of the image and the sound track, no longer to be considered as background music or voice-over, but rather in its semi-autonomy to be counterpointed with the visible events, syncopated with them as Gertrude Stein says about drama, either a little too early or a little too late.

So it is that this delirious multiplicity, itself already animated by figures and metaphors of all kinds, will now, from its status as a kind of background music, sonorous, from silent partner in the "vile" drama of gossip and incitement, become agents and actors in its own right. The sun's rays heat the cheeses, whose wafting odor passes from sight and mere visual inspection to temporality itself:

> Le soleil oblique entrait sous le pavillon, les fromages puaient plus fort. À ce moment, c'était surtout le marolles qui dominait; il jetait des bouffées puissantes, une senteur de vieille litière, dans la fadeur des mottes de beurre. Puis, le vent parut tourner; brusquement, des râles de limbourg arrivèrent entre les trois femmes, aigres et amers, comme soufflés par des gorges de mourants. (I, 829)

> The sun was slanting into the market, the cheeses stank even more. The smell of the *marolles* seemed strongest; it released powerful whiffs into the air, like the stink of stable litter. Then the wind changed, and suddenly the deathly presence of the *limbourg* struck the three women, pungent and bitter, like the last gasps of a dying man.[12]

[12] Ibid., 212.

Now the cheeses assert their individuality, and begin to struggle among each other, in a kind of odorous polyphony and dissonance:

> Le camembert, de son fumet de venaison, avait vaincu les odeurs plus sourdes du marolles et du limbourg; il élargissait ses exhalaisons, étouffait les autres senteurs sous une abondance surprenante d'haleines gâtées. Cependant, au milieu de cette phrase vigoureuse, le parmesan jetait par moments un filet mince de flûte champêtre; tandis que les bries y mettaient des douceurs fades de tambourins humides. Il y eut une reprise suffocante du livarot. Et cette symphonie se tint un moment sur une note aiguë du géromé anisé, prolongée en point d'orgue. (I, 830)

> As they were all rather short of breath by this time, it was the *camembert* they could smell. This cheese, with its gamy odour, had overpowered the milder smells of the *marolles* and the *limbourg*; its power was remarkable. Every now and then, however, a slight whiff, a flute-like note, came from the *parmesan,* while the *bries* came into play with their soft, musty smell, the gentle sound, so to speak, of a damp tambourine. The *livarot* launched into an overwhelming reprise, and the *géromé* kept up the symphony with a sustained high note.[13]

This semi-autonomous "symphony" will now begin to intervene in the toxic gossip of the old women and as it were orchestrate their machinations at the same time that it exasperates them, in a new and heightened cacophonous counterpoint:

> Elles restaient debout, se saluant, dans le bouquet final des fromages. Tous, à cette heure, donnaient à la fois. C'était une cacophonie de souffles infects, depuis les lourdeurs molles des pâtes cuites, du gruyère et du hollande, jusqu'aux pointes alcalines de l'olivet. Il y avait des ronflements sourds du cantal, du chester, des fromages de chèvre, pareils à un chant large de basse, sur lesquels se détachaient, en notes piquées, les petites fumées brusques des neufchâtels, des troyes et des mont-d'or. Puis les odeurs s'effaraient, roulaient les unes sur les autres, s'épaississaient des bouffées du Port-Salut, du limbourg, du géromé, du marolles, du livarot, du pont-l'évêque, peu à peu confondues, épanouies en une seule explosion de puanteurs. Cela s'épandait, se soutenait, au milieu du vibrement général, n'ayant plus de parfums distincts, d'un vertige continu de nausée et d'une force terrible d'asphyxie. (I, 833)

> As they stood there taking their leave of each other, the cheeses seemed to stink even more. They all seemed to stink together, in a foul cacophony: from the oppressiveness of the heavy Dutch cheeses and the *gruyères* to the sharp alkaline note of the *olivet.* From the *cantal,* Cheshire, and goat's milk came the sound of a bassoon, punctuated by the sudden, sharp notes of the *neufchâtels,* the *troyes,* and

[13] Ibid., 213.

the *mont-d'ors*. Then the smells went wild and became completely jumbled, the *port-salut*, *limbourg*, géromé, *marolles*, *livarot*, and *pont-l'évèque* combining into a great explosion of smells. The stench rose and spread, no longer a collection of individual smells, but a huge, sickening mixture.[14]

At which point Zola adds, quite unnecessarily: "Il semblait que c'étaient les paroles mauvaises de Mme. Lecœur and de Mlle. Saget qui puaient si fort." ("It seemed for a moment that it was the vile words of Madame Lecoeur and Mademoiselle Saget that had produced this dreadful odour.")

But what is also crucial here is not so much the allegorical function of the cheeses as their veritable liberation from meaning in all their excess, so that they come to know their own temporality, in which even the silences of the body play their role. For such an onslaught of sensation seems to require something like a zero degree, what Deleuze calls a surface of inscription, in order to sound its specific note and make its effect. In Zola that role will often be played by cleanliness:

Mais, au déjeuner, il fut repris par la douceur fondante de Lisa. Elle lui reparla de la place d'inspecteur à la marée, sans trop insister, comme d'une chose qui méritait réflexion. Il l'écoutait, l'assiette pleine, gagné malgré lui par la propreté dévote de la salle à manger; la natte mettait une mollesse sous ses pieds; les luisants de la suspension de cuivre, le jaune tendre du papier peint et du chêne clair des meubles, le pénétraient d'un sentiment d'honnêteté dans le bien-être, qui troublait ses idées du faux et du vrai. (I, 681–2)

When he returned for lunch, however, he was quite won over by Lisa's soft, gentle manner. She again spoke to him about the fish inspector's job, without undue insistence but as something that deserved consideration. As he listened to her, his plate piled high, he was affected, in spite of himself, by the prim comfort of his surroundings. The matting beneath his feet seemed very soft; the glitter of the brass hanging lamp, the yellow tint of the wallpaper, and the bright oak of the furniture filled him with a sense of appreciation for a life of well-being, which confused his notions of right and wrong.[15]

Yet this last, unexpected development warns us that in sensation as well, there can be no ultimate "zero degree" in perception, that all such seemingly pure data are still haunted by a meaning of some kind, which is to say an ideological connotation (to use Barthes' early word)—here the way in which cleanliness and neatness is somehow

[14] Ibid., 215–6.

[15] Ibid., 77.

infiltrated by *bien-être*, which is to say by bourgeois comfort, itself then libidinally personified in Lisa. At this point cleanliness, the surface against which all the content-laden sense-data of smells and visual stimuli, sounds and fabrics, are perceived, itself is secretly subverted by the surface of inscription of a bourgeois value or ideal. We will see the process again later on, it constitutes the mastering of affect by ideology, of the body open to sensations by the bourgeois ideology of the body and its training, manners, stances and practice.

Yet the very multiplication of these sensory onslaughts raises the question of their succession in time, where the gradual autonomization of the various affects slowly begins to release them from their relationship to plot as such and suggest whole new forms of temporal organization. I have implied that in Octave's climactic new fashion exhibit, the oases of white which the visitors happen upon can no longer really compete with each other: even though the clients' movements are organized according to a trajectory through the now enlarged and immense department store, reaching some climactic altar to whiteness itself, yet at the same time confronting them as so many musical variations on a single theme. Yet these climaxes must not be allowed to become symbolic either, and the residual meanings of white (innocence, virginity and so forth) are precisely what are to be drowned out by the new sensibility (Zola's prophetic vision of addictive consumerism, with strong sexual overtones and undertones).

Thus, in order to maintain a focus on this strange and disembodied element which is affect, we must vigilantly separate it from its material supports or bearers, whether in the body (where it becomes simply one more sensory impression or perception) or the psyche (where it is reduced to the merely subjective). What happens, indeed, is that the registration of affect must become allegorical of itself, and designate its own detached and floating structure within itself. Here, for example, is Jean Macquart looking out across the Paris of the Commune, set on fire by extremists (the infamous *pétroleuses* of anti-Commune propaganda[16]):

Jean, plein d'angoisse, se retourna vers Paris. À cette fin si claire d'un beau dimanche, le soleil oblique, au ras de l'horizon, éclairait la ville immense d'une ardente lueur rouge. On aurait dit un soleil de sang, sur une mer sans borne. Les vitres des milliers de fenêtres braisillaient, comme attisées sous des soufflets

[16] See for example Paul Lidsky, *Les écrivains contre la Commune*, Paris: La Decouverte, 2011.

invisibles; les toitures s'embrasaient, telles que des lits de charbons; les pans de murailles jaunes, les hauts monuments, couleur de rouille, flambaient avec les pétillements de brusques feux de fagots, dans l'air du soir. Et n'était-ce pas la gerbe finale, le gigantesque bouquet de pourpre, Paris entier brûlant ainsi qu'une fascine géante, une antique forêt sèche, s'envolant au ciel d'un coup, en un vol de flammèches et d'étincelles? Les incendies continuaient, de grosses fumées rousses montaient toujours, on entendait une rumeur énorme, peut-être les derniers râles des fusillés, à la caserne Lobau, peut-être la joie des femmes et le rire des enfants, dînant dehors après l'heureuse promenade, assis aux portes des marchands de vin. Des maisons et des édifices saccagés, des rues éventrées, de tant de ruines et de tant de souffrances, la vie grondait encore, au milieu du flamboiement de ce royal coucher d'astre, dans lequel Paris achevait de se consumer en braise. (V, 911)

Filled with dread, Jean turned back towards Paris. At the end of a beautiful Sunday, on such a fine, clear evening, the slanting rays of the sun, skimming the horizon, lit up the immense city with a burning, red light. It looked like a bloody sun over a boundless sea. The panes of the thousands of windows glowed as if fanned by invisible bellows; the rooftops blazed like beds of hot coals; yellow walls and the tall, rust-coloured monuments were licked by flames like flickering fires in the evening air. Wasn't this the final burst of sparks, the enormous, purple bouquet, the whole of Paris burning like some giant sacrificial fire, a dry, ancient forest suddenly flaming sky-high, in a sparkling, crackling whirl? The fires burned on, there were still great clouds of russet-coloured smoke rising up into the air, and a huge noise could be heard, perhaps the last cries of those being shot in the Lobau barracks, or perhaps the joy of the women and the laughter of children, as they dined in the open air after their happy stroll, sitting outside the cafés. From the devastated houses and buildings, from the gutted streets, from all the ruins and all the suffering, life was stirring once more, amidst the flames cast by this regal sunset, by whose light the fire of Paris was finally burning itself out.[17]

We must carefully distinguish the levels of a passage of this kind, beginning with the awkward reminiscences of Balzac ("*on aurait dit*"), who ever invited us, with his rhetorical questions, to compare his scenes with this or that great painting of the past, as much theatrically to stage a tableau as to elicit our admiration. Such echoes are part and parcel of a whole rhetoric in Zola, which one might term a rhetoric of things (like the famous "*leçon de choses*") systematically arranged to produce that theatrical effect against which Michael Fried has famously warned us. In particular here, on the last page of this immense war novel *La débâcle* (1892) (which Henry James admired

[17] *The Debacle*, trans. Elinor Dorday, Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000, 513–4.

despite himself[18]), the descriptive amplification is allegorical of the ending of the novel as well, the final climactic recapitulation of a whole thematics of fire which informs the narrative as a whole (and the Rougon-Macquart more generally). This practice of the Wagnerian leitmotiv (to which Thomas Mann compares it), as well as of the variational system of the impressionists (Manet's haystacks and cathedrals at all hours of the day in every weather), then makes for a somewhat different temporality, one of repetition and of memory, than the stock melodramatic one. Meanwhile, the symbolic value of the passage, as a vision of the end of the world itself, can be corroborated by a wild outburst of the then Bakuninite Wagner himself (in the revolution of 1848), who claimed that nothing can be changed in music or in anything else until Paris is burnt to the ground![19] Semantically, however, this apocalypse announces a more local and historical one, namely the end of the Second Empire; and on this level the various appearances of fire are in hindsight revealed to be so many grim prolepses of this real holocaust, as in the festivities of the *Exposition Universelle* of 1867:

Ce fut le 1er avril que l'Exposition Universelle de 1867 ouvrit, au milieu de fêtes, avec un éclat triomphal. La grande saison de l'empire commençait, cette saison de gala suprême, qui allait faire de Paris l'auberge du monde, une auberge pavoisée, pleine de musiques et de chants, où l'on mangeait, où l'on forniquait dans toutes les chambres. Jamais règne, à son apogée, n'avait convoqué les nations à une si colossale ripaille. Vers les Tuileries flamboyantes, dans une apothéose de féerie, le

[18] Henry James, *Literary Criticism, Volume II: European Writers; Prefaces to the New York Edition*, New York: Library of America, 1984, 898: "I recall the effect [*La débacle*] then produced on me as a really luxurious act of submission. It was early in the summer; I was in an old Italian town; the heat was oppressive, and one could but recline, in the lightest garments, in a great dim room and give one's self up. I like to think of the conditions and the emotion, which melt for me together into the memory I fear to imperil. I remember that in the glow of my admiration there was not a reserve I had ever made that I was not ready to take back. As an application of the author's system and his supreme faculty, as a triumph of what these things could do for him, how could such a performance be surpassed? The long, complex, horrific, pathetic battle, embraced, mastered, with every crash of its squadrons, every pulse of its thunder and blood resolved for us, by reflection, by communication from two of the humblest and obscurest of the military units, into immediate vision and contact, into deep human thrills of terror and pity—this bristling centre of the book was a piece of 'doing' (to come back to our word) as could only shut our mouths."

[19] Ernest Newman, *The Life of Richard Wagner, Vol. IV*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1947, 272, notes.

long défilé des empereurs, des rois et des princes, se mettait en marche, des quatre coins de la terre. (V, 228)

It was on April 1, in the midst of *fêtes*, that the Universal Exhibition of 1867 was opened with triumphal splendor. The Empire's great "season" was beginning, that supreme gala season which was to turn Paris into the hostelry of the entire world—a hostelry gay with bunting, song, and music, where there was feasting and love-making in every room. Never had a *régime* at the zenith of its power convoked the nations to such a colossal spree. From the four corners of the earth a long procession of emperors, kings, and princes started on the march towards the Tuileries, which were all ablaze like some palace in the crowning scene of an extravaganza.[20]

But all these levels need to be distinguished from the invisible materiality of light itself, as a medium that is allegorical of the affect for which it is the recording device, a transparency capable at certain moments of thickening into an object in its own right, with its own kind of visibility, as with certain hours of the day in Los Angeles or Jerusalem, where light can be perceived in and for itself, and where the surfaces of the buildings are best observed as sheets whose pores and rugosities capture the new element and hold it for a moment, or those receding planes where pebbles and their determinate shadows serve as sundials, as in a Dali painting.

What we have not yet pointed out in this passage is the way in which the materiality of light is here secured by its redoubling: within the clear light of the afternoon sun there is enveloped the light of the city burning day and night, a different kind of light about which one cannot tell which one reflects the other, deepening it or revealing its secret essence. This is a very different contrast than that of light and dark ("in the gloom the gold gathers the light against it"), in which difference is represented by means of identity itself. It is the abstract form we need to glimpse here, as in a candle still burning in the dawn light:

Le jour naissait, une aube d'une pureté délicieuse, au fond du grand ciel clair, lavé par l'orage. Aucun nuage n'en tachait plus le pâle azur, teinté de rose. Tout le gai réveil de la campagne mouillée entrait par la fenêtre, tandis que les bougies, qui achevaient de se consumer, pâlissaient dans la clarté croissante. (V, 1024)

Day was breaking, a dawn of a delicious purety at the heart of the great clear sky washed clean by the storm. Not a cloud stained its pale rosy azure. A gay

[20] *Money*, trans. Ernest A. Vizetelly, New York: Mondial, 2007, 185.

awakening of the dampened countryside everywhere came through the window, while the candles, melting and dwindling away, grew pale in the ever stronger light.[21]

The light within the light—each one derealizing the other, dawn turning the candle flame yellow and garish, the flame itself making of dawn light something watery and unhealthy—betray one of the deepest secrets of affect. Its inner mirroring and division, an internal pli, prepares it as a vehicle for the investment of affect insofar as it mimics scale and differentiation, save that, as in this case and unlike music, it is a lateral dissociation, an opposition of the thing to itself which produces it as a thing at the same time that it effaces itself. A strange evanescent dissonance within unison as such, rather than the slippage of chromaticism: Baudelaire was onto this property, which, however, "Correspondences" theorizes in terms of harmony, as I noted. And yet he practices it: "*doux comme les hautbois*," where all the sweetness is in the sour oboe itself; "a green so delicious it hurts," in which the pleasure is in the pain itself.

Yet there is another reason why the representation of intensities (which is also their expression) should require the reduplication or redoubling we have been describing here: and this has to do with the separation of the affect from its physical bearer. For if it becomes indistinguishable from physiological experiences or reactions, it vanishes as an autonomous entity and folds back into explanatory habits and stereotypes in which subjectivity or the physiology of the body suffice as some ultimate ground or cause. Here however the mind is obliged to move back and forth between alternate mirror-images, neither of which is satisfactory in itself—candle or sun, sun or fire?—in such a way that the effect transcends either. The relevant example here might be the magic potions in Wagner—the love portion in Act I of *Tristan*, and the potion of oblivion in *Götterdämmerung*: there has indeed been much idle debate about the dramatic necessity of these contrivances—are they necessary, are we really to believe in their efficacy, or are they not rather distracting tricks the dramatist might better have avoided?

In short, do they really cause anything? If Tristan and Isolde fall in love because of the potion, then the whole love-death ethos of the work as a whole is nothing but an illusion; while Siegfried's forgetfulness of Brünnhilde comes before us as a mere plot mechanism

[21] *Doctor Pascal* (1893), trans. mine.

like the deus ex machina or the *reitender Bote*. If the famous pair are in love already, then the love potion is superfluous; as for Siegfried, Carl Dahlhaus has ingeniously observed that he lives in any case in the present and is unlikely to remember anything anyway, even so significant a moment in his own past.[22] The physical potion, or cause, is then equally unnecessary, particularly since we are no longer in the fairy-tale world of the preceding opera, *Siegfried*. Yet I think these discussions can be seen to be misplaced if they are taken to be examples of the affective redoubling we have been trying to theorize here: the physical brew makes it impossible for the spectator to take these developments as purely subjective ones, that happen to this or that individual or are subject to the psychological vagaries of this or that contingent identity. On the other hand, the very autonomous force of the passion in *Tristan* (and the radical innocence that makes of Siegfried again a blank slate and a perpetual present) differentiate both these effects from the material causes, all the while endowing them with a kind of materiality that grounds their autonomy in the first place.

But as idealists from Berkeley to Bergson have persuasively demonstrated, the idea of matter is itself an idealistic fiction (not a good concept, as Deleuze might say!); so that our various experiences of affect (above) are in a paradoxical way more materialistic than the concept of matter itself, along with that of the body. It may therefore be useful, in pursuing this chiasmus, to turn to a different category on which affect inscribes itself, one equally as invisible as light but which Kant took to be a formal precondition of perception (like time) and in no way a feature of the latter's content. This is the category of space, whose possible intensities we may explore in the following passage, a characteristic moment in *L'argent*, in which the novelist describes the pitiful enclosed back garden of an impecunious mother and daughter, last remnants of an aristocratic lineage, who wash their own clothes in secret and eat scraps behind closed doors, in order to avoid public disgrace:

> Tous les jours, lorsqu'il ne pleuvait pas, elles apparaissaient ainsi, l'une derrière l'autre, elles descendaient le perron, faisaient le tour de l'étroite pelouse centrale, sans échanger une parole. Il n'y avait que des bordures de lierre, les fleurs n'auraient pas poussé, ou peut-être auraient-elles coûté trop cher. Et cette promenade lente, sans doute une simple promenade de santé, par ces deux femmes si pâles, sous ces arbres centenaires qui avaient vu tant de fêtes et que les bourgeoises maisons du voisinage étouffaient, prenait une mélancolique douleur, comme si elles eussent promené le deuil des vieilles choses mortes. (IV, 68–9)
>
> Every day, when it did not rain, they thus appeared, one behind the other, and, descending the steps, made the circuit of the little central grass-plot, without exchanging a word. The path was merely edged with ivy; flowers would not have grown in such a spot, or perhaps they would have cost too dear. And the slow promenade—undoubtedly a simple constitutional—made by those two pale women, under the centenarian trees which long ago had witnessed so many festivities, and which the neighbouring *bourgeois* houses were now stifling, was suggestive of a melancholy grief, as though they had been performing some mourning ceremony for old, dead things.[23]

Phenomenology has taught us to read such descriptions, not as projections, but rather as accounts of our being-in-the-world; and older ideologies, such as vitalism, would have been as keenly sensitive to all the symptoms of this palpable stunting and disfiguration of the life force as Zola himself. Nor is the suggestion that nature has become a prison some mere rhetorical and metaphorical flourish, it is realized in the object world itself, as at the bottom of a well, a metaphor which has exchanged its vehicle for its tenor, becoming tangibly accessible to the starved senses. It is instructive once again to compare this garden with the miserable salon of Balzac, where the social meaning has become the meaning we read on the room's qualities. Here, the garden does not testify to the indigent situation of its inhabitants, nor to their pre-history or their pitiful strategems (about which Zola tells us): rather, it offers a phenomenologically meaningful state of the world in and of itself, which can only be juxtaposed with and compared to the other vivid spaces explored in this novel with which it coexists—filthy hovels, seedy houses of assignation, the Bourse itself from dawn to dusk, indeed Paris itself lit up in that festival of the Universal Exposition we have already witnessed.

This variety of phenomenological spaces, however, suggests another interpretation of affect which demands comment in passing, and that is the unique status of melancholia among the various kinds of affects presumed or implied by the definition. Is it really so that melancholia is the very prototype of affect, as so much contemporary theory seems to believe; or better still that affect is simply another word for

[22] Carl Dahlhaus, *Richard Wagner's Music Dramas*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1979, 98.

[23] *Money*, op. cit., 51, translation modified.

melancholia as such? I tend to want to include the properties of a given national language in the account of these general representational or registrational possibilities. Indeed, the unique sociability of French lends its expressions for feelings a collective resonance that many other languages, such as English, lack. This is true of gestures and commonplaces as well, but I here limit myself to affect alone, where it can be affirmed that the word "*triste*" has graver musical and phenomenological connotations which only Milton and T. S. Eliot have been able to convey with the English word "sad." The French word opens up that whole landscape of desolation which is the very allegory of melancholy itself, and which tolls throughout Flaubert and Baudelaire. It is enough to recall Flaubert's remark about the writing of that great historical construction which is *Salammbô*:

> Peu de gens devineront combien il a fallu être triste pour ressusciter Carthage.
>
> Few will guess how melancholy one had to be to want to bring Carthage back to life.[24]

Yet before we thus absolutize melancholia, we must remember and take into account not only the doctrine of intensities (which actually, as we shall see, turns out to find some expression and grounding in Zola's pseudoscientific theories), but also the notion of a chromatic scale, according to which affect would be no more exempt than anything else from the semiotic play of oppositions in general. Affect is somehow felt in isolation from all relationship, and yet at the same time it remains defined by its opposites, the nobler melancholy standing nonetheless in an imperceptible relationship with its more vulgar opposite number, euphoria.

But the content of these scales is of course itself variable, and even if melancholia remains a kind of constant, in Flaubert, in *Tristan*, in Munch, in Gogol, its opposite is very different in all these cases, as also in Zola, where an expected excess of orgiastic excitement is far less authentic than the peacefulness of "*bonheur*."

[24] Famously quoted by Walter Benjamin in his description of the experience of historical defeat, in a passage worth quoting more extensively: "The nature of this sadness stands out more clearly if one asks with whom the adherents of historicism actually empathize. The answer is inevitable: with the victor ... There is no document of civilization which is not at the same time a document of barbarism." "Theses on the Philosophy of History," in *Illuminations*, trans. Harry Zohn, New York: Schocken, 1969, 256.

Indeed, the very generalization of affect beyond specific named feelings, such as melancholy or joy, affords an unexpected answer to that reproach of the pathetic fallacy formulated by the New Critics. We have suggested above that this diagnosis in reality takes as its object emotion rather than affect, and in a technical sense, one may even claim that the literary representation of affect develops precisely as a response to this objection, and has as its function to replace the opposition between mind and body which such older representations presupposed. For the latter very much posit a Cartesian dualism, of the type which Heideggerian phenomenology took as its fundamental philosophical target; it is thus not only the various modernisms that sought to overcome it. Is this to attribute to Zola a secret or nascent modernism? That would certainly incapacitate the theory of realism we are trying to outline here; but only at the price of disregarding the other temporal axis of Zola's novels, namely the system of the récit and of chronological temporality and narrative in which a nascent phenomenological consciousness is embedded and with which the latter stands in productive tension.

A revealing indication of this tension is to be found in the ambiguity of the narrative structure, which, famously in Zola, posits the dead weight of the past and of heredity on his immensely varied cast of characters: their various hereditary taints, vices, obsessions and the like are so many scars and marks that testify to the tenacious survival of the past-present-future system of the récit and would seem to corroborate Sartre's warnings about its "*passéiste*" determinism with a vengeance.

Yet Zola's pseudo-science vindicates the theory of affect in another, unexpected way. To be sure, we have already observed that Zola's great plan for a series of novels socially and politically critical of the regime in which he lived was suddenly ratified by the collapse of the system at the moment in which he began to write. Now suddenly a dictatorial government, set in place by the coup d'état which was to have been the subject of the first novel of that series, is dramatically ended in such a way that the series itself knows closure and can now have something like a happy ending. The year in which Zola publishes the beginning of the Rougon-Macquart series will thus turn out to open the setting for the last novel of that series, written some twenty-five years later (at the same time that it furnishes the Empire's most dramatic moment in the military defeat which would be the subject of its penultimate work). History, then, is a more than suspiciously

complicit collaborator in the project, whose closure (known to the novelist in advance) allows all its episodes to be "historical" in the literary sense, and the object of a diagnostic already confirmed in advance.

The series, to be sure, abounds in vitalistic rhetoric and the invocation of life, nowhere quite so strident as in Jean's premonition of a rebirth of France at the end of *La débacle*, and the birth of the nameless child at the end of the final work, *Le docteur Pascal* (1893). But these appeals to the future are decorative against the background of the narrative preterite and the social and personal diseases of the period in question, now forever ended. The power of this temporal frame may well explain the weaknesses of Zola's novelistic projects after the end of the Rougon-Macquart, where little is left of a once oppressive and fateful History save the pious hope and the energetic optimism.

But it is important to rate that the great series has two distinct endings and not merely the political one, the disaster of a rotten power structure. For there is still heredity and tainted blood, corruption and obsession rooted in bodily unsoundness. Society and heredity are still the long shadows cast by the mind-body problem; nor does Zola dispose of a pineal gland whereby to hypothesize their causal interactions. Indeed, if anything, the political protagonists of this unhappy family are far more energetic than their kinsmen in a more grotesque private sphere.

The series will therefore require a second happy ending on that level as well, and it comes in the form of Dr. Pascal's medical solution to the problem of bad blood in the eponymous final volume. Nothing seems to grow old-fashioned more swiftly than the cures and diseases of yesteryear, which turn into superstition in the blink of the eye. This is indeed also the fate of Zola's medical speculation (if it ever had scientific verisimilitude for its contemporary readers in the first place). And it seems, in fact, to have been based on a far more ancient and tenacious superstition, namely the magical idea that like cures like. Thus, if you suffer from heart or kidney weakness, the ingestion of those organs will be helpful, and Yeats' monkey glands are only the most notorious recent avatar of this remedial conviction, which may well extend back into the earliest cannibalisms. The modern hypodermic needle, however, confers a certain technical cast to the practice, along with the concept of the scientific experiment, with its records and charts (Dr. Pascal's laboriously assembled

files play a significant role in this novel, where they constitute a kind of shadow rivalry to Zola's novel series itself, Pascal constituting no doubt a more fundamental creative alter ego of the novelist than the fraternal Cezanne-figure of the painter in the earlier works).

But we have not yet come to Pascal's great discovery. Suffering himself from all kinds of physical ills (to which Zola, a confirmed hypochondriac, will no doubt add the obsessive pursuit of a cure, not unlike his own monumental perseverance in a novelistic task worthy of the most impossible ambitions of the modernists themselves), he has begun to inject himself, at which point an accident reveals the truth. It is the injection as such, and not its contents, which give the patient relief: "a simple mechanical effect," remarks Pascal modestly (V, 1084): "j'ai été frappé dernièrement par ce singulier résultat que les piqûres faites avec de l'eau pure étaient presque aussi efficaces... Le liquide injecté n'importe donc pas, il n'y a donc là qu'une action simplement mécanique." (V, 1177).[25] Pascal concludes that the effect of the injection does not lie in its action on the individual organ, but rather its restoration of the equilibrium of all the organs together and the restoration of the totality of relationships within the organism itself.

It is worth reiterating this finding in the words of the medical authority from whom Zola/Pascal derived it (a certain Dr. Chéron): "all hypodermic injections produce the same effects, whatever the liquid introduced beneath the skin... The difference bears only on the greater or lesser intensity of the reaction produced."[26]

It is revealing and suggestive to come upon the word "intensity" in this context, for it confirms our intuition that Pascal's discovery is in fact an allegory of the very theory of affective narrative we have been outlining here, and that Zola's series thus culminates in a kind of autoreferential consciousness of its own representational procedures. Think of it this way: Chéron/Pascal's discovery is that of the supersession of content by form as such. Hitherto, each blighted destiny was analogous to a diseased organ, and in the case of the organs, they are treated by an injection of their own substance, distinct from the substances of all the other organs of the body. The temptation is to imagine a multiplicity of diseases and corresponding organs, just as

[25] "I was recently struck by an unusual result, namely that injections of pure water were just as efficacious ... The nature of the injected liquid is thus unimportant, the action is a purely mechanical one."

[26] See Henri Mitterand's note, V, 1654.

Zola imagined himself to be documenting the multiplicity of destinies played out on his immense social stage, each destiny with a specific and unique content of its own. But this is substantialist thinking rather than a concept of relationality. For just as all these human destinies are linked together by heredity into a single family, so also their multiplicity is mere appearance: they are in fact all the same, whether they look like obsession, neurosis, psychosis, morbid ambition, erotomania, the lust for power and so forth.

They differ, not in substance, but in intensity: they thereby correspond, not to the specific types of the named emotions, but to the purely formal play of affect. What look like the unique individual destinies of so many récits are in fact now transformed into the abstract fever-chart of affects and intensities rising and falling; and Zola's narratives are what happen to individuals and their destinies when their récits fall into the force-field of affect and submit to its dynamic, in a situation in which the two forces, the two temporalities, are still for one last moment more or less equal in their power and influence.

Here, then, we witness the autoreferentiality of the representation of affect, as a form becomes its own content and Zola's requirement of a scientific "motivation of the device" becomes in effect a formal account of his representation. The doctrine of intensity thereby becomes an aesthetic ideology for this novelistic practice, which in retrospect looks less like an account of the destiny of anthropomorphic characters than it does an immense collection of distinct phenomenological spaces. Meanwhile, his people begin to exist as bodies first and foremost, despite their identification as characters in the older sense. Zola's novels are immense accumulations of bodies in movement and intersection across such spaces, from rooms to streets, from the fetid darkness of *L'assommoir* and the underground nightmare of *Germinal* to the rococo excesses of the most vulgar Second Empire salons: bodies in full effervescence, paralysis or decay, landscapes increasingly thronged with new buildings and the wreckage of older ones, the phenomenology of History and histories caught in a dynamic of toxic expansion. Here, then, affect has become a symptomatology reinforcing the great realist project at the very moment it imperils it.

Yet this is only one way in which affect appropriates a whole narrative apparatus and colonizes it; there are as many varieties of realism as there are features and potentialities in the phenomenon of affect itself, and in the tensions between the two temporalities with which

we began. We will take several more in review in the following chapters, beginning with an affective temporality quite different from Zola's stubborn single-mindedness, which some may feel more illustrative of *Stimmung* than of affect, I mean the changeable narrative temporality of Leo Tolstoy.

Chapter IV

Tolstoy, or, Distraction

Tolstoy presents a unique practice of affect which shapes his work and which is in fact responsible for many of the features stereotypically associated with it (the multitude of characters, the seemingly "natural" rhythm of the narrative, etc.). To discuss this under the heading of psychology, however, and to abound in wonderment about Tolstoy's feeling for the psychological states and reactions of his characters, no longer seems to me particularly helpful, especially since the contemporary exploration of affect has undermined many of the standard categories and concepts which organized the system of this "discipline" (as traditional as Aristotle). The theoretical interest in affect, indeed, was prepared by the structuralist/poststructuralist "death of the subject," which is to say the problematization of notions of personal identity and of centralized consciousness. In what follows, I will proceed on the basis of a radical dissociation of these two phenomena—identity and consciousness—and indeed the theory of realism I am presenting here is itself organized around that dissociation; identity as a social mark of a relatively objective kind, which specifies individual history and indeed temporal chronology; consciousness as an impersonal field which can probably no longer even be described in terms of subjectivity. But more of that as it informs a reading of Tolstoy later on.

The literary historians invoke *War and Peace* in terms of an opposition between "domesticity" and the political, an opposition which itself has its own deeper relationship to the debates between slavophiles and Westernizers in this period but which is misleading to the degree to which the positions of the slavophiles are themselves political, as well as presupposing too simple a transfer of ideological positions onto aesthetic ones and their translation into issues of representation. On the other hand, perhaps this distinction between

the ideological and the aesthetic can also clarify the matter: for what Tolstoy's opposition to the political consists in is very precisely a loathing for what we might today call left intellectuals, that is to say, "liberals" with their pamphlets and pronouncements, their polemics and above all their practice of literature as a vehicle for political opinion. Chernyshevsky's name is the obvious tag here, as the aesthetic embodiment of all the political things Tolstoy (and after him, Nabokov) finds viscerally intolerable.

It is a position that we can identify in many of our own anti-political contemporaries, whom we should therefore describe less as reactionaries than as aesthetes. But this is the point I want to come to, namely that his hostility to political literature and a political aesthetic does not necessarily mark Tolstoy out as a slavophile in that parallel opposition which is the ideological one. (Indeed, later on in life he will discover himself to be as passionately anti-aesthetic as he is anti-political.) We must therefore be cautious in dealing with Tolstoy's anti-liberalism; another century has taught us that anti-liberalism can be as radical as it is conservative: and also that liberal modernizers, in the light of the construction of capitalism, need not automatically be judged progressive, although their enemies are often reactionary. Eikhenbaum in any case proposes that we shift the terms of the debate, and call Tolstoy's position an anti-historical one,[1] and this seems a good deal more promising as an approach to what is supposed to be the greatest historical novel ever written. Meanwhile, it is appropriate to recall Dostoyevsky's characterization of Tolstoy's work as "landowner's literature"; and Lenin's of Tolstoy's identification with the peasantry; descriptions which shift the discussion helpfully from nationalism to class.[2]

But now we need to step back from these general questions and take a closer look at affect in Tolstoy and at the kind of narrative texture it develops. It will be useful, in this regard, to examine chapter

[1] Boris Eikhenbaum, *Tolstoi in the Sixties*, trans. Duffield White, Ann Arbor: Ardis, 1982, 135: "The historical novel had been chosen precisely with the intention of being anti-historical." The companion volumes, *The Young Tolstoi* (Ardis, 1972), and *Tolstoi in the Seventies* (Ardis, 1982), are equally valuable and among the most insightful literary as well as biographical studies of Tolstoy ever written. I discuss the position of *War and Peace* in the tradition of the historical novel in "The Historical Novel Today" below.

[2] V. I. Lenin, "Leo Tolstoy as the Mirror of the Russian Revolution," in *Collected Works*, Vol. XV, Moscow: Progress, 1973. See also Pierre Macherey's discussion of this essay in his *Pour une théorie de la production littéraire*, Paris: Maspéro, 1966.

6 of Book II of *War and Peace*, an episode in the 1807 war in which Prince Andrew brings the news of Kutuzov's victory over Mortier (to be sure, a relatively minor encounter with a division that had become separated from the main body of Napoleon's army) to the Austrian court.[3] Still, coming after the Austrian disaster at Ulm, this minor Russian victory is most welcome indeed and seemingly auspicious.

Prince Andrew, in the coach carrying him to Brno, is elated ("excited but not weary"), not least at the prospect of a promotion his choice as messenger implies: yet he understands this primarily through a fantasy about the reception of other people ("picturing pleasantly to himself the impression his news of a victory would create"). These two features—the reward and the attention to "society" and its reactions—are in Tolstoy always ominous signs.

We do not yet reach the level of affect when we identify, in Tolstoy, a kind of moralizing system of the psychological which is itself a kind of ideology and which serves to evaluate his characters' feelings and to explain their dynamics. In this ideology, to be sure, we touch Tolstoy's Rousseauian convictions about the evils, not so much of society as of "civilized" society: "*le monde*," drawing rooms, gossip, manners, deceitful politeness and etiquette, reputation, in short, of everything Rousseau himself associated with Paris and with "progress." And over against this, what exactly? The natural, the deeper self, true feeling—and as opposed to society, the family, which is to say the extended family or clan, in other words what has already been ideologically identified as "domesticity," an ideology very much in keeping with the literature of landlords and landowners (and finally rather different from that of Rousseau's agonizing solitude).

But we must hold firmly to the premise that this Tolstoyan system of psychology, this *Weltanschauung* or view of human nature, is itself an ideology, an ideological construction and by no means the mere expression of that human nature nor of Tolstoy's own psychological makeup either. Clearly overdetermined by class (and by generational and historical realities, by social change as much as intellectual fashion and debate), this level of the text—Tolstoy's explanations of Prince Andrew's feelings—is far from being the ultimate one and itself demands explanation.

[3] I here use the Norton Critical Edition of *War and Peace*, in the translation of Louise and Aylmer Maude, ed. G. Gibian (New York: Norton, 1966), page number references given in the text. Book II, chapter 6 is to be found on 158–62.

But it certainly explains why Tolstoy would qualify Prince Andrew's elation in the following charged terms: "enjoying the feelings of a man who has at length begun to attain a long-desired happiness." The text pointedly avoids saying that Prince Andrew is "happy": and this is the moment to pause on this term as well, and to specify the unique meaning it has for Tolstoy and its symptomatic value as a sign wherever it appears in the novel.

It is here worth citing Boris Eikhenbaum in some detail:

> Tolstoy's key word, his catchword, is "happiness." He writes in his diary on March 3, 1863: "Whoever is happy is right!" This is a quote from the final draft of *The Cossacks*, from Olenin's letter to his friend: "My goal—I am happy; this is my goal. Whoever is happy is right! ... I am good and I am right because happiness is absolutely obvious. A person who is happy knows it more certainly than 2 x 2 = 4." These aphorisms do not simply express abstraction: Tolstoy directed them at his times, as a demonstration against its slogans. When spoken by Tolstoy, the very word "happiness" assumes a special meaning, as the opposition of "natural" human right to all other "civil" rights and obligations, as the juxtaposition of feeling to mind and of nature to civilization. In an 1863 diary entry we read: "Everything that people do they do according to the demands of their natures. And the mind only fabricates for each action its imaginary causes, which for one person may be called convictions or faith and for the people (acting collectively in history) is called *idea*. This is one of the oldest and most harmful fallacies." This is a formulation of Tolstoy's long-standing animosity toward "convictions" and ideas, or, in other words, toward the new Russian intelligentsia, toward the whole movement of the sixties.[4]

Happiness is in Tolstoy a moment and in that sense necessarily an event; but we may also say that it is somehow outside of time, although not "eternal" in the way in which non-temporal states (such as mathematical truths) are thought to be by those temporal beings which we are. What it is outside of can better be identified as the temporal continuum, the structure of past-present-future: and therefore the kind of temporal present it occupies (always referring here to the Tolstoyan system) would demand a different word than the one in current use, which is inextricable from its chronological structure. But there is no such word; and its absence opens up a space for representational innovation at the same time that it condemns theoretical presentation to the inescapable attempt to distinguish two homonyms which have nothing to do with each other. (To say that

[4] Eikhenbaum, *Tolstoi in the Sixties*, 105.

these two types of "present" make for existential problems as well is an understatement.[5])

"Happiness" as a peculiar kind of Tolstoyan present designates a reconciliation with life and the world, with being, by definition an ephemeral one, or as Heidegger says, one that withdraws in the same moment that it appears. It has preconditions but cannot be caused; and clearly, it cannot be the aim or end of any action or project, save in the sense in which Prince Andrew imagines "the feelings of a man who has at length begun to attain a long-desired happiness," that is to say, who imagines it from the outside or in the future, and also substitutes for it some other kind of satisfaction.

Its centrality and its uniqueness for Tolstoy can be judged comparatively by juxtaposing the words available for this state in the other languages ("*bonheur*" is in French a far more specific physiological condition, the English word is diluted with some general bourgeois sense of comfort, etc.); but also by comparison with its relative functional value in comparable texts. In Stendhal, for example, a writer so close to Tolstoy in this and other ways, what prevents happiness in Tolstoy—ambition, vanity, society and the opinions of other people—also blasts and denatures a comparable spontaneity ("la pensée du privilège avait desséché cette plante toujours si la délicate qu'on nomme le bonheur"[6]); but one cannot say that the deeper authentic self in Stendhal is Tolstoyan, absorbed as it is in love and longing. (And we might also add that the very framework of a single protagonist, like Julien or Fabrice, limits the perspective on such psychic processes to a single type of content and thereby a single interpretation. "Freeing himself from the initial constraint of a central personality," as Eikenbaum puts it of Tolstoy,[7] attaining what the same critic calls "mass parallelism" or what we might term "cross-cutting," thus allows for a greater variety of such processes and indeed tends to depersonalize the process itself. It should also be added that the tyranny of "point of view" is thus something Tolstoy was thereby able to do away with, rather than, as Henry James thought, a goal he was too primitive to attain.[8])

[5] See above, Chapter I.

[6] *La Chartreuse de Parme*, Paris: Cluny, 1950, 165.

[7] Eikhenbaum, *The Young Tolstoi*, 84.

[8] This is probably a central reason for James's famous characterization of the great Russian novels (and others) as "large, loose, baggy monsters": "Art of the Novel," in Henry James, *Literary Criticism, Volume II: European Writers; Prefaces to the New York Edition*, New York: Library of America, 1984, 84 (Preface to *The Tragic Muse*).

In Proust, also, the will is a powerful force for alienation and sterility, but what it alienates (creativity) is specified in still different ways from the two writers we have mentioned. Probably the Kantian aesthetic which posits a suspension of interest or practical intent has its kinship as well (indeed, as Lukács has shown, the most influential models of social and political disalienation are already anticipated in this aesthetic[9]); but to see Tolstoy from this perspective (however correct and interesting it might be) would classify his ethico-psychological referent as an essentially contemplative and aesthetic one and thereby return it to those worldly judgements and systems from which he represented it as an escape.

It therefore seems best to me to think of such crucial moments of Tolstoyan happiness as an affect, one which he constructs as the fundamental one, and which is ideologically privileged in his thought, but which for us must be grasped as a compositional element, to return to the perspective of the Russian Formalists. Indeed, Eikhenbaum lays great stress (as did the contemporary Russian critics) on the episodic structure of *War and Peace*, that is to say, on the way in which an attention to affect denarrativizes and dechronologizes the action ostensibly being narrated. This is of course preeminently the structure we have sought to disengage here: a tension between plot and scene, between the chronological continuum and the eternal affective present which, realized in quite distinct ratios in the various great realists, nonetheless marks out the space in which realism emerges and subsists, until one of the two antithetical forces finally outweighs the other and assures its disintegration.

But let us now return to Prince Andrew; he is generous with some wounded soldiers on the way to the town; arriving at dark "he felt even more vigorous and alert," recalling the details of the battle and imagining the questions that might be put to him (161). But now, approaching the door of the minister's room, his "joyous feeling was considerably weakened" by the formality of the adjutant. "He felt offended" at being asked to wait; "his fertile mind instantly suggested to him a point of view which gave him a right to despise the adjutant." The minister receives him with the artificiality "of a man who is continually receiving many petitions one after another," shaken

[9] See his essay on Schiller, "Zur Asthetik Schillers," in *Probleme der Asthetik*, Berlin: Lucterhand, 1969.

only by news of the death of the Austrian general Schmidt. And the chapter concludes thus: "When Prince Andrew left the palace he felt that all the interest and happiness the victory had afforded him had now been left in the indifferent hands of the Minister of War and the polite adjutant." It is a well-nigh Lacanian conclusion: now that this affect has been entrusted to the other, it will no longer be necessary for me to feel it.

Clearly enough, except for moving Prince Andrew to the army headquarters in Brünn, this chapter, which confirms the Russian's suspicion that the Austrians are less interested in a Russian victory than they are by the Austrian defeat at Ulm, has very little plot significance. Nothing much happens to Prince Andrew; we have already encountered the prickliness of his character in earlier chapters, so nothing further is supplied on that score; all that transpires here is a gamut of affects, of which the chapter is a kind of fever chart or musical partition. Nor is this series of moods of any great importance to the portrayal of Prince Andrew as a character, although we may well be surprised at the degree to which his fantasies are driven by ambition, startled indeed at the degree to which his reverie is taken up with fantasies and day-dreams in the first place (from the outside he seemed altogether a graver and more dignified personage). In the long run, however, all Tolstoy's characters are thus contaminated by the other in one way or another, and this particular inner life will not uniquely distinguish any one individual figure, will not in other words serve as a psychological distinguishing trait or individualizing characteristic. It is the character's name and place in the action or the chronological continuum which will hold each gamut of affects together (or, if you prefer, serve as their pretext and container).

Finally, we will not appreciate the operation of form here if we reduce Andrew's reactions to some common-sense psychological stereotype, such as disappointment at his bureaucratic reception, or exhaustion of his eagerness and excitement in advance by the exercise of fantasy. Not the content of these moods but rather their rapid succession is the mark of Tolstoy's peculiar sensibility.

What is thus crucial here is the changeability of the affects, which in turn provides the registering apparatus, the legibility of the various states. For they can only be read distinctly against a constant variation: a single affective tonality, like a single note or pedal-point held without variation, becomes in the long run indistinct or imperceptible against its background, or else slowly takes on a pathological

dimension which demands motivation in its own right. But what the chapter in question demonstrates is the ceaseless variability from elation to hostility, from sympathy to generosity and then to suspicion, and finally to disappointment and indifference: there are in principle in Tolstoy no moments of the narrative which lack their dimension of affect, to the point at which one is tempted to say that these movements and variations are themselves the narrative. The chapter is the story of the affects themselves, and not of external events or plot developments; and vivid as the characters are, the very density of the affects themselves secures an impersonal existence for them, above and beyond those individual subjects which were once the protagonists of realism.

It is this changeability and variability, this capacity for sensitivity (in the sense of irritation) and for sudden bouts of ennui, for passing enthusiasms, obsessions, drops in enthusiasm and niveau—it is all this which seems to have been characterized by Tolstoy himself as a "stream of consciousness" (a term better reserved for this play of affect than for the verbal monologues which of course Tolstoy also pioneered before the official modernists). It is not a return of the old-fashioned biographical criticism to say so; for the journals and testimony that confirm the diagnosis are yet another set of texts to be added to the literary ones. But the evidence is abundant, not least owing to his incessant self-examinations, which seem to have been provoked by his own bewilderment at this temperament, which he understood to be something a little more significant than a mere character trait.

At this point it will perhaps be worthwhile to compare a stronger, "modernist" form of such changeability in the music of Gustav Mahler, in which at first we seem to confront a simple opposition between agitation and its soothing, its calming down. But the calming down will itself depend on the variety of forms the agitation can take—noble-heroic, neurotic, anticipatory, anxiety-laden, foreboding, euphoric, rhetorically operatic, declamatory, sublime or pathologically sublime, morbid, manic, jolly, frivolous-ceremonial, etc. Each of these must be momentarily subdued according to its dynamic, while the mode of calm—always ephemeral—will itself be dissolved into a new kind of agitation. Temporality is agitation in its very nature, it cannot remain in a state of tranquility for long, the latter always evolves back into a new form of agitation. This is why the whole does not simply resolve itself into a series of variations, why the sonata form does not explain this dynamic, whose fundamental formal question is how

this restless alternation from high to low, from somber to ethereal, can possibly be concluded, and on what key. (And as for Mahler, it will be remembered that Freud's diagnosis of him was based on the composer's childhood memory of turmoil at the parents' violent quarrels, when, shutting himself in the bathroom, at one and the same time he heard the inescapable sound of the hurdy-gurdy in the streets.)

We may then juxtapose two evaluations of this libidinal restlessness at its two extremes: one a Utopian anticipation and the other a clinical diagnosis. At the one pole lies Fourier's inclusion of the "butterfly passion" as one of the three fundamental drives in human nature, whose harmonious combination is bound to ground the institutions of a Utopian society. The butterfly passion is the incessant movement from one interest to another, from one activity to another. Let Roland Barthes be the spokesperson for the Utopian dimensions and uses of this existential distraction:

> La Variante (ou Alternante, ou Papillonne) est un besoin de variété périodique (changer d'occupation, de plaisir, toutes les deux heures); c'est, si l'on veut, la disposition du sujet qui n'investit pas d'une façon stable dans le «bon objet»: passion dont la figure mythique serait don Juan: individus qui changent sans cesse de métiers, de manies, d'amours, de désirs, dragueurs impénitents, infidèles, renégats, sujets à «humeurs», etc.: passion méprisée en Civilisation, mais que Fourier place très haut: c'est elle qui permet de parcourir rapidement beaucoup de passions à la fois, et telle une main agile sur un clavier multiple, de faire vibrer *harmonieusement* (c'est le cas de le dire) la grande âme intégrale; agent de transition universelle, elle anime ce genre de bonheur attribué aux sybarites parisiens, *l'art de vivre si bien et si vite, la variété et l'enchaînement des plaisirs*, la rapidité du mouvement (on se rappelle que pour Fourier le mode de vie de la classe possédante est le modèle même du bonheur).
>
> The Variating (or Alternating or Butterfly) is a need for periodic variety (changing occupation or pleasure every two hours); we might say that it is the disposition of the subject who does not devote himself to the "good object" in a stable manner: a passion whose mythical prototype is Don Juan: individuals who constantly change occupation, manias, affections, desires, "cruisers" who are incorrigible, unfaithful, renegade, subject to "moods," etc.: a passion disdained in Civilization, but one Fourier places very high: the one that permits ranging through many passions at once, and like an agile hand on a multiple keyboard, creating an *harmonious* (appropriately put) vibration throughout the integral soul; an agent of universal transition, it animates that type of happiness that is attributed to Parisian sybarites, *the art of living well and fast, the variety and interconnection of pleasures*, rapidity of movement (we recall that for Fourier the mode of life of the possessing class is the very model of happiness).[10]

The clinical version of all this is that syndrome named Attention Deficit Disorder, whose symptoms are well-known[11]: it is by now well-known that naming a cluster of features of this kind is also a construction of the disease itself, which is to say, the bringing into being of a new disease that did not really exist as such before the name. In an age of self-diagnosis, the name then functions to alert the subject to further introspection and as a consequence to the "discovery" of new and richer evidence for its existence. The semiotics of the process, and the critique of the medical clinic they imply, are of relevance only insofar as they complete a dialectical union of opposites with the productivity of a subject unaware of the reifying medical designation, and particularly of the negative symptomatology of frequent bouts of boredom and loss of interest with which such a subject's "stream of consciousness" is bound to have been plagued.

In the case of Tolstoy, it is not merely the self-doubt and the evanescence of whole projects and commitments (the abandonment of the early works in mid-course, the very turn away from literature itself) which are noteworthy, but also features that might at first glance seem to be positive: in particular the multiplicity of characters in *War and Peace* and also the brevity of its multiple chapters and episodes (we may well wish to recall here Nietzsche's extraordinary characterization of Wagner as a miniaturist[12]). Are these not also marks of Tolstoy's

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[10] Roland Barthes, *Sade, Fourier, Loyola*, Paris: Seuil, 1980, 106–7. The English translation is by R. Miller, Berkeley: University of California Press, 1989, 101.

[11] As seems customary in the DSM, fourteen characteristics form the criteria for an official clinical diagnosis, any eight of which suffice. I quote three that seem characteristic: "stimuli extraneous to the task at hand are easily distracting; holding attention to a single task or play activity is difficult; frequently will hop from one activity to another, without completing the first." Thom Hartmann, *Attention Deficit Disorder: A Different Perception*, Grass Valley, CA: Underwood Books, 1997, 11. The reader may not find it so difficult to square this description with a "characteristic" portrait of Prince Andrew: "As he said this Prince Andrew was less than ever like that Bolkónski who had lolled in Anna Pávlovna's easy chairs and with half-closed eyes had uttered French phrases between his teeth. Every muscle of his thin face was now quivering with nervous excitement; his eyes, in which the fire of life had seemed extinguished, now flashed with brilliant light. It was evident that the more lifeless he seemed at ordinary times, the more impassioned he became in these moments of almost morbid irritation." (28)

[12] Friedrich Nietzsche, *The Case of Wagner*, chapter 7, *Basic Writings*, New York:

mercurial temperament, of his need for constant distraction and variation, of his impatience with this or that individual character and his subsequent interest in passing to another one, for the moment more absorbing? The multiplicity of characters, then, the variety of the fictive personages (and their situations), which attract Tolstoy's attention in turn—this as it were external variety is the exact correlative of his subjective mood swings, or what I have called the continuum of affect we have been able to observe within the individual scenes and attributed to each of the individual characters. It is also, of course, the opposite pole of that structural tension we are here in the process of attributing to realism itself and to its construction. The expansion and deployment of affect in a range of moods is what makes for the presence of the scene, the timeless or existential consciousness at one with its showing (and its reading); while the multiplicity of the characters—each one with a name and a potential story or destiny, and all somehow defined and marked by that truly external destiny which is war and History itself—these make up the telling as such, the time continuum, the past-present-future of the *fabula* (as opposed to the *syujet*) of the realist novel.

But now we need to invent some closer approach to Tolstoy's production of his characters. (That he is on his way to a thoroughgoing effacement of protagonists in favor of secondary characters as such is also a premise of this account, as we shall see in the next chapter. But it is the *how* of this transformation which now requires its own theorization.) We may first observe the physical externality of his characterization, even in the ostensible protagonists, Pierre and Natasha, (or perhaps I should say especially in them). We should first recall Eikhenbaum's analysis of the Tolstoyan portrait as a virtually fixed form (inherited from the eighteenth century, another source of kinship with Stendhal): it requires the treatment of three topics—psychology, speech and appearance[13]—in a rather mechanical procedure which would seem to have little in common with the introspective registration of affect on which we have commented in the discussion of Prince Andrew. All these attributes of a character would seem to objectify such a figure and indeed to reify it to the point where we would expect it to remain fixed in externality and radically distinct from any first or third "point of view." To be sure, Lacan's

Modern Library, 2000, 627.

[13] Eikhenbaum, *The Young Tolstoi*, 37.

"*trait unaire*" (Dolokhov's blue eyes, Natasha's childish gleefulness, the "little princess"' upper lip, Pierre's spectacles—Nikolai and Boris are in this respect far less distinct) can furnish one bridge between the physiognomic description and the inner state. But for the most part these descriptions seem merely to underscore the arbitrariness of the corporeal; or better still, its contingency. The trick to description is, of course, not to lock the character so firmly into any single physiognomy that the reader might be unable or unwilling to accept. The acceptance will generally stand or fall on the way in which the external description harmonizes with the "inner" character of the personage in what is essentially a symbolic or metaphoric process.

(Meanwhile, it seems possible that what stunned Tolstoy about the writing of his young peasant pupils was the unerring precision with which the children isolated a single "trait"—physiological or linguistic, a habit or a sudden interjection—to characterize their imaginary figures.)[14]

Yet Jakobson famously observed that Tolstoy had moved from a metaphoric to a metonymic mode of character portrayal; while Eikhenbaum insists on the essential fragmentation of Tolstoy's portraits: commenting on a remark of the novelist ("it seems to me that to actually describe a man is impossible"), Eikhenbaum suggests that for Tolstoy "a portrait should be composed of separate, concrete features, and not of general attributes ... the bearers of separate human qualities and features which are for the most part combined paradoxically."[15] This is why Tolstoy gradually develops a method whereby he shows his character thinking or saying one thing, while physically absorbed in doing something else, something unrelated (brushing his uniform, lighting a match, watching a dog in the yard). We must consequently posit the Tolstoyan character not as some organic unity, but as a heterogeneity, a mosaic of fragments and differences held together by a body and a name (that is to say, a past, a unique destiny, a specific story).[16]

[14] "Should we teach the peasant children to write, or should they teach us?" Leo Tolstoy, in Alan Pinch and Michael Armstrong, eds., *Tolstoy on Education*, London: Athlone Press, 1982, 222–70.

[15] Eikhenbaum, *The Young Tolstoi*, 34.

[16] It is regrettable that so knowledgeable and subtly intuitive a critic of Tolstoy as Boris Eikhenbaum, on whom any student of Tolstoy must rely as massively as I have here, should have found the character of Natasha improbable and unconvincing as she passes from adolescence to the matronliness of the epilogue. (In addition, he calls "the domestic, family part of Tolstoy's novel ... principled, tendentious," *Tolstoi in the*

The strong form of such a presentation (which is also a whole novelistic conception of the phenomenology of individual identity) appears when these unrelated traits enter into opposition with each other: this seems to be what Eikhenbaum means by his expression "combined paradoxically," but which I will be so bold as to call a contradiction. Here is Prince Vassili calling his two sons fools ("a quiet one" and "an active one"): "He said this smiling in a way more unnatural and animated than usual, so that the wrinkles round his mouth very clearly revealed something unexpectedly coarse and unpleasant."[17] And here is one of the sons in question: "Le charmant Hippolyte was surprising by his extraordinary resemblance to his beautiful sister, but yet more by the fact that in spite of this resemblance he was exceedingly ugly."[18]

But this does not yet get us to the heart of Tolstoy's relationship to his characters and in particular to their multiplicity, which almost, but not quite, effaces the very category of protagonicity as such, to the distress of many of its early readers; others simply thought many of the characters were trivial and uninteresting—unworthy of the novelist's attention. It is to that attention that we must now turn, remembering that from another perspective it was precisely Tolstoy's moody loss of attention to this or that character which made for the rapid crosscutting from one to the other (what Eikhenbaum calls "parallelism") in the first place.

I will describe this novelistic attention as a kind of "narcissism of the other," which momentarily fulfills the commandment to "treat thy neighbor as thyself." The healthy self (but we need not enter on the long tradition for which it is the health and vitality of Tolstoy which is extolled all above all[19]) necessarily includes a "healthy" dose

Sixties, 149). Here the biographical method leads him astray, since he finds different models concealed under each of these stages, whose unexpected transformations Proust will later foreground as one of his fundamental themes and effects. Yet these characterological changes over time reveal the same phenomenon of dissonance to be found in individual scenes, and betray the deeper impersonality Tolstoy has discovered beneath the surface variability of character, temperament and indeed mood and affect.

17 *War and Peace*, 6.

18 Ibid., 12.

19 See especially Thomas Mann, "Dostoevsky—in Moderation," in *The Short Novels of Dostoevsky*, New York: Dial, 1945, vii: "the divine and the fortunate, the children of nature in their exalted simplicity and their exuberant healthfulness" (referring to Goethe and Tolstoy, whom he had contrasted with the debility and sickness of Nietzsche and Dostoyevsky in a earlier essay).

of narcissism which dictates the conferral of special privileges on itself (to the point of *mauvaise foi*), and which motivates a permanent fascination with all kinds of features of ourselves not necessarily fascinating or even attractive to other people. This is the conatus of the biological individual, what keeps it interested in life, in survival, in the satisfaction of its desires and even of its whims: Agamben's "bare life" appears at the moment in which this narcissism is extinguished and the organism survives itself.

I believe that Tolstoy's attention to his characters, his interest in them, can best be described as a kind of momentary transfer of narcissism to these external beings, whose vitality fascinates him for the briefest of periods, so that whether it is the youthful delight of Natasha or the cold vindictiveness of Dolokhov (this last unexpectedly entering into contradiction with his love for his mother and his family)—on each of these manifestations, as on so many others, Tolstoy's own narcissism warms itself for a moment. The description is not complete unless we specify repulsion as another form of this well-nigh carnal fascination: for antipathy or repugnance (very much also including indifference) are also modes in which the rapt mesmerization with the other can be expressed.

This is the sense in which there are no villains in Tolstoy (another feature of the great realists to be discussed later on): for categories of good and evil are, as we shall see, survivals of those melodramatic forms and stereotypes that realism must necessarily overcome. Even Napoleon, the supreme object of Tolstoy's censure in *War and Peace*, and perhaps the character who less than any other profits from Tolstoy's secret indulgences, is the object of a visceral loathing and not any disinterested Kantian moral judgement. Yet we must here add in a qualification: part of the negative judgement on Napoleon is a judgement on society and on its glamorization of him, a judgement on a collective hero-worship akin to vanity and social ambition on the individual level. And it is certain that the fascination with characters like Prince Vassili (whose social status and influence is as subject to judgement and disapproval as his more materialist schemes and ambitions) must necessarily be transmuted by that ideological and Rousseauian ideology of nature and of the condemnation of society and its artificiality which was one of Tolstoy's "philosophical" messages and motivations in writing *War and Peace*. Repulsion is thus a form of fascination like any other; and Tolstoy distinguishes himself from Stendhal by a novelistic practice in which, in the latter, characters

deadened by their identification with society and the social—characters distinguished by "*la sécheresse du coeur*"—are handled differently from protagonists who still retain a possibility of spontaneity and authenticity.

Perhaps a somewhat different model can be adduced for this peculiar dynamism: in *The Transmission of Affect*, Teresa Brennan finds telling evidence for her theme in an anecdote related by Montaigne in which an old man draws vitality from the mere presence of the young Montaigne, "feasting his senses on my flourishing state of health."[20] His conclusion—that the younger man would thereby "find his energy depleted"—is less relevant than the phenomenon itself, which suggests a kind of affective contagion, a glowing enlargement of affect well beyond the natural limits and boundaries of the individual subject, a kind of "transmission," to use Brennan's term, susceptible of modifying our current conceptions of intersubjectivity and indeed of subjectivity itself as some purely inward, private and psychological matter. This is, at any rate, the kind of reenergizing force I attribute to that relationship which is Tolstoy's fascination with his own characters.

That he himself is aware of it can then be documented by its return in the very content of the narrative as an affective phenomenon in its own right. Thus, for example, the first appearance of the "little princess" (Prince Andrew's wife Lise), whose radiating power is not merely to be attributed to sensual beauty (indeed the passage in question is preceded by the evocation of the "defect" of the *trait unaire* we have mentioned above):

> Everyone brightened at the sight of this pretty young woman, so soon to become a mother, so full of life and health, and carrying her burden so lightly. Old men and dull dispirited young ones who looked at her, after being in her company and talking to her a little while, felt as if they too were becoming, like her, full of life and health. All who talked to her, and at each word saw her bright smile and the constant gleam of her white teeth, thought that they were in a specially amiable mood that day.[21]

[20] Teresa Brennan, *The Transmission of Affect*, Ithaca: Cornell, 2004, 16; in the same way, perhaps, the ageing Goethe found renewal in the mere existence of the youthful, rebellious Byron, the path not taken.

[21] *War and Peace*, 8.

Thus we have come full circle, and from the homology between the affective continuum and the multiplicity of characters we return to the ways in which that multiplicity itself feeds the power of affect in both content and form, and in which both these developments enrich the scene of narrative consciousness and the destinies and continuities of past/present/future to the point of straining realism to its limits, to a threat of its ultimate dissolution, just as they strain the very limits of the individual subject itself and "personal identity."

Perhaps, indeed, in the light of what has been argued here, it might be time to invent a different way of reading Tolstoy, something more intimate to substitute (at least for a time) for the orchestral interludes of the epic with which he is stereotypically associated. But as a recorder of war, Tolstoy was perhaps more original in his late novella *Hadji Murad*, which deals with the guerrilla warfare he himself experienced in what is today Chechnya. As a modern war novel, *La débacle* is surely a greater accomplishment than *War and Peace*, the military parts of which in any case spring from Stendhal's Waterloo episode, something Tolstoy himself would readily admit.

It is when we come to affect, whether registered in solitude or in interpersonal relationships, that Tolstoy is surely unequaled. And perhaps, if it is true that La Rochefoucauld's maxims are in reality miniature novels, we might want to invert this "genre," not for purposes of literary classification, but for new models of singularity. At any rate, such notations[22] cannot but have their effects on older

[22] I cannot resist quoting a miniaturist evocation of affect in Natasha's attraction to Karagin (or better still, her feeling of his attraction to her): *War and Peace*, 624–25:

> "And do you know, Countess," he said, suddenly addressing her as an old, familiar acquaintance, "we are getting up a costume tournament, you ought to take part in it! It will be great fun! We shall all meet at the Karagins'! Please come! No! Really, eh?" said he.
>
> While saying this, he never removed his smiling eyes from her face, her neck, and her bare arms. Natasha knew for certain that he was enraptured by her. This pleased her, yet his presence made her feel constrained and oppressed. When she was not looking at him, she felt that he was looking at her shoulders, and she involuntarily caught his eye so that he should look into hers rather than this. But looking into his eyes she was frightened, realizing that there was not that barrier of modesty she had always felt between herself and other men. She did not know how it was that within five minutes she had come to feel herself terribly near to this man. When she turned away she feared he might seize her from behind by her bare arm and kiss her on the neck. They spoke of most ordinary things, yet she felt that they were closer to one another than she had ever been to any man. Natasha kept turning to Helene and to her father, as if asking what it all meant, but Helene was engaged in conversation with a general and did not answer her look, and her father's eyes said nothing but what they always said: "Having a good time? Well, I'm glad of it!"

categories of character and of narrated interaction; and it is now to one such body of work, as saturated with named characters as Tolstoy, yet characters as distinctive in their development and as full of consequences for the evolution of realism as such, that we now turn.

Chapter V

Pérez Galdós, or, the Waning of Protagonicity

If Zola is the Wagner of nineteenth-century realism (and George Eliot perhaps its Brahms), then Benito Pérez Galdós is its Shakespeare, or at least the Shakespeare of the late comedies and romances. The absence of Galdós from the conventional nineteenth-century list of the "great realists"—even one limited to Europe—is more than a crime, it is an error which seriously limits and deforms our picture of this discourse and its possibilities. Coming at the end of the tradition, he enjoyed the great good fortune of the historical conjuncture, not only arriving at the moment when everything remained to be said about the belatedly nascent bourgeois world of nineteenth-century Spain and of Madrid as the last great European metropolis; he also inherited fully developed all those novelistic innovations and instruments of representation which, since Balzac, a century of novelists had worked to perfection. In addition, an immense series of historical novels—the *Episodios nacionales*—is superadded to the prodigious *Novelas contemporaneos* which from the maturity of 1880 on rivalize with *La Comédie humaine* or the Rougon-Macquart.

Galdós's Madrid is as full of mystery as Balzac's Paris, and the former's receptivity is as open to all the levels of social life as it is to all the intellectual currents of the last decades of the century. Full of curiosity about servants and of sympathy with women of all classes (he was a life-long bachelor, one of those characteristic practioners of what Jean Borie once called "*la littérature des célibataires*"[1]), as exploratory of the lower depths as Dickens, as sympathetic to his ambitious young men but with more indulgence for the slackers than Balzac himself, as alert to the vibrations of civil war and political tension as Stendhal, as ironic as Thomas Mann, as gossipy as Proust, as familiar

[1] Jean Borie, *Le Célibataire français*, Paris: Le Saegittaire, 1976.

with the urban terrain and the streets of the city as Joyce, as prolific as Trollope, he felt the energizing influences of French naturalism and Russian spirituality as enlargements of his outsider's view (he came to Madrid from the Canary Islands) of the prosperity of bourgeois Spain, whose 1867 revolution avoided the convulsions of Italian or German reunification as well as the militant nationalisms of Eastern Europe, well before 1898 casts a grim shadow over Spanish destiny. Like Dostoyevsky, his vocation was awakened by a reading of *Eugénie Grandet*; he was the Spanish translator of *Pickwick Papers*, and later on, in his final blindness, became a senator for the nascent Socialist Party; nor is his worldly-wise moralizing without its distant family likeness to George Eliot's sententiousness.

My argument will turn on a rather different form of the tension between the two temporalities—between plot and consciousness, or telling and showing—than what we were able to perceive in the emergence of affect. Now it will be a matter of the character system as such, organized around the prodigious Balzacian "method" of the "*retour des personnages*," at the point at which Galdós (like Faulkner later on) realized that he had a whole novelistic world to administer, and not just one or two local episodes to record. Yet what I will show is that the effects of this serial organization in Galdós are quite different from the consequences in *La Comédie humaine*, where in principle even the most minor characters have the right to become protagonists of their own separate novels. Here in Galdós, on the contrary, we will witness what I will call a deterioration of protagonicity, a movement of the putative heroes and heroines to the background, whose foreground is increasingly occupied by minor or secondary characters whose stories (and "destinies") might once have been digressions but now colonize and appropriate the novel for themselves. Clearly any discussion of secondary characters will want to rely on one of the most important contributions to the study of the novel in recent years, namely Alex Woloch's *The One vs. the Many*;[2] in effect, I want to historicize his findings in what follows, and assert a historical trend in the relationship of these groups to each other, or in other words a structural modification of the character system which is necessarily an integral part of narrative as such (and which can also know individual reconfigurations at the hands of stylistically original novelists as well, as distinguished from the momentous structural trend I have in mind here).

[2] Alex Woloch, *The One vs. the Many*, Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2003.

But let's begin with a collection of the many: they are lodged in an enormous building near the very center of Madrid, a palace with 2800 rooms (Versailles only has 700), which houses the Queen, to be sure—Isabela II—but also offers private apartments and rooms for hangers-on of the court, ranging from the middle bourgeoisie to aristocratic and royal relatives of various conditions. This fascinating social space, although immensely larger and more various, might well have demanded comparison with Zola's apartment building in *Pot-Bouille*, save that here Galdós's line of sight will be trained on a single habitation alone: it is the suite of a rather scatter-brained woman who thinks she is distinguished and has a mania for consumption, especially clothes and expensive finery. She is married to an uptight bureaucrat with a hobby, who is extremely miserly, intent on avoiding not merely unnecessary expense but also, if possible, even the necessary kind: and yet the hobby is a curious, artisanal one, the weaving of pictures out of human hair (evidently a recognized artistic activity in the nineteenth century, about which one would be curious to learn more[3]—Galdós does not often insert such handicraft figures, allegorical or not, into his cast of characters). At any rate, this is an eccentricity of the type associated with the Great Detectives of the period; and it is characteristic of the distinguishing traits that mark secondary characters off from protagonists, reminding us of Woloch's extraordinary observation: "two existential states lie behind the two pervasive extremes of minorness within the nineteenth-century novel: the *worker* and the *eccentric*, the flat character who is reduced to a single functional use within the narrative, and the fragmentary character who plays a disruptive, oppositional role within the plot."[4] Bringas's thrift is functional, and required in order to bring the catastrophe of debt to a climax; his eccentricity however marks him as an individuality in his own right, but a constitutively minor individuality of no particular interest to us.

The Bringas wife, however (the novel is entitled *La de Bringas* [1884]), is for all intents and purposes the protagonist of this novel: through her point of view and her drama we are allowed to meet a steady stream of minor figures, from a complacent princess, through various friends and would-be yet curiously half-hearted suitors, along with the usual maids and clerks, arriving finally at the infamous usurer,

[3] See on this curious art form, which is the "hair picture" the translator's introduction to *That Bringas Woman*, trans. Catherine Jagoe, London: J. M. Dent, 1996, xxi–xxii.

[4] Woloch, *The One vs. The Many*, 25.

Torquemada, into whose hands she ultimately falls, and to whom, as we shall see, Galdós devoted no less than four novels in his own right. Throughout this increasingly desperate quest, we are subjected mercilessly to the inner monologue of this stupid woman, whom Galdós ventriloquizes with a wit that makes this intolerable stream of language delicious for the reader. It must be observed that, like all the great realists, Galdós is a great mimic, not only coining the unique accents of authentic dialogue, but also inventing the tonality in which the thoughts of his characters are to be noted, as in a musical score.

One of the features, indeed, that distinguishes Galdós (and many of the other late-nineteenth century novelists) from the novelizing pioneers of the early century is the sharpness, the spirit and wit, of their characters' dialogue. In part, clearly this results from the imperceptible shift in the reader's attention from the plot line to the immediacy of the characters' encounters with each other; but also from the attention to the sound and timbre of the spoken voice, reflected in the attempts to capture accent and dialect (as in early George Eliot), and that heightened value attached to the personal intonation as such, to the unique sound which is henceforth, in the realm of affect, the sound of the individual body. The transmission of information about plot development is no longer the principal function of the voice here, but rather its qualities in the present of time.

Plays are not prose, Gore Vidal once observed: the implication is that dialogue, to be sure not poetic in any bad or regressive sense, now has a substance and density of its own, distinct from the surrounding fabric of the prose context. Joyce meanwhile proudly and wistfully described the characters of *Ulysses* as "the last of the great talkers." Something of that is also involved in this promotion of speech and its registration: and in the case of Galdós it is clear—his characters are talkers par excellence, they love to talk, and not only to gossip, but to express themselves volubly on the occasion not merely of every feeling, but of every *acontecimiento*, which is to say that it is their speech that transforms every moment into an event. Nothing is too minor to pass without the exercise of fulsome opinion; and the delight of Galdós's novels is this inexhaustibility of the spoken word (even in inner monologue) called forth by the new primacy of affect in the realm of voices and their bodies.[5]

[5] It should be noted that in his old age Galdós wrote a number of "novels" (which cannot strictly be called plays) exclusively in dialogue.

But I hazard the guess that such mimicry essentially holds—in all the like-minded novelists with whom we have here to do—for minor characters rather than protagonists: the language of protagonists is the language of poetic drama or of tragedy, expressiveness which demands a stage and a public, as in Corneille or in opera: otherwise the reader's empathy and identification (whatever those are) is enough to motivate us to lose ourselves in the protagonist (if that is what we do). Their inner life must not be marked or personalized; they must not be allowed to become other to us or to be visible from the outside. It is our old friend the impersonal consciousness, the eternal present of an anonymous and purely formal awareness without content, that is required for them.

But in the world of secondary characters irony is back in place: the movement out of point of view to the observer of otherness and back, the paradoxical combination of outer and inner distance which brings the external judgement of the récit to bear on the internal experience of the temporal present. To be sure, the novel is generally a combination of both perspectives, and as such irony is always structurally possible (as most often in the *Bildungsroman*, where it plays on the naïveté of the inexperienced protagonist); but it is wrong to erect irony into the fundamental building block of the form as such, as Henry James tried to do. Yet the perspective seems to demand some further engagement on the part of the novelist, as Wayne Booth famously demonstrated—some ultimate judgement, which can range from savage to indulgent but which in Galdós takes the form of a permissiveness which can intensify into a glacial indifference, as the character who is its object inevitably destroys herself.

The point I have wanted to make here, but have only presupposed, is that in fact "the Bringas woman" is not a protagonist at all: she is preeminently a minor character who has unaccountably been allowed to become the center of a novel in her own right.[6] That novel is not a récit, but one might well imagine it as one, in the form of the gossip retailed by other characters in other novels of the series. Can we somehow allegorize the subject of such a narrative, and parlay debt, mindless consumerism and prodigality into obsession and punishment, as Balzac often did? In other words, can we endow a story like this with the kind of significance hitherto reserved for real protagonists, thereby also redeeming author and form as well, and restoring

[6] She also figures in the earlier novel *Tormento* (1884).

their dignity and status?[7] I suppose that such narrative exercises are receivable in the context of an enormous literary production, in which each stands as yet another virtuoso performance by its now famous maker. Yet under normal circumstances, this kind of reaction would make sense only when a lighter or more occasional product of this kind stands side by side with the truly central or major productions with which we compare it: the narrative masterpieces for which this episode can in a pinch be seen as a preparation and warming up. The problem is that there are no major novels in Galdós's immense corpus.

I'm aware that this is a scandalous thing to say, about one of the country's great classics (but there is always Cervantes, after all, whose ethos is of course as omnipresent in Galdós as in so much else of the Spanish tradition). Meanwhile, one risks the appearance of true ignorance, given the existence of *Fortunata y Jacinta*, Galdós's longest novel and for many his masterpiece; but as Stephen Gilman has observed (and he is everywhere acknowledged as one of the fundamental authorities on the subject), *Fortunata y Jacinta* is in fact not one novel but four[8]; which brings each down to the standard length of what one does not want to call a novella in Galdós's production. Still, as the very title suggests, this one certainly seems to have protagonists, and it will be in order for us to test our hypothesis against so monumental a text.

It is the story of a happy marriage, a "marriage made in heaven," as they say, which only faces two seemingly minor problems to overcome before it can fade into that non-narrative state Tolstoy's famous dictum seems to foretell. On the one hand, the perfect wife, Jacinta, cannot bear children; on the other, the perhaps less than perfect husband, Juanito, without being at all dissatisfied with his wife, also knows a second love—or perhaps it is better to call it *amour*—with a lower-class girl (Fortunata) who does in fact bear him a son. The novel will then, after many peripeties, be resolved with the predictable return to equilibrium achieved by a swap: Jacinta will receive Fortunata's child as her own, and Fortunata will become a kind of saint and go to heaven.

But is there any point in telling this immemorial story again, or rehearsing its now structuralist restoration of order? The fatal

[7] Does transforming it into a sociological example do so? On Rosalía's temperament as a cultural trait, see Maurice Vallis, *The Culture of Cursileria*, Durham: Duke University Press, 2003; I am indebted to Stephanie Sieburth for this reference.

[8] Stephen Gilman, *Galdós and the Art of the European Novel, 1867–1887*, Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1981.

encounter of the upper-class male with the lower-class female is to be sure always full of sociological promise: but Galdós's sympathy with women is omnipresent and dispenses him from the suspicion of patriarchal bias. What is more significant from the standpoint of plot construction is its gradual withdrawal from the conventional drama of the love triangle (or the novel of adultery). The only way, indeed, for the young Santa Cruz family to know any kind of story or récit is by way of the accident of barrenness; their marriage is quickly dispatched in the opening pages, and both recede, leaving the foreground to Jacinta and her milieu.

Meanwhile, these pages are crowded with minor characters of all kinds; numerous family acquaintances and schoolchums of Juanito, for example, the latter giving rise to any number of Galdósian novels in their own right, the former providing at least one stellar figure, the notable philanthropist and founder of a monumental hospice for fallen women, Guillermina; and later on, Jacinta's husband, the unfortunate Max, along with his aunt the usurer (and friend of Torquemada) and his brother the priest; Max's employer (he is a pharmacist); Fortunata's erstwhile partner in crime, the frightening Mauricia la dura, and her more respectable counselor, Feijoo; and many more, not excluding the narrator himself, who turns out to be yet another distant acquaintance of Juanito. The prestidigitation whereby the formerly "omniscient narrator" is transformed, by a touch of the magic wand, into yet another minor character (not unlike the one who appears for the first and last time on the first page of *Madame Bovary*)—nothing is more appropriately emblematic for our purposes here: Henry James—himself just such a minor character in real life, a listener and observer, a voyeur and a gossip, the eager recipient of hearsay and tall tales of all kinds (preferably usable ones!)—would have been indignant at being assigned so humiliating a position.

The reader will have suspected that we are moving towards a momentous assertion, namely that Fortunata is herself a minor character! In spite of the disproportionate attention she receives in this novel (about which on the contrary it might equally be asserted that she herself becomes the protagonist, consigning both Jacinta and Juanito to minor roles in the wings), there cling to her the marks and scars of the protagonist of the récit: we are interested in the development of her consciousness (as so many moralizing interpreters have been), but from the outside, as one of Guillermina's cases, and not

as the true center of consciousness. The "other woman" is always a secondary character: in the novel of adultery it is the wife (guilty or offended) who seizes protagonicity from the husband, the male lead. She is able to combine the récit-like destiny of the victim with the central consciousness of the primary figure, thereby (for a time) winning that possibility of authenticity on which we have already commented. But the object of the husband's infidelity (or of her own) is a mere pretext, and the extraordinary attention she receives here has no ready-made paradigm to house it, so that indeed Fortunata's story passes through any number of generic discontinuities on her way to beatitude (yet another narrative paradigm!).

Can we speak, in so illustrious a case as this, of narrative digression? What is clear is that Galdós is easily distracted by his minor characters, in that very much like Tolstoy; and we are tempted to apply to him the same characterization we offered of the Russian novelist —that of a "narcissism of the other"—save that Galdós is already so selfless as to problematize the idea of narcissism itself. Perhaps it might be better to wonder whether he does not seize a chance to live himself in each of his characters, major or minor, and thereby, like "*el amigo Manso*," to populate a somehow posthumous life.

At any rate, as far as the formal developments are concerned, some obvious sociological contexts can be mentioned. We can for example float the hypothesis that Galdós's content, the social raw material at his disposal, strikes an uneasy compromise between the atomized individualism of more fully bourgeois societies with their nuclear families, and the more archaic traces of the older feudal clans and castes.

The population of Galdós's novels is indeed organized into households, an ambiguous category which does not preserve the blood jealousies of the older clans but yet is not technically purely familial either, in the sense of some later extended family. Rather, these households very much include servants,[9] often the first approach of bourgeois novelists to the lower classes; they include the other families who circulate in their orbit, sometimes somewhat subordinate in their gravity to the central family, in the case of *Fortunata y Jacinta*, the Santa Cruz family (and this distribution of social weight includes the partnership of the two families of husband and wife); they touch on the less often seen "connections," of a political and a social type;

[9] See Bruce Robbins, *The Servant's Hand*, Durham: Duke University Press, 1993.

and finally on those characters I will categorize under the rubric of the "friend of the family," someone who is not related, yet sups at the table, performs all manner of favors and services, and often operates, with his handyman's know-how, as the fixer on a social rather than an odd-jobs level. So it is that at the very outset of this immense journey which is *Fortunata y Jacinta*, immediately after a summary account of the hero and his generational friends, the students, and then a sketch of the family itself, suddenly a single figure absorbs our attention in a brilliant and detailed portrait: it is Estupiñá, the "friend of the family." Introduced obliquely, we quickly receive his whole life-story and then, at the opening of a new chapter, are treated to this from the novelist: "When I personally met this illustrious child of Madrid he was on the brink of his seventieth birthday, but he carried his years very well."[10]

> El llamado Estupiñá debía de ser indispensable en todas las tertulias de tiendas, porque cuando no iba a la de Arnáiz todo se volvía preguntas: «Y Plácido, ¿qué es de él?» Cuando entraba le recibían con exclamaciones de alegría, pues con su sola presencia animaba la conversación. En 1871 conocí a este hombre, que fundaba su vanidad en *haber visto toda la historia de España* en el presente siglo. Había venido al mundo en 1803, y se llamaba hermano de fecha de Mesonero Romanos, por haber nacido, como éste, el 19 de julio del citado año. Una sola frase suya probará su inmenso saber en esta historia viva que se aprende con los ojos: «Vi a José I como le estoy viendo a usted ahora.» Y parecía que se relamía de gusto cuando le preguntaban; «¿Vio usted al duque de Angulema, a lord Wellington?...» «Pues ya lo creo.» Su contestación era siempre la misma: «Como le estoy viendo a usted.» Hasta llegaba a incomodarse cuando se le interrogaba en tono dubitativo. «¡Que si vi entrar a María Cristina!... Hombre, si eso es de ayer...» Para completar su erudition ocular, hablaba del *aspecto que presentaba Madrid* el 1 de septiembre de 1840 como si fuera cosa de la semana pasada. Había visto morir a Canterac; ajusticiar a Merino, «nada menos que sobre el propio patíbulo», por ser él hermano de la Paz y Caridad; había visto matar a Chico...; precisamente ver no, pero oyó los tiritos, hallándose en la calle de las Velas; había visto a Fernando VII el 7 de julio cuando salió al balcón a decir a los milicianos que *sacudieran* a los de la Guardia; había visto a Rodil y al sargento García arengando desde otro balcón, el año 36; había visto a O'Donnell y Espartero abrazándose; a Espartero solo, saludando al pueblo; a O'Donnell solo; todo eso en un balcón; y por fin, en un balcón había visto también en fecha cercana a otro personaje diciendo a gritos que se habían acabado los Reyes. La historia que Estupiñá sabía estaba escrita en los balcones.

[10] Benito Pérez Galdós, *Fortunata y Jacinta*, trans. Agnes Marcy Gullon, London: Penguin, 1986, 40.